He is chiefly employed in exorcising devils who have taken possession of any person. He invariably carries with him a copy of the Qúrán, and when he enters the room where the possessed person is confined, he begins by reciting a few appropriate texts. At the sound of these words the devil usually steals away; but if he is a powerful one, and disregards the words of the sacred volume, the book itself is exhibited, and he is warned to leave. If this too fails, a few sentences are scribbled on a piece of paper, and this is burned beneath the patient's nose. This, the Ojhá asserts, is an infallible cure.

A demoniac is known by the following signs: The eyeballs are bloodshot, the tongue protrudes, pain is not felt; if the person is weak unusual strength is displayed, and several men are required to hold him. He amuses himself in wandering about, muttering, and breaking all articles within his reach.

The belief in persons possessed by evil spirits is universal, and even educated Muhammadans do not dispute the possibility of such an occurrence. The delirium which often accompanies the hot stage of ague, especially in the case of girls, is always referred by the women of the Zanánah to the presence of a demon, and it is often difficult for a doctor to prevent their summoning a wizard to exorcise the sufferer. Hysteria, with its sudden seizure and strange involuntary convulsions, is a disorder in treating which the Ojhá acquires undeserved credit; but as long as the belief in demoniac possession lasts, the race of wizards will flourish.

When demons of ordinary power are in possession of a person, a favourite remedy is burning turmeric, mustard seeds, and chillies, and making the fumes be inhaled.

Whatever method be adopted to expel the devil, his return is easily prevented if a particular sentence of the Qúrán be worn as a talisman around the neck.

Other wizards draw magic circles around the demoniac, while incantations are read.

Most of these men pretend to have "Mantras," or spells to ward off or cure diseases. During difficult labour, a sentence of the Qúrán bound on the woman, or a draught of water into which an incantation has been blown, are certain to hasten the birth of the child. Another belief prevalent among all classes in Bengal, is the disastrous effect of the evil eye. Every mother spits on her child, or smears a little lamp-black on the child's face before allowing her darling to go out of doors. The wizards however, claim, by means of charms, to permanently protect children.

An Ojhá never marries, and he cannot allow anyone to cook his food. A person so familiar with the power of darkness must

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always be on his guard, lest some mischievous imp take possession of him.

Allied to the Ojhá is the Jhára-wáláh, or Jhárná-phúnknáwáláh. Hindustánís are greater proficients in this imposture than the inhabitants of Bengal. Like the mesmerist, the Jhárawáláh chiefly practices passes, or gentle shampooing, and while doing so he must not breathe. A deep inspiration is taken, and, while the rubbing lasts, he repeats an incantation to Kálí, the patroness of these wizards, and then blows on the limb that is under manipulation. A twig of the sacred Ním tree is often used in making passes. This order of wizards are chiefly employed in curing rheumatic or neuralgic pains; but, in 1872, they were in great demand to cure the obstinate muscular pains following an attack of Dengue fever.

At the end of the seventeeth century the miraculous cures performed by Mr. Greatrix,[1] the stroker, created much sensation in England. By stroking the seat of pain he could remove it at once, and effect a permanent cure. His practice was identical with that of the strokers of India of the present day.

PANÍR-WÁLAH.

Dacca has long been famous for its cheeses, although none are made in its neighbourhood. In the city, however, reside all the export traders, or Kárígars, who are either Hindus or Muhammadans.

The finest cheeses come from Sarrail in Silhet, and from Joan-Sháhí and Susang-Durgápúr, in Mymensingh, the pure water of the rivers in these districts being believed to bestow a peculiar richness on the milk.

Two kinds of cheese are made, the first, called "Dalama," or "Gáea," is prepared with cows' milk, and must be eaten when fresh; the other, "Panír," or "Bhainsa," is made of buffaloes' milk.

Hindus will not manufacture or eat cheese, because it is a heinous offence to add salt to milk; while to mix rennet with it is a deadly sin. Cheese making is therefore a Mussulmán trade, the maker proceeding as follows: he takes milk, curdles it with rennet (Máya), and, after allowing it to stand for some time, pours off the water. The curd being then cut into pieces, is placed in small baskets, and left to dry. During the first day the baskets are turned several times, and, after twenty-four hours,

[1] "Philosophical Transactions," vol. xxi, page 429.

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three or four holes are made in the cheese, into which salt is put, and the outside rubbed with brine. On the third day the cheese is turned over; on the fourth more salt is added, and it is then considered fit for use.

PANKHÁ-WÁLÁH.

Fans are always manufactured by Muhammadans residing in outlying suburbs of the city, who are generally cultivators.

They make the large hand fan (Aráni) with the leaves of the Palmyra palm, a smaller sort being made with the same leaf, and either left plain (sáda), or ornamented with gaudy colours and talc, hence its name of "Abraqí."

Occasionally Hindu Bairágís, who earn an uncertain livelihood by hawking execrable pictures of their gods, also make hand pankhás for sale.

PAṬWA.

This is the common name in Eastern Bengal for the Muhammadan who makes tapes and braids. In Hindustan, however, he is called by the Arabic names, Iláqaband, or Bisáṭí.

The Paṭwas are intelligent workmen and skilful dyers, who, in the days of the English factories, were famous for the manufacture of a lac dye, known as "*Jhúrí.*"[1] The lac was first washed, mixed in a solution with Sajjí-maṭí, an impure alkali, then heated, powdered Lodh bark (*Symplocos racemosa*) being added, and after boiling a short time poured into a copper vessel and allowed to cool.

At the present day they impart a fixed golden colour to silk by straining lime and fuller's earth, and boiling them with "*Kamúlá*" (*Rottleria tinctoria*); silk steeped in this, then washed and dried, acquires the above colour. Silk dipped in a solution of alum, and macerated in water in which chips of Jack-tree bark have been boiled, becomes yellow, and if afterwards immersed in indigo water, prepared by the Nílgar, it changes to a green colour.

The Paṭwa makes the Kardhaní, or waist string, worn by natives of all ranks and religions, which consists of coloured cotton string. He also manufactures tassels (Jhabbá) for caps,

[1] "Indian Repertory," vol. ii, 579.

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paijáma strings, nets, fringes, and silken purses; and stringing beads he makes silk borders for bracelets, armlets, and charms. In his shop are also procured the "*Baddhí*," or sash, worn during the Muharram, and the "*Shamsa*," or silken rosette, that adorns the gaudy wrappers of rich Muhammadans.

The skilled Paṭwas, who are generally addressed as Kárígar, form a small community, occupying not more than twenty-five houses in the city of Dacca.

QALA'Í-GAR.

Muhammadans are the only natives who use copper vessels requiring tinning, the Hindus using either iron, brass, stone, or earthern cooking vessels. The furbishing trade is a busy one, there being at least twenty-five families in Dacca living by it.

The Qala'ígar prepares at his home a paste consisting of sal ammoniac boiled in water, in the proportion of one part to three. The copper vessel being first scoured with Jháma, or burnt brick, the paste is applied with a scrap of cotton, while with a heated iron the tin (qala'í) is coated over the inside and again rubbed with the paste.

Villagers usually bring their vessels with them to the city, but in the cold season the Qala'ígar makes a circuit through the interior, finding plenty of work.

RAFÚ-GAR.

Last century, it is said, that from five to six hundred Rafú-gars, or darners, found employment in the different European factories in and around Dacca, but now their number does not exceed a hundred and fifty. They have always been esteemed one of the most respectable classes of Muhammadans, their chief bearing the honorary title of "Mihtar Jí." Formerly, they never intermarried out of their own circle, but now, through poverty, are obliged to be less particular. The following curious custom is observed:—They instruct only the sons and grandsons of the male line in the mysteries of their handicraft, declining to teach their daughters' children; but so long as marriages were confined to their own clique this practice could have had little meaning. In former days an expert Rafú-gar earned from ten to twelve rupees a month; the less expert about eight. Their occupation

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was to examine the webs of muslin, and extract any threads that were broken, replacing them by new ones. This operation was called "Chunná," to pick, or choose. The Rafú-gar was a confirmed opium smoker, his skill being most striking when under the influence of that drug. The female Rafú-gar is often as dexterous as her husband, but she generally works at embroidery. Formerly the hemmer (Maghzí) was distinct from the darner, but now the Rafú-gar is reduced to hem as well as darn.

Closely connected with the darner was the "Purza-gar," generally a woman, who cut the threads connecting the flowers on Jamadáni muslins, and arranged them on the reverse side of the cloth.

RAKHWAL

Is a Muhammadan cowherd hired by citizens, who keep milch cows, to take the cattle to the jungle daily, and bring them back in the evening. He receives two anas a month for each animal. In the villages Chandáls are the usual cowherds; but in families where there is either an old man, or an aged widow, unable to earn anything by labour, the cows are committed to their charge.

RANGREZ.

Dyeing is considered one of the most respectable trades in Dacca, the dyer being usually called Çáfí, pure, or clean, while Khalífa and Ustád are honorary titles among them. The Rangrez rarely marries out of his own class, and will have nothing to do with the Kúṭí, Chamṛa-farosh, or other low grades of his co-religionists.

Dyeing is still in its infancy in Bengal, and the colours given to cloth are most unstable. The chief dye is safflower, from which are derived two colours, "Gulábí," or damask, and "Gulnár," or scarlet, tints in great demand for colouring bridal dresses and turbans. By mixing safflower and turmeric, "Basantí," a colour worn by Krishna,[1] is produced. With indigo and Gulábí, a colour known as "Kásní" is made, and with indigo and turmeric a green dye, called "Sabzí." A purple

[1] Hence the common epithet Pítámbara, clad in yellow, in the same way as Balaráma is called Nílámbara, from wearing blue garments.

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dye, Baiganí, obtained from Sappan wood, is a favourite colour for dyeing silk garments much fancied by young Brahmans, and others. As these defective dyes disappear in a shower of rain, clothes have to be frequently returned to the Rangrez, who, in consequence, is one of the busiest of workmen.

In former days each season had its particular coloured turbans, and the rich vied with one another in the showiness of their head-dresses. Basantí was, of course, the fashionable tint for spring, green being the orthodox colour for Muhammadans during the month of Muharram, as yellow is for the strict Hindus on the Janmáshṭami, or birthday of Krishna.

In dyeing portions of a pattern, or imitating in colours the outlines of plants and animals, the Rangrez sews on different shaped pieces of cloth, but when a wavy stripe on a coloured ground is required he merely stitches the cloth into folds. This mode of dyeing is called "Chunrí."

RAZ.

In Bengal, the mason, bricklayer, and plasterer are names of the same person, who generally belongs to the Kúṭí division, and though low in the social scale he will neither prepare mortar, nor act as hodman. The man or boy who prepares mortar, usually an apprentice, is called "Jogária," while the hodman is known as the "Tagháríya," from the hod which he carries. A woman occasionally takes the place of the latter, being designated the "Mihtaráni." Ustádgar is the ordinary title of masons, a class of workmen who will put their hands to almost anything. As occasion offers, they become traders, day labourers, or brickmakers; but this last occupation is usually left to the Kumhárs and Chaṇḍáls. Moulds for making bricks were formerly unknown, but of late years have been universally adopted. By the older method, the bricklayer merely flattened the clay to the proper thickness, drew lines according to the size wanted, and then cut off the pieces of clay. Ornamental bricks, and small sized tiles, called, "Ja'farí" or "Mirzá Ja'farí," are also manufactured by the Ráz, and are employed in making cornices and eaves.

Traders in lime (Chúná-wáláh) belong to any caste or race, slaked lime being imported by them from Silhet.

At the present day skilled masons earn from nine to fifteen rupees a month; the hodman about six, and the "Jogária" about four.

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REZA.[1]

This is the name of children employed in beating concrete roofs and verandahs with a wooden mallet, "Píṭní" or "Reza." They are always Muhammadans, usually belonging to Kúṭí families. These children are supervised by the mason, while their beating is regulated by a woman called Shariyárí in Bengal, Kamín in Hindustan. She recites indecent songs while the Reza beat time with their mallets.

ÇÁBUN-WÁLAH.

Soap was unknown to the ancient Hindus, who used as detergents Sarjiká or Sajji-maṭi, an impure carbonate of soda, and Besán or peasemeal.[2] Soap is one of the chief exports from Dacca, and it is highly esteemed throughout Bengal, at Penang, and the Malay Archipelago.

Soap is manufactured as follows: Eighty pounds of flat (Pattá) and forty of broken (Chúr) Sajji-maṭi are mixed in water with sixty pounds of shell lime, and as the solution is poured off water is added until all the salts are dissolved. Animal suet and Til oil are then mixed in varying quantities in a large vat, and slowly heated, the weaker lye being gradually added until an uniform mass is obtained. The fire is then extinguished, and the soap within a few days solidifies. The strained sediment is removed to another vat, where it is mixed with the stronger lye, called Tezí. After a second boiling, the common soap is fit for the market, but if an article of prime quality is wanted, three or even four boilings are necessary. The manufacture of good soap takes from fifteen to thirty days.

SÁDA-KÁR

Is a Muhammadan silversmith, who manufactures silver rings, gold ones not being usually worn by the lower classes. The onyx (Sulaimání), the salmon-tinted ('Aqíq), and yellow

[1] Reza in Persian signifies a bit, or portion; and as children only receive a part of a man's pay, the word is used to designate workmen receiving less than an adult's pay.

[2] Other vegetable detergents were also in use, such as Arishṭa, Phenila, or Soap-nut (*Sapindus detergens*), Ríṭhá (*Sapindus saponaria*), and Khalí, oilcake.

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(Sharbatí) carnelian are the favourite stones with Muhammadan men; and the Sádakár fixes these in rings with lac, and then turns in the bevelled edge of the setting.

Within the last few years several of the Kúṭí class, known as Muhammadan Sonárs, have become expert goldsmiths, competing on equal terms with the Hindu in the finest filagree work.

ÇAIQAL-GAR

Is a Muhammadan who polishes iron weapons and brass utensils with emery, or pumice stone (Jhámа); he furbishes swords, pistols, guns, knives, and scissors, and scours brass vessels and ornaments. In the cold season he visits the inland villages, while the Muhammadan villagers bring with them any articles requiring polishing whenever they come to the city. The Çaiqal-gar also paints or gilds chairs and boxes, and he is often expert at lacquering chairs and tables.

SANG-GAR.

This is a Muhammadan trade distinct from the Sang-tarásh, or stonecutter of Bihár, and the Çaiqalgar of Bengal. He is a cutler who sharpens agricultural implements, knives, and hatchets.

Cutlers manufacture their own grindstones in the following way. A red sand, brought from the Assam and Cachar hills by Ganṛar boatmen, being mixed with lac (Chapṛá), is thoroughly heated over a fire, and, while still plastic, fashioned into the form of a wheel, and allowed to cool. Water is never used in sharpening iron instruments, a little fine sand being placed in the trough to lessen the heat, while the cutler holds the point of the knife with a piece of bamboo. A pedal is not required, as a servant drives the wheel backwards and forwards. Cutlers never work with a revolving wheel, and it is only when driven towards them that the edge of the instrument is applied. When the grindstone is worn out, it is sold to the village barbers, who manage with it to sharpen razors, and put an edge on spades, hoes, and "daos" for their fellow-villagers.

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SHÁL-GAR.

Muhammadans who follow the profession of shawl cleaners, generally come from Hindustan, being invariably addressed as Paṭhán.

They wash Kashmírí, and other, shawls with soap or with the soap-nut (Ríṭhá)[1], darn holes, and then fumigate them with sulphur. Many Shálgars act as agents of the great Punjábí shawl merchants.

SHÍAHS.

The Shíahs, formerly large landholders in Eastern Bengal, have been steadily decreasing in numbers and influence during the last fifty years. At the present day they constitute a small proportion of the Muhammadan community, and in the city of Dacca do not possess above a hundred houses, although one fourth claim to be Sayyids. The majority are poor, a few only holding property which has been transmitted from father to son for three or four generations. When the English Government acquired possession of the Díwání of Bengal, many of the oldest and most respected families emigrated to Lucknow or Murshídábád, and those who remained had local ties which prevented them following the example of their neighbours.

By the Sunní the Shíah is styled Ráfizí (heretic), Tashaiyu', Irání, or Mughal; while he designates the Sunní Chár-yárí, Sunní Jam'at, or Tasannun.

In Dacca, the Shíahs having no Imám-dár, or priest, to lead the congregation at their devotions, the duty devolves on the most learned, or most honoured, among them. Although many of the old mosques in the city were built by Shíah nobles, the Sunnís will not permit any of that sect to enter them unless at hours when the service is not going on. A few years ago, quarrels arose between the rival sects, and, nowadays, the hatred of the Farazí is with such difficulty suppressed, that the Shíah rarely claims the right of worshipping in the public mosque, and very seldom resorts to it. Many Shíahs have turned Sunnís, marrying Sunní wives: but no Sunní will give his daughter to a Shíah.

Since the death of the last Nawáb of Dacca, in 1843, there has been no leader to keep the Shíahs united, or to prevent their absorption by the masses of Muhammadans around, while the disreputable life of the last Nawáb, and the absence of all restraint, have hastened the downfall of the old families. Many

[1] Sanskrit, Rishṭa, *Sapindus detergens.*

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have become drunkards and libertines, and opium eating or smoking is very generally practised. Among them, however, a few gentlemen with literary tastes are to be found, and their knowledge of the world, more especially of Persia and other Muhammadan countries, is more intimate than generally obtains among Sunnís. At their homes Persian is still spoken, Hindustani being only used out of doors and to servants, while Bengali is an unknown language.

Although by long residence in Bengal the Shíah race has degenerated like the Armenian, the occasional importation of pure Persian blood has preserved a few families, among whom tall muscular men with characteristic Mughal physiognomy and pale olive complexion are to be found. The women are of a pale brown, or sallow complexion, often pretty, and with finely shaped figures. Both men and women are grossly superstitious, being more thoroughly imbued than the Sunní with Muhammadan legends and traditions.

The Shíah, again, is more reserved, exclusive, and dignified than the Sunní. The latter is beginning to attend school, and to advance with the onward movement of his contrymen, but the former rarely exhibits any energy or ambition to get on in life. Like the descendants of the early Portuguese, they dwell on the past, lamenting the decadence of their power, and differing in no material respect from their forefathers of a century ago. They cherish old customs and repudiate new ones, allowing the different races around to adopt modern ideas, and to progress towards a happier civilisation, while they alone remain unchanged.

The Shíahs are charitable to the poor, a few even paying "Zakát" at the rate of a fortieth of their income, and "Khams," or one-fifth of their profits, to the Sayyids. Although the Zakát is only distributed among Muhammadans, they inculcate and bestow charity on the destitute of all creeds.

The Muharram is the great Shíah fast, during which they do nothing but mourn and weep, eschewing fish for thirteen days, chewing no pân, and leaving the hands and feet unstained. The Husainí Dalán is still crowded with the "Marsiya," singers, and with spectators, but the number of Shíahs joining in the most solemn services do not exceed thirty. The number is decreasing yearly, and there is every prospect of the building being soon closed for want of worshippers.

The Shíah still preserves many superstitions regarding food. He will not touch the flesh of hares, peacocks, wading-birds, birds without gizzards, and fish without scales.

The 'Aqíqa, or thanksgiving festival on the birth of a child, though adopted by the Farazí, is peculiarly a Shíah custom, and

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consequently rejected by the Sunní. Like the Farazí the Shíah does not consider it meritorious to visit or make votive offerings at the tombs of Indian saints, a point in which they differ from the Persian Shíah.

The Dacca Shíahs still observe the Múṇḍná ceremony on the seventh day after birth, but they are too poor to comply with all the requirements, such as weighing the child's hair with gold coins, and distributing the amount in charity.

During the palmy days of Muhammadan rule, the Shíahs were the merchants, the Hindus the agents, brokers, and carriers of the inland commerce. At the present day the Shíah still trades, purchasing goods cheap in Calcutta and selling them at a profit in the villages of the interior. The ordinary name for a miscellaneous store, where mirrors, pictures, glass shades, and candelabra are sold, is "Mughaliya dukán," although the proprietor is not a Shíah.

It need hardly be added that the religion of the Shíahs is the same as that of the Persians, and has remained unaffected by the Farazí movement around.

SHIKÁRÍ.

Few Hindus in Eastern Bengal take any pleasure in sport, and only a few low caste men ever fire a gun. The Muhammadan, on the other hand, is often a keen sportsman, shooting deer and stalking paddy birds, rails, and other water birds. Rich families, again, often keep one or two Shikáris to supply their tables with all the common marsh birds and with an occasional deer or hare. The Mír-shikárí Bediyás and the Binds are, however, the only classes in Eastern Bengal who live by the game they kill.

In the cold season Muhammadans from Chittagong visit the Dacca district and capture the "Machh-rangá," or large blue kingfisher (*Todiramphus collaris*), in the following manner: On the bank of a pool or running stream, two nets hanging on rings are fixed at an acute angle, within which a tame kingfisher is placed as a decoy. The birds are most pugnacious, and as soon as a wild one sees the stranger it swoops down, but striking the upright net it becomes entangled, and all attempts to get free are unavailing. The concealed sportsmen make their appearance, and capturing the helpless bird, kill and skin it. The flesh is eaten, while the skin is pinned on a thick jungle leaf and dried. When sold to the Burmese, four anas are got for each skin.

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The Mags, who occasionally visit the Eastern districts for the same purpose, by using nooses of string, and placing them in a circle around the decoy bird, are equally successful.

SHÍSHA-GAR.

The Shísha-gar is a glass blower, not a manufacturer of glass. He buys old broken tumblers and lamp shades, and in a very simple and expeditious manner fashions lamp-shades, phials, pipe stands and mouthpieces, and bottles (Qárúra) indispensable in the practice of Hakíms.

The articles manufactured are very brittle and full of air bubbles. With copper a green tint is given to glass; but the Shísha-gar is ignorant how to impart any other, and he cannot mould vessels.

The workman makes the various articles by fixing a mass of molten glass on the point of an iron tube, and by alternate blowing and rolling fashions it as he wishes. The size of the vessel is regulated by a pair of iron pincers held in the right hand, while the iron tube is being twirled in the left.

During the Durga-púja the Shísha-gar is very busy, but at other seasons he depends on orders. Even the rude articles he makes are in great demand, and his small phials filled with perfumes, as well as lamp-shades, are to be seen in every respectable house. It is a matter of regret that men, so expert with clumsy tools, and so anxious to learn, should not be instructed in the modern art of glass blowing.

SIYÁHÍ-WÁLAH.

Ink manufacturers are always Muhammadans, there being in Dacca about twenty families of them.

There are three kinds of ink:—

1. Mushkí, made with charred rice soaked in water, to which lampblack is added.
2. Kitábí, made like the first, but gum acacia is an additional ingredient.
3. Qurání is a mixture of lampblack, gum, and vinegar, thoroughly boiled together.

Red ink (Shangarf), only made to order, is composed of red-lead disolved in garlic juice.

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SÚZAN-GAR.

The artizans of this name manufacture with brass wire, pins, linked chains, finger-rings with bead setting, earrings, nose-rings, and tethers for tame parrots. Formerly they also made needles, but English ones are so vastly superior that no others are now used. They repair broken china and glass with gluten, sugar, and bands of wire.

The Súzan-gars have learned the art of plating in Calcutta, and gild in the following manner: A pot containing a solution of potash is warmed over a fire, and a brass ring tied to a piece of gold with a copper wire is immersed in it for five or six minutes, when it is removed, washed, and placed in the sun, and the gilding is complete.

The Súzan-gar often keeps a "Manihárí," or huckster's shop, where miscellaneous stores are sold.

TAMBÁKÚ-WÁLAH.

The use of tobacco spread with wonderful rapidity through the East. In 1565, Sir John Hawkins first brought it to England; in 1601, the Portuguese introduced it into Java;[1] and the same year Asad Beg procured some at Bíjapúr, which he presented to Akbar. It was then supposed to have come from China, but the leaf was already in use at Mecca and Madínah.[2] According to the author of the Dárá Shikohi, the plant was first cultivated in India, by order of Akbar, in 1605. In 1617, the smoking of tobacco "having taken very bad effect upon the health and minds of many persons," Jahángír ordered that no one should practice the habit, but the Khán-i-'Álam was so addicted to it that he could not abstain.[3]

The use of tobacco extended, notwithstanding a prohibitory edict of Sháh 'Abbás (1582–1627), and in 1637, Mandelslo[4] found both rich and poor in Teheran smoking it, and drinking "Cahwa." The plant was grown near Bághdad, and in Kurdistán, but its preparation being defective, "Inglis tambáku" was preferred. The Persians smoked it through a cocoa nut, a dried pumpkin, or a glass vessel half filled with scented water.

[1] Crawford's "Dictionary."
[2] Elliot's "History of India," vi, 165.
[3] *Op. cit.*, vi, 351.
[4] I, 576.

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Chardin,[1] who lived in Persia from 1664 to 1670, mentions that the English first introduced "Tabac de Brezil" about 1630, but finding it too strong, the Persians took to cultivating the plant for themselves, the finest quality being grown at Hamadán and towards the Gulf. To increase its stimulating effects, Indian hemp was usually mixed with it.

It was probably owing to a spirit of opposition to what was then a Hindu and Muhammadan custom, that Guru Govind (1675–1708) forbad the use of snuff by his followers, and at the present day the Sikhs abstain from tobacco in all forms.

In India a name for tobacco is Súratí, from Súrat, where it was first imported; but physicians pronounce this sort to be possessed of very drying properties, and only fit for use when washed in rose-water, or "Bed-mushk."

According to the Hakíms, tobacco is hot and dry, being good for cold and lymphatic temperaments, but prejudicial to thin, spare habits, as it tends to consume, and still further emaciate the body. Its corrector (Muçlih) is milk, and when mixed with molasses the injurious effects of the weed are counteracted.

In Eastern Bengal, tobacco from Kochh Bihár is considered the finest; but that grown at Lucknow, Benares, or Patna is preferred by some, while tobacco grown locally is generally wanting in pungency; but a variety called "Wiláyati," evidently introduced by the English, and remarkable for its small leaves, is highly commended for its strength.

With very few exceptions all men smoke in Bengal, and boys scarcely able to walk may be seen inhaling the fragrant weed. Muhammadan women smoke and many chew, while, on the other hand, Hindu women only chew, and no high caste female will smoke.

Tobacco leaf is sold by Hindus of different castes, but Muhammadans alone will sell it ready made for smoking. Tobacco in towns is prepared for use by mixing the cut leaf with molasses, and then pounding them together in a mass, but in villages the leaf is merely cut up, mixed with molasses and kneaded with the hands. Nine-tenths of the native population smoke tobacco in one or other of these forms, but connoisseurs object to the pungency of the weed thus prepared, and prefer spiced tobacco (Maçálah ka tambákú), consisting of various ingredients, kept ready mixed, and sold by the tobacconists to customers of known tastes. Camphor, fœnu-greek, bay-leaves, and grated sandal wood are ordinarily used in Bengal; but by Hindustánís, conserve of roses, Jack-fruit juice, or that of the pineapple "Keorá" (*pan-*

[1] III, 15. George Sandys, in his travels of 1610, is the first Englishman who describes tobacco-smoking among the Turks. In Russell's "Aleppo," i, 373, further particulars regarding the introduction of tobacco in the East are given.

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danus) or "Kus-kus" are fancied. Among the higher classes of Muhammadans the white part of the Harsingár (*Nyctanthes*) flower is dried in the sun, and the expressed juice, mixed with tobacco, is said to impart the most delicious flavour to the weed.

Strong tobacco is, as a rule, chewed, the mild smoked. In Upper India tobacco leaf mixed with lime is generally chewed; but in Bengal, women, who are the most inveterate chewers, mix it with pân. The saliva is always expectorated, and there is no more repulsive sight in the Zanánas than that of walls, mats, and floors disfigured by the stains of the tobacco chewer.

When tobacco leaf is torn into small pieces, and the pipe-bowl filled, it is called "Sulfá," and again, when a plate of zinc or copper is put between the tobacco and the lighted charcoal, it is designated "Táwá."

Snuff (Nás), which is generally retailed by Muhammadans who keep miscellaneous stores, is rarely used except medicinally, being said to cure headaches by eliminating morbid humours from the brain. Two sorts of snuff are sold, the Benares and Masulipatam.

As a cure for a cold in the head, a very popular remedy is tobacco-leaf, which has been broken and dried before a fire. A pinch or two of this snuffed up, is said to cure the most obstinate cold.

TÁNTÍ.

The Muhammadan weaver belongs to a different "qaum," or division, to the Juláha, the former weaving fine Jámadání, or embroidered cloth, the latter only coarse muslins. These two classes eat and drink together, but never intermarry. The Tántí, moreover, resents being called Juláha, and is usually addressed as Kárígar, or Jámadání Tántí.

Mussulmán weavers are very numerous in Dacca, especially at Dhemra, Nabíganj, and other villages along the banks of the Lakhya, where they cultivate the soil whenever trade is dull. Their women never weave, working instead at "Chikan" embroidery, and looking down on the females of the Juláha class because they clean, card, and spin cotton.

Many Muhammadan weavers accept orders from the Hindu Tántí, who rarely manufactures Jámadání muslins. Hindu Mahájans, or Sardárs, as capitalists are called, or the Mussulmán "Sháot,"[1] advance money for certain sorts of work, which is allotted among different families, who agree to finish the piece

[1] Said to be a corruption of the Sanskrit Sádhú, a merchant.

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within a fixed time. The great market for Jámadání cloth is Dhemra, on the Lakhya, and every Friday a fair is held there, at which large quantities of cloth are bought and sold.

The loom of the Tántí differs from that of the Juláha in having two "reeds" (Shánah), and two pedals (Jokhia), with which a web of from three to three and a half feet can be woven. The weaver, with whom a boy generally works, having no pattern to guide him, learns off by heart the number of threads he has to miss or pick up. Boys are taught the trade by having to join broken threads, and it is surprising at what an early age they become expert weavers.

It is a curious fact, and one very difficult to account for, that the modern Farazí doctrines have gained no footing among these weavers, the few who have been perverted invariably relinquisn the occupation of Tántís, being excommunicated by the community. The only other Muhammadan classes among which Farazí preachers have failed to make any impression are the Hajjám and Dhobá, who observe in all its old perfection the Hinduized Muhammadanism of India. The weavers make pilgrimages to the tombs of saints, construct "Ta'ziyas" at the Muharram, invoke Zindah Ghází, the Panch Pír, and other Indian worthies, and participate in the license of the Holí.

Jámadání muslins are named from the pattern on them, and are usually worn by women, although fast men occasionally assume a Jámadání dhotí, or waist-cloth. The Sárí, or female wrapper, with an embroidered end, is known as "Achla," without one, but with four Koní, or Pankhí, "'Tethí."

Muslin is, as a rule, ornamented with flowers (Bútá), spots of various figures, stripes, cheques, or the pear-shaped designs so familiar on Kashmír shawls; and sometimes the piece is dyed of an ashen colour with charcoal and Káí, or starch.

TÁR-WÁLÁH.

This is the offensive trade of the Boyaudier, or gut-spinner, who prepares gut from the entrails of goats and sheep[1] for the strings of pellet bows (Ghulel), and musical instruments, such as the Behlá and Sárangí.

The fresh intestine being scraped and cut into lengths, according to size, is rolled in the palms of the hands, and dried. In former days, the entrails of all goats and sheep slaughtered in Dacca became the perquisite of the trade, but of late years they are bought as required.

[1] Tánt in Dacca, is gut made from the intestines of cattle.

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The Tár-wálahs intermarry with other Muhammadans, as their ancestor is said to have been the Khádim, or custodian, of a private mosque, the property of Nawáb Sháistah Khán, from which post he was arbitrarily driven out.

ṬIKIYÁ-WÁLÁH.

The makers of charcoal balls for tobacco-pipes are always Muhammadans, and there are about twenty-five houses occupied by them in Dacca. Boot sellers and Ṭikiyá manufacturers never sell their goods on Friday, the Muhammadan Sunday, a custom for which they can assign no reason.

Charcoal is prepared in huts erected on the borders of jungly tracts, thorny underwood producing the best. As the wood becomes charred, it is sprinkled with water and pounded in a "Dhenkí," after which the powder is sifted, and mixed with Congee water until a soft paste is formed. Women manipulate this into flattish cakes, which are arranged on mats and placed in the sun. Common "Guls," as they are called, sell for six or seven paisa a thousand; when bought wholesale by brokers they are sold at so much a mat, or so much for three mats, equal one "Gasht," or day's sale, and costing from five to six anas.

Guls again are either "Kachcha," soft, or "Pakka," hard; the former being made like the "Ṭikiyá," with the addition of rice paste (Leí), and the juice of the "Gáb" (*Embryopteris glutinifera*); the latter being prepared in a similar way, but, after adding the Gáb, the mass is again pounded, put into a vessel in which it is trodden with the feet, "Methí" (*Trigonella*), coriander, and syrup (Ráb), being mixed with it.

The "Kachchá" gul blackens cloth, and is rapidly consumed when once a-glow; the "Pakka" does not soil the fingers or cloth, it burns slowly, and when properly made will be found burning at the centre for some time after immersion in water. The Kachchá sell at from five to six anas a hundred, while the Pakka fetch sixteen to twenty-four anas.

ZAR-KOFT.

In accordance with the minute subdivision of labour in the East, the maker of gold and silver foil is distinct from the

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Koft-gar, or inlayer of metals, the latter being regarded as the more respectable calling.

Silver or gold foil is prepared as follows: A rupee-weight of silver is drawn into a wire a yard long; it is then beaten flat, cut into lengths, and put between the folds of a skin,[1] and with an iron mallet, weighing about four pounds, the metal is hammered into as fine a leaf as possible. Gold-leaf thus prepared is sold to Kabírájs for medical purposes, and to the Koft-gar for his particular trade.

[1] The skin, brought from Umritsur, is probably that of the hare, or musk-deer.

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SECTION II.

RELIGIOUS SECTS OF THE HINDUS.

INTRODUCTORY REMARKS.
RITES AND CUSTOMS COPIED FROM ABORIGINAL RACES.
SECTS :—

Vaishnava.—Rámánuja—Rámávat—Nímávat—Vaishnavas of Bengal—Báyan-Kaupína—Kiṣorí-Bhajana—Jagat Mohaní—Spashṭa-Dáyaka—Kaví-Indra-Parivára—Báola—Darwesh-Faqír.
Ṣaiva.—Kánpháta-Jogí—Brahmácharí.
Various.—Ṣrí-Náráyaṇa—Suthra Sháhí—Nának Sháhí—Trináth Pújah.

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HINDU.

THE Hindus of Bengal deny that they have any Dravidian, or Kolarian, blood in their veins, and disown any connection with these two aboriginal races; yet Colonel Dalton[1] has arrived at the conclusion that aboriginal blood does form an important element in the constitution of the modern Bengali. It was most natural for the non-Aryan tribes to seek amalgamation with the civilised and enterprising foreigners, and this desire has always been encouraged by the Patita, or fallen, Bráhmans. The stages through which the mixed races passed before becoming Hindus can be ascertained by observing what is occurring at the present day. The Hill Garos, entering the plains, and intermarrying with Hindus, gave rise to the Hajong, a mongrel people, who, again, are kinsmen of the Doí, a caste having Bráhmans as Purohits. The same gradation is also observable in the case of the Ráj-vaṇsí Kochh, the Kochh Mandáí, and the Súrya-vaṇsí.

It is therefore reasonable to conclude that intermarriages between the early Hindus of the plains and the Dravidian Bhúiyas of the hills gave birth to similar mixed tribes, which, in the course of time, have been absorbed into the ranks of the Hindus, and are now reckoned pure Aryans. How far the aboriginal strain has impressed itself on the habits and customs of the people is a subject worthy of inquiry, as throwing a strong light on the real origin of the present inhabitants of Bengal. Many religious rites and usages have undoubtedly been adopted from the forest tribes, while others as certainly are survivals of particular tribal ceremonies, antecedent to the ordinances of the Ṣástras. Bráhmans, and high-caste Hindus, assert that there is no resemblance between their ceremonies and those of the aborigines, and if any similarity be detected it arises from the latter copying them. But not only is the appearance of the typical Bengali distinct from that of the typical Aryan, but the habits, religious rites, and gods of the two races differ materially. If any inference is to be drawn from these

[1] "Descriptive Ethnology of Bengal," pp. 305–309. Professor Max Müller, in the 17th Report of the British Association, London, 1848, says: "In Northern India the lower classes of the Hindus consist of aboriginal inhabitants, and some continue still outcasts in forests, and as servants in villages."

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facts, it surely is that the Aryan settlers in Bengal, being either too few in numbers, or too weak, to eradicate aboriginal ideas, finally yielded, and adopted the superstitious rites of their neighbours. Other points are worthy of notice. These traces of aboriginal influence are chiefly found among the outcast tribes, presenting a remarkable diminution in the higher; and Bengali Bráhmans are still found practising ceremonials not enjoined by the Śástras, and clearly indigenous.

So many of the rites and usages of the people in Eastern Bengal are contrary to Hindu conceptions, and closely resemble the rites and usages of the Dravidian and Kolarian races, that we may reasonably conclude that they have been derived from the pre-Aryan tribes, more especially as the Śastras, and Puránas, are silent regarding them. It is, however, absurd to suppose that superstitious rites of aboriginal origin will be found as common among the high castes, as they undoubtedly are among the low, for within the memory of men still living many outcast tribes have discarded characteristic ceremonies, because they were at variance with Hindu orthodoxy, while many singular customs formerly observed by the Brahmanical order have fallen into disuse, and are now repudiated by it. Still there remains so much that is not Hindu, but aboriginal, that we can only ascertain its prevalence by examining those customs peculiar to Bengali Hindus, but unknown to the purer Aryan of Upper India.

1. Wearing the hair long and twisted into a knot, fixed behind, at one side, or on the top of the head, is characteristic of Dravidian tribes. When unwound the hair hangs in dark tresses over the neck, and to prevent inconvenience the wearer ties it with a silken or grass thread. Even among the semi-Hinduized races of Bengal, the Tíyar, Ṛishi, Beṛua, Chaṇḍál, and Gaṇṛár, this fashion still survives, and the young men adorn the top-knot with a "Champá," or other fragrant, flower. A reddish colour towards the point, very characteristic of all semi-Hinduized peoples wearing long hair, is usually attributed to neglect of oil, but no such change of colour is seen among Vairágis of high caste, who are the only Hindus who never shave the head.[1]

Dr. Caldwell affirms that wearing the hair long, and twisted into a knot, is peculiar to Dravidian races, being the badge of non-Aryan tribes, and that shaving the head, except the Sikhá, or Choṭí, is the distinguishing mark of an Aryan, or pseudo-Aryan, race. The Vishnu Puráṇa, again, states that the Páradas

[1] Jogis are often seen with red matted locks, but this is due to their smearing the hair with Alkaline earth.

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wore long hair, and Menu includes them among the Dásyus, who are undoubtedly non-Aryan, being distinguished by their long hair.

By the higher classes of Hindus long hair is, even at the present day, considered the proper coiffure for the Nícha, and when any of them appear with shaven pate, and cue, they have to bear much chaff at their pretensions. Most of the lower castes, however, are vain of their dark tresses, and spend much time in arranging them. It is amusing to watch a young Chaṇḍál boatman with his mirror, comb, and pot of mustard oil, intent on dressing his hair in what he regards the most taking style, and when he steps ashore there is no diffidence apparent in his walk, and no misgiving as he struts among the shaveling Hindus. It will be long before fashion changes with him, or induces him to give up so much personal gratification.

Whenever any of the long-haired castes appear before Hindus, as the Ṛishi is often required to do, they either hide the locks beneath the folds of a turban, or wind them so as to be invisible. For this reason, few notice the prevalence of the custom in Bengal—a custom, moreover, chiefly found among castes rarely brought into contact with Europeans.

It is a remarkable fact that Nicolo de Conti, describing the dwellers of the Delta, early in the fifteenth century, says: "The Indians along the Ganges have no beards, but very long hair, which some tie at the back of their head with a cord, and let it flow over their shoulders." No traveller at the present day would represent the inhabitants of Bengal as a long-haired people, but De Conti wrote before the advent of Chaitanya, and before Vaishnavism obliged its followers to shave the head. It is probable, however, that the Venetian traveller is speaking of the fisher and agricultural races, who even now wear the hair in the style he describes.

Wavy or frizzled hair, as distinguished from woolly, is occasionally seen among the lower castes. One member of a family may have it, while the others have the usual long silken locks, and when it occurs the beard and moustache are large and bushy. Three of a Beṛua family from the banks of the Padma exhibited this peculiarity of hair in a remarkable manner. The eldest, aged 30, paternal uncle of the other two, had the hair frizzled, but fine and glossy, and whiskers large; the second, aged 26, had coarse curly hair; and the third, aged 19, had luxuriant red-tipped locks hanging in clusters over the shoulders.

Long hair is deemed by all Hindus an attraction, and one of the numerous epithets of Kṛishna is Keṣava, the long-haired. Loose unkempt hair (Jaṭa), rolled in a knot above the head, is

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characteristic of Jogis, and Ṣaiva mendicants, and an epithet of Ṣiv is Jaṭa-dhara, wearing matted hair.

2. Individuals with blue eyes and red hair are less common than in Hindustan; but among the Ṣánkhárís of Dacca a few families are remarkable for this singularity. Their skin is either colourless,[1] or brown in patches, the hair coarse and red; but there is no defect of vision. This hereditary peculiarity has descended through several generations, and is not considered a bar, or even an objection, to marriage.

Natives with blue (kanjá), grey, or cat's eyes (viḍála chakra), although common in Bengal are perhaps less so than among Rájputs, Kurmís, and the Kolítas of Asam.[2] This anomaly, generally accounted a blemish, is either inherited, or, like a mother mark, congenital. The blue iris is always crossed by white, or grey, radii, while the pupil is surrounded by a pale yellowish areola. The hair of the head is black, but soon turns grey; that of the body and eyebrows is pale brown. Examples of this defect were noticed among individuals of the Ghaṭak, Gop, and Chaṇḍál castes.

3. When Europeans first visited Bengal they were struck with the pale colour of the people. The Cingalese, and residents of Southern India, who were best known, being of dark hue, the travellers were not prepared to find races paler than those left behind.[3] Manrique, who resided at Dacca about 1640, and traversed Eastern Bengal, speaks of the people as being either of a yellowish-brown colour (color bázo), or black like the Cingalese. At the present day all shades of yellowish-brown are met with, and colour is no longer a test of purity of race. As a people the inhabitants of Bengal are darker than Hindustání tribes; but even among Bráhmans the colour of the skin is often as swarthy as among Dravidians. The Chamár is proverbially dark, but many Ṣrotriyá Bráhmans are darker. Exposure to the sun, wind, and rain tends to blacken the skin. Members of a caste residing in the country are darker than their town brethren, and those engaged in agricultural pursuits than sedentary traders. Comparing the different strata of the population in Bengal, it will be found, as a general rule, that the higher the caste the fairer the complexion, and the lower in social grade the darker. But to this rule there are many exceptions, and it cannot be predicated from the hue of the skin what is the social position of the individual. The natives regard dark men as belonging to low, and fair ones to high castes; but experience

[1] Leucoderma, or Leucopathia.

[2] Dalton's "Descriptive Ethnology," pp. 79, 320.

[3] Linschoten writes, "Incolae colore similes sunt insulanis in Seylon, nisi quod plusculum albicent quam Cingalas."

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proves that this test is most fallacious. The Aryan blood has, as in other parts of India, prevailed over the aboriginal, and in physiognomy, build, and complexion, the native of Bengal generally shows more resemblance to the former than to the latter. The figure of the average Bengali is that of a short, slim, well made, but physically weak man, with ample forehead and an intellectual cast of countenance, differing in every respect from the typical flat-featured, broad-nosed, squat and dumpy figure of the Dravidian. It is, however, rash to argue from physique, or colour, for among the present inhabitants of Bengal, and even in the ranks of the most distinguished, individuals are found who resemble in every respect the race with whom they have the least manifest connection.

4. Tattooing is a style of personal decoration fashionable among all classes of women. Bráhman, Chaṇḍál, and even Muhammadan, females think their charms are enhanced by permanently staining the face. In some parts of Bengal it is forbidden to a Bráhman, or a clean caste man, to drink water from the hands of any woman without a spot or stain. This prejudice, although formerly deeply rooted, is now dying out fast. There is no doubt, however, that staining the skin was originally an aboriginal, not an Aryan custom, and neither in Sanskrit nor Bengali are there words for tattooing.[1] The terms Godná and Pachhná, common to most of the Indian languages, are Hindi. Moreover, the most expert tattooers in Hindustan are the Natní, in Bengal the Bediyání and Chaṇḍální; and the Chamáin women have recourse to it more than the females of any other class.

Tattooing is practised by most Kolarian and Dravidian tribes. The Anka Miris are so called by the Asamese, on account of their stained faces. No Naga can be tattooed until he has brought home a head, and marriage is then permitted, if he makes himself as hideous as possible by tattooing. The Kyeng girls of Arakan are tattooed at an early age, and so disfigured that they are saved from being kidnapped by neighbouring tribes. Other races have adopted distinguishing stain marks. The Bírhor women stain their chests, arms, and ankles, but never the face; the Oráon the brow and temples only; the Ho paint on the skin an arrow, the national emblem;[2] but any Kisan female getting tattooed is summarily expelled from the tribe.

Among semi-Hinduized races this decoration is greatly admired. The Ágareah tattoo the hands and feet, not the face;

[1] Painting the face with sandal, saffron, and other fragrant substances was practised, and Pattra is the usual Sanskrit term for this decoration.

[2] Dalton's "Descriptive Ethnology," pp. 132, 191.

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and the Chamár stain all the exposed parts of the body. Hindus in Eastern Bengal are usually satisfied with a stellate spot (ullikhi) stained on the forehead above the base of the nose, but often fancy having the helix of the ear tattooed, and ornamented with filigree studs. Buchanan informs us that tattooing was more fashionable in Bihár than Bhágalpur, and that the strict Hindus of Gorakhpúr were not prevented drinking from the hands of a maiden of unstained face.

5. Several customs connected with marriage, and the rights of property, though prohibited by Hindu legislation, are still practised by the semi-Hinduized tribes, but considerably modified in the course of ages. The most important of these tribal usages is widow marriage. Menu[1] denounces the practice as fit only for cattle, but admits it was allowed in the days of the impious Veṇa. In one passage,[2] however, the legality of a childless widow marrying a kinsman is conceded. At the present day neither Bráhmans nor clean Ṣudras practise it, but in 1756 the famous Rájah Ráj Bullabh, a Vaidyá of Dacca, wishing to get his widowed daughter re-married, consulted the Pandits, who decided that women are at liberty to re-marry, if their husbands be not heard of, if they die, become ascetics, impotent, or degraded.[3] This decision, more favourable than could have been expected, was never, it is said, acted upon. In Buchanan's time three-fourths of the Hindus of Dinájpúr recognised widow marriages as lawful, but did not reckon it so honourable as Viváha or proper matrimony. Whenever observed the contract is voluntary, the usual ceremonies are curtailed, turmeric is not used, and divorce is prohibited except for adultery. Sagái[4] is the usual term in Bengal, Nikáh in Upper India.

In Eastern Bengal at the present day widow marriage, though less common than formerly, is still solemnized by the Chaṇḍáls, Mahisha Goálas, Gaḍariyá, Kochh Mandái, Kándho, Kewaṭ, Jaiswára Kurmís, Muriárí, Ṛishi, and Súraj-vaṇṣi. In Kámrup[5] the Vaidika Bráhman, and Ráj-vaṇṣi, widows re-marry; the children of the latter however, cannot marry in their father's class, but must be satisfied to wed with inferior clean tribes. Among the Mahrattas, Páṭ, as it is called, is common with all Ṣúdra castes, and the ceremony is always performed at the Kṛishná-paksha, or dark half of the month. Banjára[6] widows

[1] Menu, ix, 64–66
[2] *Ibid.*, ix, 190.
[3] "Calcutta Review," xxv, 358.
[4] Sa-gotra—of the same family.
[5] Buchanan, iii, 519.
[6] "J. A. S. of Bengal," xiii, 4.

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re-marry, the ceremony consisting in the gift of a new cloth, and the selection of a fortunate hour in which to conduct the bride to her new home. Among the Mallialies of Madras,[1] a widow must marry any man proposing to her, and the ceremony generally takes place fifteen days after the husband's death.

Any Muhammadan widow in Bengal can re-marry four months and ten days after the death of her husband, but she can only become a Nikáh wife.[2] These instances are enough to prove that widow marriage, though denounced by the Bráhmans, is still practised throughout India. The two castes which observe it most frequently are the Kurmí and Koeri; but of late years the Ayodhyá Kurmís, apeing the usages of their superiors, have relinquished it altogether. Widow marriage is not universal among Kolarian and Dravidian tribes, but Colonel Dalton mentions it as existing among the Mikirs, Máns, and Páni-Kochh, and it is probable that when rich no widow belonging to these or kindred tribes ever pines for a second husband.

In former days, when a Hindu died before consummation, his widow was marriageable to his brother, he and she both consenting; but a certain blemish attached to her from having been previously affianced to another. This union was quite distinct from the proper Levirate marriage, which recognises a brother, or near kinsman, as the person to raise up seed (kshetriya) to a deceased and childless brother. Even Menu says,[3] if a widow, her lord being dead, have no sons, she is to be dependent on the near kinsman of her husband; and again,[4] the son by a kinsman inherits the collected estate of the deceased. On the other hand, such a commission to a brother, or other near kinsman, is denounced by the same legislator,[5] as being nowhere mentioned in the nuptial texts of the Vedas.

6. Among many Hindu tribes, the Levirate marriage custom is still observed. The Ját men assert the right of marrying their deceased brother's wife; but the women vehemently dispute the claim.[6] With the Koerí[7] the usage is still common. Within the last few years the Rishí, Chandál, Patní, and Ganrár have relinquished this usage, which is repugnant to the feelings of all Bengali Hindus. The Hindustáni Tántí, Chamár, Dosád, and Gadariyá still practise it, and are not ashamed to

[1] Shortt, part ii, 43.
[2] "Koran" (Sale), chap. ii, p. 28.
[3] Menu, v, 148.
[4] *Ibid.*, ix, 190.
[5] *Ibid.*, ix, 65.
[6] "J. A. S. of Bengal," xxxv, 135.
[7] "Descriptive Ethnology," p. 321.

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confess that they do so. Dalton states[1] that the polygamous Málers observe the Levirate marriage, and when a man dies his numerous widows are distributed among the brothers and cousins, but only one to each. The Márs of Sirguja, too, always take to wife their sisters-in-law. Dr. Shortt mentions that in Vizagapatam Bráhmans, Chhatrís, and Ṣúdras do not allow their widows to marry, but they are taken in concubinage by the younger brothers. In Bengal the union is never obligatory, and, if either objects, the widow returns to her father's house, and may re-marry with the man of her own choice. No compensation is paid to the widow's family should the objection have come from the brother-in-law. It is only in the case of a deceased elder brother's wife that this Jewish custom is observed.

A very remarkable instance of the Levirate marriage is preserved in the Puránas, and goes to prove that the usage was not so abhorrent then as it is now. In the Vishnu Purána Vyása, by command of his mother Satyavatí, marries the two widows of his eldest half-brother Vichitravírya, and begets, besides others, the famous Páṇḍu. In this legend there are two peculiarities—the command of the mother to the son, and the relationship of the heir, who is half-brother of the deceased.

By Hindu law seven kinds of second marriage are recognised, which are, however, in practice restricted to the Ṣúdra castes. The Levirate marriage is designated Punar-bhú, being born again; while Para-púrvá is any woman who has had a previous husband.

The Levirate marriage is really a right of succession, or a counterpart of that right, and is closely connected with the descent through females, a more archaic system of kinship than that through males. According to McLennan,[2] both procedures can only be explained by the practice of polyandry. In the ruder form, namely, that in which the husbands are not brothers, the descent in the female line is always observed.

7. Polyandry is still a recognised institution among the Butias,[3] the Kametis, and Botis of Ladák,[4] and the Kasias[5] of Eastern Bengal, and with these tribes female descent is the rule. Kasia children inherit through the mother, and are buried beside her, while the father lies among his kindred. Polyandry is extinct among the Garo and Kochh, but Garo sons do not inherit, and the widowed mother remains head of the house. The Kochh husband, again, transferring all his pro-

[1] Op. cit., p. 273.
[2] "Primitive Marriage," p. 200.
[3] Dalton, p. 98.
[4] Cunningham's "Ladak," p. 295.
[5] "J. A. S. of Bengal," ix, 834; xiii, 625.

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perty to his wife, goes and lives with her mother, and when she dies, her daughters are the heirs.

Vestiges of these primitive customs are still found among the Hindus of the plains, although polyandry has been obsolete for centuries. That these vestiges are survivals of systems older than the Aryans is most probable, for they exist among the Todas, the most ancient inhabitants of the peninsula, but no Hindu will admit they were ever practised by his ancestors. Nevertheless, these usages are met with at the present day among the aboriginal tribes of Central India, and the lowest agricultural races of Bihár, who, Colonel Dalton considers,[1] are descended from Kols. It is a remarkable fact that Mithila and Sarvária Bráhmans still recognise the bhánjá, or sister's son, as the family priest; and the Mungírya Tántís style him Bráhman, investing him with the presidency at all domestic and party gatherings.

8. Demonolatry, or Shamanism,[2] is a system of religious worship peculiar to Dravidian and other non-Aryan races; but it is still practised in Bengal by Chaṇḍáls, and more frequently by Chamárs and other low Hindustání castes. By Shamanism is understood an ecstatic state into which the devotee throws himself by abstraction, drugs, and the excitement of the giddy dance, quickened by the din of musical instruments. As Sir J. Lubbock points out, Shamanism is no definite system of theology, but a stage of belief in advance of that in which animals and trees are worshipped. It expresses a yearning after a closer communion with a higher intelligence, and when in ecstasy the worshipper is believed to have soared above the world, and become united with a loftier and holier nature. While in this condition he is able, or supposed to be able, to foretell futurity, and, inspired by a demon, to answer questions beyond the ken of other men. In Hindustán the common term for this divine fury is "Deo charhána," to make the god mount up; in Bengal "Biál paran." The beings worshipped are not of this world, but connected in some mysterious way with the deity. They are usually regarded as devils, wicked, vindictive, and fitful, whose enmity is averted by timely sacrifices. It is unusual to pay adoration to any particular demon, but the Chamárs call upon Deví, with all the superstitious formalities of Shamanism.

Tribes practising this form of worship have no regular priesthood, although in Southern India the Shaman is a recognised profession; consequently any one, who feels himself fitted, can

[1] "Descriptive Ethnology," p. 63.

[2] Shaman, in Persian, signifies an idolater, being derived from the Sanskrit Śramaṇa, a Buddhist mendicant.

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assume the character, and whenever trouble or calamity threatens it is easy to hire a competent actor.

The priests of the Kolarian Santál are the most expert Shamans, and after prolonged fasting, prayer, and mental abstraction, throw themselves into a frenzy by the beating of drums.[1] In Eastern Bengal the Shaman is popularly called the "Matwálah," or the intoxicated, as it is customary for him to prepare for the performance by fasting a whole day, drinking Bháng, or smoking Gánjhá, and quaffing the freshly drawn blood of a goat, sheep, or buffalo. In Dacca the Charak Púja and the Dashara are the favourite seasons for demonolatry, but whenever the future is to be interrogated a Shaman is hired.

It is a curious instance of the corruption prevailing among Bengali Muhammadans that individuals are found performing at the "Shaikh Sadú-ka-Karáhí," exactly similar antics to those of the Hindu Matwálah.

9. Partiality for pork is an infirmity shared by Kolarian, Dravidian, and low castes in Bengal. The Oráons prefer pork to everything, and their villages swarm with pigs.[2] Even in Menu's days the pig was a domestic animal in India, and a Bráhman was degraded immediately by touching its flesh.[3]

Breeding pigs is an occupation only followed by the very lowest tribes in Bengal; but fondness for its flesh remains long after Hindu influences have taught them to discard other aboriginal customs. The Patní, outcast Bhúinmálí, Dôm, Chamár, and Rishi, not only breed pigs, but eat them. The Bind, Chandál, Dosád, Kahár of Hindustání connections, Kándho, and Kochh Mandái, are still fond of pork; but the Súraj-Vansi, Bengali Kahárs, Karrál, and Baqqál, having assumed the airs of clean Śúdras, renounce any taste for the unclean animal.

The pig being the usual victim sacrificed to Grám-devatas, the eating of its flesh was originally a Kolarian or Dravidian custom, which has been preserved by the semi-Hinduized tribes now found in Bengal.

10. The drinking of rice spirit, Surá, was countenanced by the Vedic Hindus, and the Rámáyana describes several Bacchanalian scenes in which Ráma, and even the gentle Śítá, joined. Krishna denounced intoxication among his Yádava brethren, but the credit of having first enacted a law against it is due to Śukráchárya, preceptor of the Daityas. Menu[4] prohibits

[1] On demonolatry, devil-dancing, and demonical possession, see "Contemporary Review" for February, 1876. In Southern India the "Peyadi" eschews Bháng and other drugs, and is often a woman. In "Lettres Edifiantes," xi, 45, a Jesuit father confesses his belief in the possession.

[2] Dalton, p. 251.

[3] Menu, v, 19.

[4] *Ibid.*, xi, 91, 96.

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Bráhmans from tasting Surá, which is made from the Mala, or filthy refuse, of the grain, or drinking any other inebriating liquor, and mentions eight different kinds of spirits, including Ásava, the most pernicious of all.

Intemperance is not general among Bengali Hindus at the present day, but the consumption of spirituous liquors among certain classes is excessive. In Eastern Bengal many of the three highest castes follow the Tantric ritual, and observe the secret Kaula orgies, which require the drinking of large quantities of coarse spirit. A whole bottle of bázár brandy is often quaffed at a draught on such occasions, and it is reasonable to infer that individuals who can stand such a quantity must prepare themselves by solitary drinking. Intoxication, however, is denounced by the strictest Kaula worshipper, and the effects of their orgies are rarely discovered.[1] It is among the low and semi-Hunduized, tribes that drinking to the extent of insensibility is practised, and to ensure this desirable result, they add Dhatúrá or Bháng, to the spirit. In Bengal all the low castes drink spirits, and at festivals in honour of Grám-devatas intoxication is the usual termination. Low Hindustání castes are more confirmed drunkards than their Bengali fellows, and are not ashamed at being detected in liquor. No Hindu of intemperate habits is excluded from caste privileges as long as he does not cause a scandal; otherwise the Panchá́it is obliged to pass sentence on his conduct. With all low Hindu castes the liquor of the Tál palm,[2] or Tṛiṇa-rájah, the king of grasses, is the favourite stimulant; but when intoxication is desired, bázár, or raw rice, spirit, is preferred.

11. Fetichism. The believer in this superstition fancies that the possession of a fetich of any spirit enables him to make a servant of that spirit; but it must be recollected, as Sir J. Lubbock points out, that an object regarded as a fetich by one person may be an idol to another.

In Bengal Fetichism has become modified, often disguised by contact with the higher Hindu religion, and few will admit that the thing worshipped resembles in any respect the fetich of the African negro. Yet in what other light are we to regard the reversed Ṣankh shell, bought for its weight in gold, and confided in to secure wealth and happiness; or the scarlet seeds of the "Rakta-chandana," employed by the Kíchaka to ensure success, and much plunder; or the hollow siliceous concretions, said to

[1] Further details of the drinking habits of Hindus are to be found in the "J. A. S. of Bengal," xlii, 2.

[2] Sir W. Jones says: "The juice of the Tál is the most seducing and pernicious of vegetable liquors: when just drawn, it is as pleasant as Pouhon water (at Spa), fresh from the spring, and almost equal to the best mild champagne ("Asiatic Res.," iv, 311).

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be petrified grains of rice offered to Vishnu, and extolled by Bráhmans as the safeguard of their holy shrines; or the "Vana-linga" of the Nerbudda? Still more in point is the Sálagráma,[1] or Ammonite, which has been deified, and is worshipped as the special deity of the Brahmanical order, fetching enormous prices according to the fictitious power and virtue ascribed to its varying shapes.

Whatever may be the ideas of the higher ranks, respecting marine curiosities, rare fossils, or strange seeds, there can be no doubt that the care and veneration bestowed on them by the owners tend to support the belief of the lower classes, that they are emblems of the deity embodied in them, and who acts through, or by, them. That any intelligent Bráhman would allow that the Sálagráma is more than an idol is not to be expected, but the Kíchaka admits that he addresses his petitions to the seeds as he would to any sentient being. In fact, the Kíchaka remains in the lower stage of Fetichism, while the Bráhman has risen to a higher belief—that of idolatry and anthropomorphism.

12. In every Hindu village of Eastern Bengal there is a tola, or quarter, consecrated, either to Kálí, Chandí,[2] Shashṭhí, or Siddheṣvarí, to which the villagers repair, either collectively or singly, to present offerings, and propitiate the deity supposed to inflict disease or calamity. Any large stone, or slab, beneath a Pipal, Bat, or Seorhá tree, smeared with red-lead, and moistened with Ghí, or milk, is conceived to represent the guardian deity. The villagers never analyse the motives of this strange worship, but few believe that the god is embodied in the stone. The block is merely regarded by the multitude as the medium through which the god acts, or communicates his will, and for this reason it is always approached, and spoken of, with reverence.

This conception of a guardian deity has been adopted by the Bráhmans. The city of Dacca has an idol, carefully preserved in a holy shrine, called the Dhákeṣvarí, which, like the Trojan Palladium, is revered as a pledge of the safety of the city and its inhabitants. At Patna, again, the tutelary deity is Pataneṣvarí, and in both instances the attendant Bráhmans identify the god with Durgá, or Kálí.

The most popular deity of all low Bengali castes is Deví, Jalka Deví, Bandí, Bana-Durgá, Champa-batí, Mahámáyá, or Parameṣvarí, undoubtedly a goddess of the aboriginal races.

[1] Regarding the varieties of this fossil and the fables grounded on its singular structure, see Ward's "Hindus," iii, 222, and "Lettres Edifiantes" (Edition 1781), xiv, 107–115.

[2] "The Artemis, or immortal huntress, of the Oráons" (Dalton, p. 258).

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She is invoked with bloody sacrifices and libations of blood, and spirits, under shady trees, or at night in the silence and solitude of the forest. A Bráhman never officiates, but one of the company stabs the victim, usually a pig, with a knife, or bamboo spit, and catching the blood in a cup offers it to the dreaded goddess. No doubts are ever entertained regarding the acceptance of the sacrifice, or fears expressed that Deví is dissatisfied with receiving only the spiritual part of the animal, for the victim is at once cut up, roasted, and eaten by the assembled worshippers, while the skin, hoofs, and offal are buried. It is strictly forbidden to leave any of the flesh uneaten, or to carry home a morsel of it. The feast always ends in a liberal consumption of fiery spirits.

Deví is usually invoked in the month of Srávan (July and August), and by many her worship is called the Srávania Púját. It is obvious that this rite, bearing no resemblance to any Bráhmanical ceremony, is a survival of an aboriginal cultus pertaining to those unclean castes which are most unlike the Hindus. By the Ráwats, for instance, Deví is the goddess of the tribe, and to her sacrifices are offered whenever sickness or sorrow overtakes their families.

13. A large and ubiquitous class of beings, included under the generic name of Bhúta, or Bhúta-devatás, identical with the ghosts, banshees, bogeys, and goblins of Western credulity, are worshipped by the superstitious classes of Bengal. They are most numerous in jungly tracts where lofty trees afford shade and silence, or in the sombre valleys of hilly districts. Around Dacca, and in Bikrampúr, where old "Pipal" and "Bat" trees of dense foliage abound, Bhúts are very numerous and very powerful. Others dwell in cities, in ruined temples, in graveyards, in burning ghát, and even in dry wells. They are met with on the arid treeless plain, the flooded river, and the lonely forest glade. The timid recognise their cry in the hooting of the owl, the howling of the jackal, the yelp of the village cur, and the whistle of the plover. One kind of demon, sedentary in its habits, attaches itself to a village, another to a household; some inflict plagues, others blight the opening bud, or convulse the new-born babe. The Bengali sees in every accident the work of evil spirits, and his longing desire is to obtain some means of counteracting their influence. The women are naturally the chief adherents of this superstition, and while engaged in the most commonplace work are ever watchful against the entrance of a devil.

The length that these simple people go in their belief of Bhúts is almost incredible. The mildewed ear of rice, the appearance of wild rice, or of weeds, in the paddy fields, the

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murrain among the cattle, the hail smiting the green crops, the weevil spoiling the mangoes, the shrivelled yellow leaves of the pân garden, are one and all the work of malevolent spirits. Many persons turn this credulity to profit. Mantras, or magical formulæ, are bought from the Ganak Bráhman; copper amulets, containing sentences of the Koran, from the Khwándkár; and charms of various kinds, such as a vertebra, tooth, or scale of a fish, a segment of a bone, a seed, or a bit of wood from the Vairágí. Fields and gardens are protected from the evil eye by a black pot painted with a white cross, having the limbs bent at right angles, and raised on a mound.[1] If hail should threaten to beat down his spring crop the Silarí is summoned to avert the danger.

The peasant, however, is not the only class enslaved by this marvellous belief, for even educated gentlemen, acting under female dictation, call in the aid of magicians to cast out the devil haunting his house, or tormenting his child. Infants and pregnant women are especially subject to the malign influence of a Bhúta; but all convulsive diseases, the delirium of fever, and raving madness, are referred to possession by an evil spirit. In such cases, the Kabíráj, confessing his want of power, makes way for the exorcist, or Ojhá, and magic is substituted for medicine. The Bráhmans, profiting by this grievous superstition, have set apart one day in the year for the worship of the whole host of devils, and have craftily selected a moonless night near the autumnal equinox. The Bhúta-chaturdasí, as this festival is called, falls on the fourteenth of the dark half of Áswin (September and October).

14. By far the more important Grám-devata in Eastern Bengal is Bura-Burí, literally old man and old woman. In some places this deity is identified with Bura-Ṭhákuráin, Bana-Durga, or Siddheṣvari, or Vriddheṣvari, other personifications of that goddess; but according to the Bráhmans Bura-Burí is Mahádeva and Durga.

The annual festival of this rustic divinity is the Paush Sankrant, or last day of that month, corresponding to December and January; but on any occasion of sickness, or trouble, its favour may be invoked. There are several shrines in the Dacca district[2] sacred to Bura-Burí, but whenever Bat and Pipal trees are entwined, or married, as the Hindus say, there is the favourite haunt of the god. The worship ought properly to be

[1] This is the Svastika or mystical cross, of the Buddhists.

[2] "The most ancient and holy spot in Upper Assam is a shrine of Bura-Buri. The most esteemed offering is a white buffalo. ("J. A. S. of Bengal," xvii, 467.)

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held beneath a "Seorhá" tree (*Trophis aspera*[1]), but if not available a branch of it will answer.

At Golá-Kandha, near Sunnárgáon, a very celebrated fair in honour of Bura-Buri is annually held in Paush, at which crowds of Chaṇḍáls, as well as representatives of all Ṣúdra castes, assemble. At Cháchar-tolá, on the banks of the Padma, is a very old shrine, dedicated to this deity, and tended by Ṣrotriyá Bráhmans from Chakra-Ṣála in Chittagong. The sanctuary is a ruined brick building, in which is placed the idol represented by a ghat, or waterpot, on which stands a cocoanut daubed with red-lead. The eyes are of brass, while the protruding tongue is a partially detached portion of the shell. The dense grove around consists of Pipal, Tamarind, and Vakula trees, while over the ruined building hang the branches of Pipal and Bat trees, whose roots, penetrating through the masonry, are steadily disintegrating the walls. Each morning the idol is ornamented with garlands of flowers, while leaves of the Bel tree are heaped on its top, and those falling to the ground are presented to the credulous worshipper, in token of the god's satisfaction. Male goats and buffaloes are the ordinary victims. The Bráhman, or his assistant, decapitates the animal with one sweeping cut of a "dáo," and pours out the blood in front of the sanctuary. The trees of the grove are then sprinkled with the blood, and red-lead daubed on the roots and branches. This horrid practice not only disfigures the trees, but the odour round about is that of the shambles.

All castes from the Bráhman downwards present votive offerings to Bura-Buri, and even Muhammadans occasionally resort thither. Vaishnavas, who cannot take life, bring a kid, which is afterwards set free, as the Bráhman is forbidden to sell it. By Chaṇḍáls, and other low castes, ducks' eggs are offered, and a pig being killed, its blood is caught up, and poured out as a libation before the idol. In Bhowál they afterwards eat the flesh; but in other parts of Bengal, having given up this unholy custom, they allow any one to remove the carcass. When Bráhmans, or Káyaths, sacrifice an animal to Bura-Buri, where there is no established shrine, a servant usually gives the *coup-de-grâce*.

At Shujá'atpúr, on the outskirts of Dacca, a "Pipal" and "Bat" tree intertwined has for generations been a favourite spot at which to make offerings to Bura-Buri, especially after the recovery of children from illness, when the parent dedicates the child's cue, or top-knot, and offers milk, sweetmeats, plantains, and sometimes a cock, to the divinity. Muhammadans

[1] Sanskrit, Ṣákhoṭa. It is also known as Piṣácha-dru, Piṣácha-vṛiksha, or Bhúta-vṛiksha, the tree of the goblins.

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on similar occasions make pilgrimages to the spot, and present offerings.

There can be no doubt that this androgynous deity, worshipped throughout the valley of Assam, and along the banks of the Brahmaputra, has been derived from the aboriginal tribes, and identified by the Bráhmans with Hindu gods. But, not content with this recognition, they even deign to officiate at its shrines.

15. Another tutelary village god is Pancha-nanda, to whom a "Sthán," or shrine, served by Ṣrotriyá Bráhmans, is consecrated at Dacca. It is situated in a quarter of the city called Káyath-ṭolí, and consists of a brick platform with a square pillar at one end from which an iron rod projects, having an oval mass of concrete, stained red, fixed at its point. When a child is six years old, a lock of its hair is offered to the deity, along with rice, sweetmeats, and plantains. The Bráhman being fed, mumbles a short prayer, and the ceremony ends. The object of this worship is the preservation of children from sickness. As thus described, the homage paid to Páncha-nanda differs materially from that observed in former days[1] in Central Bengal, when the blood of sacrifices was required to propitiate the god.

16. Araṇya, or Jamáí, Shashṭhí is the most popular goddess of Bengali women, for her favour is supposed to ensure the health of children, and prevent barrenness. By the Bráhmans she is regarded as an Anṣa, or portion, of Durga, or Kálí. Her festival is held on the sixth of the waxing moon of Jait (May and June). On this day a hole is dug, and a branch of the Bat tree, with its twigs sprinkled with red-lead, curds, and pounded turmeric, is inserted. Around the hole bamboo leaves, tufts of Dúb grass, and flowers, are thickly strewn. A Bráhman then performs the service with oblations of fruits and confections, and expatiates on the benefits to be derived from the adoration of Shashṭhí. Before leaving the spot every woman present sprinkles curds and tumeric on the hallowed branch. At this festival a great fruit fair is held, when large quantities of Makhánna (*Anneslea Spinosa*), mangoes, jack-fruit, cucumbers, berries of the Paniyálá, and drupes of the Palmyra palm, are sold, and many Hindus make it a rule not to eat a mangoe until the Bráhman has been given one on the morning of this day.

Shashṭhí is properly worshipped under a Bat tree, and most villages have one consecrated to her, but the populace do not believe that she is born, lives, and dies, with the tree, like the Dryad of Greek mythology. Each villager as he passes makes obeisance, and refuses to pluck the smallest leaf or twig, for fear of offending the divinity.

[1] Ward's "Hindus," iii, 183.

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The most important ceremony, however, in honour of Shashṭhi is the Chhaṭhí, observed on the sixth day after birth, when Vidhátá,[1] or Brahmá, enters the house, and writes its destiny on the child's forehead. On this occasion two lumps of cowdung are placed at each side of the nursery door, and for fifteen days red-lead is coated over them, and Dúb grass, well moistened, laid on the top.

17. Siddheṣvarí and Vriddheṣvarí, regarded by Bráhmans as Anṣas of Durga, are popular village deities, being worshipped whenever vows are realized, unexpected good fortune occurs, or calamity befalls the village, or a family in it. A monolith, or rudimentary rock, is so very rare in the plains of Bengal, that when met with it inspires both awe and veneration among the superstitious classes, who readily connect it with some god they worship. At Mirzápúr, in Bhowál, an upright slab, called Siddhí Mádhava, is worshipped by all the inhabitants, Muhammadans sacrificing cocks, and Hindus swine. At Sunnárgáon a black basaltic slab, let into a wall, is believed to restore stolen property, if whitewashed, and a few prayers mumbled afterwards. Hindus, however, do not restrict their veneration to big stones, but worship any object remarkable for its size or antiquity. Thus the monster Muhammadan cannon standing in the chauk of Dacca, is supplicated as a male spirit whose consort, another similar piece of ordnance, lies sunk in the river. Any person anxious to obtain a favour has only to stain the muzzle and breech with red-lead, and his wish will be fulfilled.

It is as the village guardians, and family benefactors, that these deities are usually worshipped; but when epidemic diseases break out, causing sickness and mortality in their homes, it is to them that supplication is made. Kálí, at first a Grám-devata of the aboriginal races, has become the Rákhya, or Bhadra Kálí, the protectrix of every Bengali village, to whom prayers and sacrifices are offered on the outbreak of any pestilence. The following incident was witnessed in 1874. At the great Váruṇí fair, cholera appeared, causing many traders and buyers to leave. The zamíndárs, bankers, and other interested parties, accordingly agreed to celebrate a special worship in honour of Kálí, not only to propitiate her, but also in hope of restoring confidence, and of bringing back the deserters. Money being freely subscribed, and professional singers hired, an image of the goddess was paraded throughout the fair, after which an operatic entertainment was given at which crowds of people attended. The cholera, which had been

[1] The angel Jabráíl (Gabriel) acts in the same capacity for Muhammadan children.

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only sporadic, ceased, and the stoppage was attributed to the beneficent Kálí.

Ṣítala, the personification of smallpox, is held in especial honour, for an annual festival, held on the first Chaitra, about the middle of March, is assigned to her, and the Málákárs, who officiate on this day, also worship her whenever a villager sickens with the disease.

Chamárs, however, are singular in not worshipping either Kálí or Ṣítala, in times of sickness. When any febrile disorder appears among them, the women observe a ceremony, called Jar-Jarí, to appease the anger of Jar Asura, who causes fever.

It is to be noticed that none of the above-mentioned Grám-devatas have properly any temples, or special priests. In Bengal it is the caste Bráhman, in Bihár a Chaṭiyá, or Bhakht, who officiates, when required; but it is a recent innovation for a sanctuary to contain the idol, and for Patit Bráhmans to earn a livelihood by tending it. In every instance the stone, slab, or shrine, is placed beneath a tree, or in a grove, consecrated to the particular Grám-devata.

18. The transition to a regular worship of individual trees was a natural development of the same belief. Mr. Fergusson considers that the worship of trees was derived by the Bráhmans from the aboriginal races, and, during the Buddhist supremacy, adopted as one of the most distinctive peculiarities of their creed. When Buddhism was driven out of India, the worship of trees survived, and still flourishes, forming an important part in the daily services of the inhabitants. It is difficult to determine the reasons for the selection of particular trees, or shrubs, and their consecration to certain gods and spirits; but some inherent peculiarity may have influenced the people in their choice. Thus the vitality, beautiful foliage, and quivering leaves of the Pipal, the branches and capillary roots of the Banyan, the fragrant flowers of the Vakula, and the medicinal virtues of the Bela, would naturally impress the simple forest tribes. The Seorhá, sacred to Bura-Buri, being a dioecious plant, would, for this reason, excite wonder and reverence.

The Gujálí, or Ṣál, the favourite tree of the Kochh Mandáí, and Dravidian tribes generally, provides not only the most valuable timber for house-building, but the most perfect shade. The popular belief that a grove of Ṣál proves at certain seasons most unhealthy by causing a deadly fever, was another reason of its being regarded with the deepest veneration. In one instance the Gujálí has acquired an exceptional position in the eyes of the Hindus. At the north end of the great tank of Rámpál stands a tall umbrageous tree, the only one of its kind in that quarter, said to have been planted by the Bráhmans

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from Kanauj. It is not a patriarchial tree, but the two stems now growing are shoots from the parent root. Whenever a Hindu, or Muhammadan, villager obtains his desires, he pours oil on the root, daubs it with red-lead, and passing makes obeisance, touching the earth with his forehead.

It is hard to ascertain what are the precise ideas entertained by Hindus regarding these different trees,[1] but the general prejudice against cutting down, or approaching them after nightfall, indicates the belief that good or evil spirits are embodied there. The Vaṭa, Pipal, and Deva-dáru are the trees usually preferred by the male Brahma-daitya, or Bhúta, as well as by the female Ṣankhiní, or fairy, and Pretní, or bogey. When the large-horned owl is heard hooting from one of these trees it is popularly said to be the shriek of an evil spirit.

It often happens when a pair of these ill-omened birds take possession of a village tree that the villagers become so demoralised, through terror, as not to leave their homes after dark, while the children scream at every sound. It might be thought that birds proving such a nuisance would be shot, but no Hindu is so impious as to do so, and it is left to any passing European to rid them of the birds.

It is a curious fact that one of the latest outgrowths of corrupt Vaishnavism is the veneration for trees. The Darwesh Faqír sect will not permit a leaf, or twig, to be plucked from the trees growing within the Ákháras, although flowers are the ordinary offerings at the tomb of a Mahant.

19. The worship of animals is still extensively observed in Bengal. The cow receives divine honours at least twice a year, on the first of Baisákh, and the second of the moon in Jyeshṭha. The most severe penance is inflicted on any one killing it, even by misadventure; but starvation, ill-treatment, and cruelty go unpunished.

Monkeys of every species are deemed sacred, and may not be killed; but especial honour is paid to the Langúr, or Hanumán (*Presbytis entellus*), although no particular day is assigned for this purpose. The Hanumán of Hindu mythology, represented as a son of the wind, or an incarnation of Váyu, the wind god, is invoked by all sailors and fishermen; and when a calm occurs, the Manjhí, or steersman, shouts "Ai Hanumán!" instead of whistling as the British tar does.

[1] The following are the sacred trees of the Hindus:—

Aṣvattha (Pipal)	*Ficus religiosa.*	Nimba (Ním) ..	*Melia Azadiracta.*
Vaṭa	*Ficus Indica.*	Vilva (Bela) ..	*Aegle marmelos.*
Vakula ..	*Mimusops elengi.*	Tulasí ..	*Ocymum sanctum.*
Harítakí ..	*Terminalia chebula.*	Deva-dáru ..	*Uvaria longifolia.*
Ámalaka ..	*Phyllanthus emblica.*		

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20. It is, however, to Manasa Deví, the dreaded Queen of snakes, that the natives of Bengal pay the most marked respect. To her the whole month of Ṣrávan (July and August) is hallowed, and all classes, from the Bráhman to the Chaṇḍál, adore her. If Mr. Fergusson is correct in his supposition that tree and serpent worship is one of the very earliest known, we have in Bengal at the present day a most perfect and uncorrupted example of this ancient cultus. There is perhaps no class so strict in attending to all the minutiæ of her worship as the Kulina Bráhmans of Bikrampúr. Manasa Deví is usually represented with four arms, grasping a cobra in each hand, with the beautiful, but deadly, Bungarus fasciatus, twisted round her neck, and with her feet resting on a goose. She is regarded as a daughter of Ṣiv—hence one of her titles, Ṣiva Ja—and the husband of Jarat Káru. Two plants, common in Bengal, are sacred to her, the Síj, or *Euphorbia ligularia*, and the Nág-phaní, or *Cactus*[1] *Indicus*. The acrid, milky juice of the former is employed as a cure for snake-bites, and the fleshy joints of the latter bear a striking resemblance to a cobra with expanded hood. The fifth of Ṣrávan is the Nág-panchamí; but the last day of that month, or Sankránt, is dedicated to her. For these fête days the Sámperia, or snake-charmers, are engaged, who make the tame snakes crawl about, and go through the stereotyped performance, before the spot on which the rice, milk, sugar, and fruits are displayed. Where there is a Sthán, or shrine, with an image of the goddess, buffaloes, pigeons, or turtle are sacrificed; but the Chaṇḍáls are singular in proffering swine. No conscientious Hindu ever kills a snake, and it is reckoned very meritorious to place milk and sugar near the hole occupied by a cobra.

21. A people so prone to conceive embodied spirits in trees and animals, naturally endowed with divine attributes the rivers which fertilized their fields, brought grain and firewood, and supplied fish and turtle for their use. Throughout the Delta the Ganga Púja, or worship of the river Ganges, is one of the most popular and ancient observances. The goddess is invoked daily; but the merit of worshipping her is greately enhanced if performed at the full moons of Baisákh, Jyeshṭha, Kártik, and Mágh, and on the thirteenth of the waning moon of Chaitra. Her descent to earth is commemorated on the Dashará, the tenth of the waxing moon of Jyeshṭha (May and June). It is asserted that bathing in the sacred stream has the virtue of conferring blessings such as no imagination can conceive, while the sight, name, or touch of Ganga cleanses from all sin. Formerly barren women made offerings to the goddess, and vowed that if blessed with children one would be cast into the river as a

[1] The *Cactus* was introduced into India by the Portuguese.—Royle.

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thank-offering; but now-a-days, although more humane ideas prevail, the worship has lost none of its reputed efficacy.

The Jal-palaní, or close fishing season, lasting from the first to the tenth of Mágh, was originally a holiday in honour of Ganga; but at present her worship is chiefly observed on the tenth day, when a kid is thrown into the river.

The old Brahmaputra is worshipped with similar veneration, and the great bathing day, the eighth of the waxing moon of Chaitra, attracts many thousands from all parts of Lower Bengal. The bathing Ghát, sanctified by a well-known Puránic myth, is at Nángalbandh. When the moon is in a certain Nakshatra, or lunar mansion, and the eighth of the moon falls on a Friday, immersion at this spot cleanses from every sin.

The most famous festival, however, in Eastern Bengal is that held in honour of Varuṇa, the god of waters, on the full moon of Kártik (October and November), when devout Hindus bathe at the Yoginí Ghát, where formerly the Dhullasari, Lakhya, and Brahmaputra rivers united. The religious ceremony has come to be regarded as merely the formal inauguration of the great fair commencing on that day, to which merchants and dealers from every part of Northern India bring wares and merchandize for sale.

There are other rivers, for instance the Gaṇḍakí and Karatoyá, to which Hindus resort; but the number of pilgrims is yearly decreasing. Other devotees repair to the sacred rivulet flowing from the hill of Sítákhund, in the Chittagong district, or to the adjacent Balwákhund, the "Brahma's burning founts" of *Lalla Rookh*, to atone for heinous sins.

Not satisfied with attributing a divine character to the rivers of their native land, the Hindus have peopled the waters themselves with animistic beings, who protect, or destroy, the unguarded boatmen. Khwájah Khizr and Pír Badr, Muhammadan water spirits, are objects of fear and worship to the Hindus; but the semi-Hinduized tribes have also conceived beings like the Lurline of German romance. The fisher races make sacrifices to one Khala kumárí,[1] a Naiad, who, dwelling in the deep pools and eddies, sucks in boats, and leaves none to tell the tale. The Chamárs, again, have created another Naiad, Jalka Deví, who not only swallows up boats, but inflicts diseases on land.

22. Besides these supernatural beings the natives have placed each trade and profession under the care of a tutelary deity to whom various powers are ascribed. Whenever business is slack, or prices low, the Hindu workman worships his god with similar ceremonies to those paid by the Roman artisan to his divinity, or by the mediæval Christian to his saint. The

[1] Sanskrit, Khala, cruel; kumárí, maiden.

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Káyaths and scribes worship Sarasvatí on the Śrí-panchamí; Gandha Baniks and Modís, Gandheśvarí, a form of Durgá, on the full moon of Baisákh; Sánkhárís, Agastya Muní, on the last day of Bhádra; and Kumárs, Kámárs, and other mechanics, Viśvakarma. The ceremonies observed at these trade festivals bear a striking resemblance to one another. The day, always kept a close holiday, is often preceded, or followed, by one or more idle days. When the service is to be performed, the tools, implements, and machinery, being washed and smeared with red-lead and sandal-wood powder, are heaped in a pyramid, with a lighted lamp in front and oblations composed of garlands and bouquets of flowers, rice, fruit, and sweetmeats arranged on every side. On these occasions the caste Bráhman attends, and having invoked a blessing, receives a trifling fee. The most important of these trade jubilees is the Dhullisari,[1] on the first of Báisákh. It is kept by the Tánti, Dhobí, and Sutár castes, and all who spin, weave, or make use of cotton, and lasts for three days. The goddess is now identified with Durgá; but formerly she was the divinity supplying the water used for bleaching purposes. Her image (pratimána), erected by public subscription, is placed in a quarter of the city called Sútrapúr, and samples of cotton fabrics, as well as a selection of trade implements, being exhibited, are ornamented with fruits and vegetables.

Besides the various ceremonies already mentioned, the agricultural classes practise many superstitious rites to ensure a bountiful harvest, ward off the attacks of insects, mildew, smut, and other parasitic diseases, and protect the fields from hailstones. Of all the rural festivals none is more popular than the Vástu Púja, on the Paush Sánkrant, when three Anśas of Śiv, as they are now called, are worshipped, in the hope of securing seasonable rains and luxuriant crops. On the outskirts of the village a terrace is raised, as the "bedí," or altar, of the officiating priest, around which plantain stems are inserted, and fruits and flowers strewn. On this same day the Chaṇḍáls keep a ceremony peculiar to themselves, and of unknown origin. The village "bedí," usually a permanent structure, is often resorted to by the husbandman anxious about his crops, who, after planting a branch of the Jívala (Odina Wodier), makes offerings of milk, sugar, and rice. Bráhmans also observe a worship called the Vástu Púja when the foundation of a house is dug, or a tank excavated, which appears to be identical with the above.[2]

When the fields are yellow with harvest, in November, a

[1] Either from the river of that name, or from the Sanskrit Dhavala, white, beautiful, and Iśvarí, goddess.

[2] For further information see "J. A. S. of Bengal," xxxix, 199.

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curious procession of peasants may be seen in any agricultural hamlet, carrying a straw figure, inside of which are dead flies, mosquitoes, and a Khaliṣa[1] fish, and led by a man beating a sieve, chanting "Bhála ai, Burá jái; Mashá, Mácchi dúr jái!" which may be translated, "Good come, Evil go; mosquitoes, flies, depart away!"

In other districts of Bengal this revel is known as Alakshmí, or bad luck.

23. In passing from the worship of animals, trees, and rivers to that of the spirits of the dead, we are transported from a primitive to a later belief, and from a conception of simple races to one upon which the attention of the wisest is still engaged. The worship of the Manes is intermediate between that of Bhútas and idolatry. As Sir J. Lubbock points out, in uncivilized societies, when there were no great differences of rank, deceased spirits would indeed scarcely rise beyond the dignity of ghosts; but under a more settled government the ghosts of the great would tend to become gods.[2] The worship of ancestral spirits is one of the oldest phases of Hindu belief, and flourished for ages before it had entered the mind of any one to bestow divine honours on the spirits of the great. Menu regards this worship with especial reverence. An oblation, he says,[3] by Bráhmans to their ancestors transcends an oblation to the deities, because the latter is considered as the opening and completion of the former. Hindus are taught that the soul emancipated from the body becomes a Preta, or ghost, remaining in charge of Yama until the Sráddha, or obsequial ceremonies, are performed, when it ascends to the heaven of the Pitṛís, and reanimating another body, receives the just reward, or punishment, of its former deeds.

The observance of the Sráddha is incumbent on the head of a house, and the yearning of every Hindu is to leave a son who will perform the ceremony necessary to ensure his father's felicity. At the obsequial rite, offerings of cakes, flesh, and other viands, along with libations of water, must in the first instance be presented to the ancestors, and then to the general body of the progenitors, of mankind.[4] On each of the ten days after death, the nearest-of-kin offers an obsequial oblation, and on the Ekádaśí, or eleventh day, a special service is performed at which Bráhmans are feasted. With the Bráhmanical order, this is the purificatory ceremonial; but with the Śúdras, as well as most unclean castes, it is postponed to the thirtieth day,

[1] The *Trichopodus Colisa*.
[2] "Origin of Civilization," p. 339.
[3] Menu, iii, 203.
[4] Wilson's "Religion of the Hindus," ii, 61.

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the latest on which it can be held. The Vaiṣyas of Dacca, however, keep it on the expiration of fourteen days; the Chaṇḍáls, like the Bráhmans, after ten. But there are many varieties of Ṣráddha, the most important, the Sapiṇḍana, being celebrated on the first anniversary of the person's decease. In the last half of Bhádra (August and September), immediately before the Daṣaharáa, the Mahálaya Ṣráddha is annually observed in honour of all the Pitṛís, and many other seasons for the worship of the Manes are fixed by certain astronomical periods and events.

The spirits of Bráhmans at once pass into the heaven of Pitṛís, while those of Ṣúdras and vile castes go through an innumerable series of new births, before arriving at that stage of perfect purity when they become reunited with the world of disembodied spirits. Púrva Janma, or Metempsychosis, is universally accepted without producing any moral restraint on the lives or morals of the people. The two great sects worshipping Ṣiv and Vishnu, or their counterparts, have promulgated the doctrines that observance of the annual festivals, pilgrimages to sacred places, and adoration of Bráhmans, will compensate for sins, however heinous, and release all who practise them from any transmigrations. By this Bráhmanical system Yama has been dethroned, and his authority usurped by the emissaries of Harí and Ṣiv. The uneducated classes draw no distinction between Pretas, or ghosts, and Bhútas, or evil spirits, although the former are properly spirits of the dead, the latter subordinate servants of the gods. If the Ṣráddha has not been properly performed, the Preta haunts the place of death, and, lodging in a tree, or ruined building, eventually becomes a Bhúta, without power or versatility.

The Ṣráddha thus becomes a solemn obligation, and the son, or nearest-of-kin, deems it of paramount importance to discharge all its formalities. The expense of fulfilling this religious duty is often so heavy as to force the son to incur debt and burden the family with liabilities requiring many years of industry to pay off. The detailed bill, given below,[1] was paid by a native

	Rs.	a.	p
[1] Present to Guru Thákur	8	0	0
„ Purohit and assistants	31	0	0
„ officiating Bráhman	12	8	0
Bulls borrowed for the occasion	17	4	0
Goála for ghí, curds, and "khír"	145	0	0
Modí for gur, sugar, and sweetmeats	38	14	9
Rice, dál, and chúrá	15	0	0
Fish and vegetables	7	8	0
To Kumár for pots	3	4	0
To Napít, Dhobá, Bhúinmálí	4	4	0
"Dakshiná" before eating	4	14	3
Miscellaneous	5	15	9
Total .. Rs.	293	8	9

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doctor, earning twenty rupees a month, and who had many poor relatives dependent on him.

24. The veneration paid to Bráhmans, and to the sacred cord they wear, has fortunately died away; but by the masses they are still regarded as men whose lives are passed in meditation and religious exercises, whose blessing is auspicious, and ministration indispensable at every festival and domestic occurrence. The Kulin Bráhmans, being a very exclusive people, generally live in villages apart, while the executive priests reside in the midst of their flocks, and can only be distinguished from the peasantry around by the sacred cord. The people are always civil and obedient to the Kulin Bráhmans; but having few interests in common, their mutual relations are formal and lukewarm. Bráhman landlords are often considerate and liberal to their ryots, although there is a greater gulf between the two than in the case of Ṣúdra landlords.

The Purohit, or domestic priest, rarely an educated man, shares in all the joys and sorrows of his flock, and although sanctimonious is often immoral in character. In spite of these failings he is looked up to by the caste he serves as no other Bráhman is, while disrespect and disobedience are unknown. The Bráhmans of Eastern Bengal, as a class, are addicted to smoking Indian hemp, and to sensuality, vices originating from their idle lives and polygamous laws. But however profligate the Bráhman may be, the Ṣúdras still worship and employ him, as they cannot sever the connection with one who is indispensable. Cringing as is the veneration of the Ṣùdra for his Purohit, it is independence when compared with the grovelling self-abasement of the Vaishnavas in presence of their Gosáin, who is regarded as infallible and incapable of doing any wrong. Still more extravagant is the adoration of a Bráhmaní, or other caste woman, at the impure assemblies of the Ṣákta, and Kiṣori Bhajana sects.

Besides these different classes of Bráhmans, individuals of the sacred order proclaiming a new gospel of salvation every now and then rise up, and win over crowds of credulous people. The following account of one of the best of these enthusiasts, who caused much excitement among the lower classes, is not only interesting but illustrative of the ignorance and gross credulity of the masses. In this instance the character personated, or which has been given by his followers, was previously assumed by his master.

Kálí Kumár Chakravarttí, a Ṣrotriyá Bráhman of Pátabhog, in Bikrampúr, was remarkable, even in his childhood, for his devotion to the god Harí. When six years old, Padma Lochana Ṭhákur, a Bráhman of Farrídpúr, reputed to be an incarnation

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of Harí, visited Pátabhog, and at a private interview is said to have imparted a special mystical power to the boy. When old enough, Kálí Kumár became a clerk in the banking house of one Bhakta Podár, and while filling this lowly office, announced that through the favour of Harí, he could perform miracles, such as cooking food without fire, and transforming a ball of clay into sugar. His fame gradually spread, and the villagers credited him with the power of curing the sick. His success in treating female disorders was most striking, and the credit of miraculously curing the wife of a rich Tálukdár was bruited throughout the country. Shortly afterwards Kálí Kumár relinquished his humble calling, and became manager of the Tálukdár's property. Mádhava Nág, and his wife, treated him as their son, lodging him in their own home. Gradually rising in reputation he is now looked up to as the most holy person in Bikrampúr, being worshipped by thousands as the real Harí. By the peasantry he is known as the Bara, while his deputy is called the Chhoṭá, Harí. He does not claim any special authority over diseases, but teaches that unfaltering faith in Harí, and continued prayers, will certainly ensure recovery from the most desperate illness. Bathing thrice a day, and avoiding certain heating articles of food are minor ordinances. Sometimes he varies the treatment by picking up a handful of earth, and ordering the patient to rub his body with it before bathing. In 1873 Kálí Kumár made the pilgrimage to Jaganáth, when nearly three hundred persons voluntarily accompanied him, and in turn ministered to his wants. In 1874, on the Paush Sankránt and Śrí Panchamí festivals, as many as twenty thousand persons, chiefly women, of the lower classes, assembled at his residence at Rájnagar to worship him; while, during the rains, as many as a hundred and fifty boats were to be seen moored off his ghát. The higher, as well as the lower, castes apply to him for medical advice, the former only when the Kabíráj and English doctor have failed to give relief. It is said that from lack of faith in Harí, and doubts regarding the sacred character of Kálí Kumár, the higher castes derive less benefit from a visit to the holy man of Rájnagar, than peasants and artisans do. Kálí Kumár always denies that he is a god, and rebukes those who address him as one; but the multitude persist in their belief. Fees are never exacted from the pilgrims, but they are recommended to evince their faith by buying Batásá, and other sweetmeats, for the poorer brethren. When his daughter married, he declined to accept a present of one thousand rupees collected for her by a subscription, limited to one rupee.

A character such as this is difficult to understand. Although

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no pecuniary gain is derived from his teaching, all his wants are anticipated, and he has found a comfortable home supplied with every necessary. It is hard to stigmatise Kálí Kumár as an impostor, for, however absurd his treatment of disease, the faith in Harí that he inculcates is a great advance on the idolatry and demonolatry of the lower castes. We may regret the possibility of such men thriving, and being worshipped as divine beings; but the improvement he has effected excites the hope that others, announcing a higher creed, will soon spring up, and sweep away men like Kálí Kumár Chakravarttí.

The list of superstitious rites practised by the inhabitants of Bengal, and derived from aboriginal races, might be indefinitely extended, for there are no bounds to the credulity of the ignorant. It is remarkable, however, that neither the worship of Grám-devatas, nor the offering of bloody sacrifices to evil spirits, debar the worshipper from participation in the religious observances of his caste. Toleration has gone so far that even the Purohit countenances many of these rude ceremonies, although at others the suppliant officiates himself. Among a few of the very lowest tribes evil spirits are the only divinities, but by the large majority of the population they are considered subordinate to the gods of the Hindu Pantheon. It is here that the non-Aryan impress has been so deeply written on the religion of the people. It was not by ignoring, but by blending the popular belief with their own, that the Bráhmans spread their influence and authority, and laid the foundation of that strange and corrupt faith now professed by the Hindus of Bengal. The village gods, the spirits of land and water, the Dryad of the forest, and the queen of snakes, were too deeply stamped on the inmost feelings of the aborigines to be easily effaced, and it was a far-sighted policy to recognise a Hindu deity in every village god, and Kálí in every guardian spirit.

It is not to be inferred, however, that the masses in Bengal are not Hindu in religion.

The religion taught by the Bráhmans is the modern phase of their belief, but it has not taken so deep root as to stifle all affection for the older forms. The large majority of the Śúdras and working classes have embraced the Kṛishna Mantra, or creed, which affirms that Kṛishna is the one omnipotent god; but the Bráhmans, Vaidyás, and Káyaths are enrolled under the banner of Śiv, or of his Śáktís.

Without entering into the controversy as to the date when Vishnu, Śiv, and the gods of the Hindu Pantheon were introduced into India, it may be stated, without arousing any difference of opinion, that for at least eight hundred years a perpetual warfare has been maintained between the followers of

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Vishnu on the one hand and of Ṣiv on the other. Professor Wilson was of opinion that none of the present popular religions of India assumed their actual state earlier than the time of Ṣankara Áchárya, in the eighth or ninth century, and it is certain the great Vaishnava teachers lived in a comparatively modern age. Rámánuja dates from the twelfth century, Mádhava-áchárya from the thirteenth, and Vallabha-áchárya from the sixteenth. It is in the Puráṇas which followed, or accompanied, the teachings of these masters, that the bitter rivalry between the followers of Vishnu and Ṣiv is set forth. In the Vishnu Puráṇa, Vishnu is the Param-eṣvara; in the Linga and Ṣaiva Puráṇas generally, Ṣiv is the one Supreme God. In the still more modern Brahma-Vaivartta Puráṇa Kṛishna becomes pre-eminent.

Vishnu, in one or other of his various forms, is the most popular god in Bengal. In his Avatára, or incarnation, of Ráma, and more frequently in that of Kṛishna, the divine herdsman, he is adored by millions of Hindus. All the most popular festivals, all the most venerated shrines, and all the most honoured fraternities are his. In 1811, Ward[1] estimated the followers of Vishnu in Bengal at five-sixteenths of the Hindus. In 1828, H. H. Wilson calculated[2] them at one-fifth, and in 1872 Dr. Hunter[3] at from one-fifth to one-third of the whole Hindu population. No image of Vishnu is now-a-days called by his name, but the Vishnu-pada, or footprint, is still adored at Gayá, and is the ordinary relic in all temples of Kṛishna.

A carefully prepared list of 384 temples and shrines in the Dacca district shows that—

227 were sacred to Kṛishna, as Harí, Giri-dhárí, Ṣrídhara, Vásudeva, Dámodara, or Lakshmi Náráyaṇa.
16 to Rádhá-Mádhava, Rádhá-Vallabha or Rádhá-Ramaṇa.
33 to Mahápraḅhu Chaitanya.
6 to Vishnu as Viṣvambhara, Ṣárnga-dhara, Jagad-dhátṛi, or Rája Rájeṣvara.
2 Ráma-Ṣíta.
2 Balaráma.
39 to Kálí.
38 to Mahádeva, or Ṣiv.
6 to Durga as Daṣa-bhujá, or Anna-púrna.
3 to Manasa Deví.
12 to Siddheṣvari, Nityánanda, Trináth, and Samádhi.

[1] Ward's "Hindus," iii, 469. At p. 259 he computes them at a half of the Hindus.
[2] "Religious Sects," i, 152.
[3] "Orissa," i, 114.

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Seventy-four per cent. belong to Kṛishna in one or other of his numerous forms, and only twenty-one per cent. to Kálí, Durga, and Ṣiv.

It is owing to the Bhágavat Puráṇa, compiled in the twelfth century,[1] that Kṛishna has become the popular deity in Bengal. This celebrated work, translated into every language of India, is still one of the authorities most valued by all Vaishnavas. The form of Kṛishna worship instituted by Chaitanya and his successors is now predominant. Since his death in 1528 Chaitanya has been identified with Kṛishna, and this deification has been ratified by the Charitámṛita, written thirty years after his death. The moral and tolerant doctrines of this national teacher penetrated the hearts of the people, and roused an enthusiastic spirit that has unfortunately driven many into strange and perilous wanderings. Among the pure Ṣúdras there is less deviation from the original creed than among the lower mixed classes, who have always been neglected. The religious sentiments of the latter, instead of being properly guided, have been left to develop as fancy, or bias, disposed them. Whether this be a satisfactory explanation or not, it is certain that the corrupt, often immoral, sects now existing are chiefly patronised by the lower and most ignorant classes of the community. The equality of all men, a doctrine preached by Chaitanya, but repudiated by the Gosáins, has been restored by most of the later offshoots of Vaishnavism, and with them no distinction conferred by birth, wealth, or prescription, is ever recognised.

The principal Vaishnava sects in Eastern Bengal are eleven in number. Three are met with throughout India, namely, the Rámánuja, Rámavat, and Nímávat, but the eight following are peculiar to Bengal:—

1. Vaishnava.
2. Báyan-Kaupína.
3. Kiṣorí-Bhajana.
4. Jagat-Mohaní.
5. Spashṭa-Dáyaka.
6. Kaví-Indra Parivára.
7. Báolá.
8. Darwesh-Faqír.

The Kiṣorí-Bhajana and Spashṭa-Dáyaka were founded by fallen Bráhmans, the Jagat-Mohaní by a fisherman, the Kaví-Indra Parivára by a Ṣudra, the Báolá by a Chaṇḍál peasant, and the Darwesh-Faqír by a Karmakár. It is remarkable that the Báyan-Kaupína, Kaví-Indra Parivára, and Spashṭa-Dáyaka have sprung from trivial, but, in the eyes of the Vaishnavas,

[1] Wilson's "Vishnu Puráṇa," xxxi.

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significant acts of the Guru, or spiritual leader. Until more precise information is obtained regarding the peculiar doctrines of these Vaishnava offshoots, it is impossible to explain how sects, originating from such trifling blunders, can survive and attract disciples. The Kaví-Indra Parivára sect includes many intelligent merchants who doubtless are pleased to belong to a religious body, rejecting celibacy and seclusion from the world; but it is not apparent what greater attraction it holds out than the primitive Vaishnava belief. The reason assigned for the existence of the Darwesh-Faqír order is that it admits any outcast, even a Muhammadan, into communion. It claims to be Vaishnava, and to follow the teaching of the Charitámṛita, but judging by the habits of the Udásís their chief peculiarities are love of dirt and avoidance of cleanliness, partiality for spirits and the encouragement of that vice in others, and refraining from shedding blood, or injuring vegetable life.

The Vaishnava orders of Hindustan repel the religious classes of Bengal, who support but do not join them. The Rámánuja, Rámavat, and Nímávat fraternities choose disciples of Hindustání birth and high caste. The Rámánuja profess to admit Bráhman, Kshatriyá, and clean Śúdra tribes; the Rámavat exclude all Bengali castes, but enroll Hindustání Śúdras; and the Nímávat, rejecting even Kulin Bráhmans, enlist any clean Śúdra of Upper India. Mendicants belonging to these three classes are treated everywhere with respect, and receive alms from all ranks. The Dacca Rámavats, moreover, are entirely supported by rich Bengali gentlemen, and their Ákhárá is repaired by contributions raised by the Hindu population. Yet none of these orders have any hold on the affections of the masses, or any influence over their spiritual lives.

RÁMÁNUJAS.

The Rámánujas, or Śrí Sampradáyís, are not numerous in Bengal, and in Dacca have only one monastery, called the Urdú Ákhárá, from the quarter of the city where it is situated, or Śárngár Śthán, from the particular deity to whom it is consecrated. The Mahant, Rám Prasád Dás Pandit, is a Kanaujiya Bráhman of Benares, who, while studying with his Guru at Murshídábád in 1864, was deputed to supervise the Dacca establishment. He exercises a general control over all Rámavat Ákhárás in and around Dacca, and rightfully claims to be the Guru of that sect.

The Urdú Ákhárá is endowed with landed property yielding

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about four hundred rupees a year. It was founded in the seventeenth century by one Manasa Rám, and the sanctuary was dedicated to Ṣárnga-dhara, or Vishnu the archer, but it now possesses images of Baldev or Balaráma, Govinda Dev or Kṛishna, Rámá, and Jagannáth. The Ákhárá is a curious storied building, resembling in many respects the private residence of a rich Hindu. The sanctuary, reached by a steep staircase, forms one side of an arcaded court, remarkable for its cleanliness and good order. The pillars and walls, overlaid with the beautiful cement of the Mughal period, are disfigured by hideous paintings of Hanumán and his devilish crew, while the arcades are ornamented with more refined portraits of Hindu deities from Jaipúr in Rájputana. The whole place is pervaded by an air of peace and tranquillity, accompaniments rarely found in a home of Indian devotees.

The Rámánuja sect comprises three grades of disciples—the Brahmáchárya, Upakurvváṇa, and Naishṭhika. A novice must undergo a probation of six months before he can be initiated, and he must either be a Bráhman, Kshatriyá, or Vaiṣya, no Ṣúdra ever being admitted to full privileges. A religious student beginning to read the Vedas is styled Brahmáchárya, and prohibited from shaving, paring the nails, or taking any thought of the body. He may continue in this probationary stage for life, or until he masters the doctrines of the sect; but when the period of pupilage is terminated, he may marry. The birth of a son, however, obliges him to leave his home and become a Vánaprastha, or dweller in the forest, passing an austere and solitary life, only broken by an occasional visit to his Guru. It can readily be imagined that a cheerless life like this has scarcely any attractions for the multitude, and it is an undoubted fact that many who have professed "to observe through life the practice of study, poverty, and continence," have joined the ranks of the vagrant and disreputable bands of mendicants roving over the length and breadth of India. Should he wish to enter upon the higher life the Brahmáchárya either becomes a Naishṭhika, one practising asceticism till death, or an Upakurvváṇa, one who lives the cenobitical life of an Udásí in the house of his Guru, and continues the study of the Vedas.

At the Dacca Ákhárá the disciple is marked at the initiatory rite[1] with the Ṣankha of Vishnu on the left shoulder, and with the Chakra on the right. The stamp is made of eight metals (Ashṭa-dhátu), gold, silver, copper, brass, tin, lead, iron, and zinc (dastá); but the Dwáraka stamp is said to be an iron one.

The Rámánujas are most punctilious about the privacy of

[1] Called Tapta-mudrá.

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their meals, and should any one see or speak to them while so engaged, the food is either thrown away or buried. At meals, silken or woollen garments, never cotton, must be worn, and no one can taste anything without permission of the Guru. They will only eat food cooked by a Bráhman of their own sect, but do not reject articles prepared with "ghí" by a Rámávat. The Rámávat, again, takes rice cooked by any Rámánuja, or by any other Rámávat, whether he be by caste a Bráhman, Kshatriyá, or Vaiṣya. A Rámánuja will not drink from the water-vessel of a Bengali Kulina Bráhman, and, although the latter is a member of the sect, will not touch food cooked by him. The Rámánujas are more respectable, and more respected, than the Rámávats, never stupefying themselves with gánjha like the latter.

In Dacca it is computed that there are about twenty Gṛihí, or domestic Brahmácháryas, and twenty-five vagrant ones, who roam from one shrine of Vishnu to another, living on the alms of the charitable.

RÁMÁVAT.[1]

This is essentially a Hindustání sect, no native of Bengal being admitted into its ranks, although its Ákháṛás are wholly supported by the contributions of rich Bengali families. As a rule the Rámávats are recruited from among the Kanaujiya Bráhmans, but other castes are occasionally received into religious communion, it remaining optional with any one to decline eating with them. At a casual visit to a Rámávat Ákháṛá sixteen men and one Bráhmaní woman were interrogated, when thirteen men were found to be Hindustání Bráhmans; one a Sannyásí, and probably a Bráhman; one an Uriya Chhatrí, and one an Ahír. Women are sometimes inducted, and treated as sisters, but should any glaring immorality be detected the sinners are expelled.

The largest and most frequented Rámávat Akháṛá in Dacca, called Lál Bihárí, after one of the names of Kṛishná, has for thirty years been ruled by Har Bhojan Dás, a Kanaujiya Bráhman from Ayodhyá, the disciple of a former Mahant, who when dying bestowed "Upadeṣa," or religious initiation, on this his chosen successor. Another popular Ákháṛá, known as "Ṣama Sundara," or Kṛishna, has as its Mahant a Kanaujiya Bráhman, whose "chela," or disciple, is a Bráhman of Faizábád.

[1] Regarding the peculiar doctrines of the Rámávats, see Wilson's "Religion of the Hindus," vol. i, 46–68.

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The founder of this sect was Rámánand, the disciple of the still more famous Rámanuja, who lived towards the end of the fourteenth century of our era. Notwithstanding that discipline is stricter in this than in sects of Bengali origin, the Mahant is not worshipped, but only obeyed and respected as a holy man, while adoration is paid to Vishnu, or Rámá-Chandra, alone. He is the patron god of the Rámávat community, but his worship has in some instances been supplanted by that of Harí, who is identified with Kṛishna.

There are different grades among Rámávats, the most austere being the "Tapási,[1] erroneously styled Jogís; Ashmen, the early English travellers happily called them. They wander throughout India almost naked, smeared over with ashes, and stupefied with gánjha, refusing to bend the knee before any idol, or any potentate, or to accept lodgings; but residing under a tree, in ruins, or among tombs—wherever, indeed, shelter is afforded, and a prospect of food invites them.

The majority of the sect call themselves Rámávat Sádhu, or ascetics, who, in Bengal at least, dress in questionable taste, at the most wearing a rope round the waist, and a cloth of scanty dimensions round the loins. A few shave the head and beard, but the greatest number cherish a profusion of long tangled locks rolled round the head like a turban, or wound in coils and tied in a large knot over the left ear.

Celibacy is strictly enjoined, but there are no more dissolute and licentious rogues to be met with, even in Bengal, than these ascetics. Aspirants for admission into the society have to undergo a period of probation, the Mahant, who alone can initiate, first satisfying himself of their sincerity and worthiness; but after admission the novice may allow his passions to run riot, if he does not publicly scandalise his brethren. At initiation the new convert is enrolled in a gotra, called "Aichittra,"[2] to which all Rámávats belong.

Rámávats are generally very illiterate, and can seldom read or write. Certain of them falter through a Nágarí book, but few understand what they read. The rule of the sect is contained in the pages of the Rámáyana, the Ṣrí Bhágavat, and the Bhágavat-gítá. Bríndában is the headquarters of Rámávats worshipping Kṛishna; Ayodhyá of those adoring Ráma.

The chief aim of the Rámávats is the conclusion of a pilgrimage to all the holy shrines of India. From Dwáraká to Ṣítá-Khund, in Chittagong, and from Gangútrí to Rámeṣvara, the enthusiast wanders without fear, picking up an uncertain meal from any random traveller. Gánjha is their chief solace,

[1] From the Sanskrit Tapas, penance.
[2] Perhaps Ahi-jit, a name of Kṛishna.

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and it is surprising with what impunity they smoke it in their journeyings, and when stationary in their Ákhárás. If, as is generally believed, Indian hemp induces insanity, it is strange that a Rámávat is rarely admitted into a lunatic asylum. Natives addicted to its use maintain that if abundance of highly nutritious food be taken at the same time, gánjha may be smoked with perfect safety for years. There seem to be grounds for this assertion, and if care be taken to regulate the quantity consumed to the daily food, no bad effects are produced. The Rámávat is usually fuddled, but this state is regarded as religious abstraction; and gánjha, according to him, by stimulating the imaginative faculties, and determining the ideas, fixes them on the god he is always contemplating. As with the Vaishnavas his highest ambition is to feel for Rámá a sensual and emotional desire, which it is the peculiar property of gánjha to impart. He therefore regards the smoking of the weed as an imperative duty, enabling him to abandon the world and its pleasures, and to live in continuous ecstatic contemplation of the deity.

The ordinary diet of a Sádhu consists of the following articles: —

Milk, 4 lbs.
Aṭá (wheat flour), 1½ lb.
Ghí (butter) 4 ounces.
Vegetables and fruit, *ad libitum*.

On this diet he can safely smoke five pipes of gánjha a day, and five at night, the quantity taken with each depending on the taste and nerves of the smoker, but a quarter of a tolá, or forty-five grains, is the average portion.

The ecstatic state is by these ascetics designated "Khiyál," a dreamy, sensual reverie, in which the emotional affections predominate; or "Ánanda," in which the mind is quiescent, and the devotee enjoys enchanting peace, and perfect resignation.

As with the Vaishnavas all forms of adoration, beyond the unceasing repetition of the name Ráma, or Harí, are deemed useless; but in every Ákháṛá there is an idol tended at regular hours, when Ṣankh shells are blown, and gongs sounded, while offerings of flowers and fruit are presented by the laity. Besides, in the courtyard there is usually a Tulasí plant, which is carefully cherished, and in the sanctuary a Ṣálagrám, sharing equal adoration with the idol.

The abstractions of the Sádhus are often so prolonged as to necessitate the use of a bamboo crutch (báns-ka-kúbṛí). Their necklaces, made of Rudráksha wood (*Eleaeocarpus ganitrus*), must consist of seventeen, nineteen, twenty-one, fifty-four, or a hundred and eight beads.

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NÍMÁVAT.

This religious sect, one of the four primary divisions of the Vaishnava faith, has always been unpopular in Eastern Bengal, although it was formerly believed[1] to be the most numerous of the Vaishnava sects in Bengal, "with the exception of those which may be considered the indigenous offspring of that province."

In Dacca two Ákhárás are still open; one, situated at Háthí-ghát, is about eighty years old. The first Mahant was one Balarám, a Hindustání Bráhman, the fourth in descent from whom is the present Mahant, Har-dev Dás, and Adh-Gaur Bráhman from Mírat. The other Ákhárá, in Chaudharí Bazár, was built by one Krishná Moní Bairáganí, about twenty years ago.

This sect has few characteristics beyond its name, and the sectarial mark consisting of a circular black patch between two parallel yellow streaks.

In Dacca there are no Grihasthas, or secular members, and only four Viraktas, or cenobitical. Disciples are not enrolled from among Bengalis, the Kulin Bráhman even being rejected; but any Hindustání Bráhman, or clean Súdra, is admitted. The Nímávats regard Mathurá and Jaipúr as the most sacred places of pilgrimage, and the Bhágavat as the chief religious book. Nágarí is generally understood, but Sanskrit is unknown. The chief occupation of the Viraktas is the preparation of "Bhog," or food for the idols, consisting of rice and pulse boiled together (Khichrí), which is offered four times daily. After being presented, and prayers said, it is eaten by the Mahant and his disciples. The idols in the Ákhárás are Jagannáth, Madana Gopála, Rádhá-Krishna, Balaráma, and Subhadra, the sister of Krishná.

VAISHNAVAS.

In February, 1485, during the reign of Jaláluddín Fath Sháh, was born Nimái, the son of Jagannáth Misra, a Vaidika Bráhman of Silhet, and of Sachi his wife. His birth was preceded by many marvellous signs, while his infancy and boyhood were distinguished by events which portended his future eminence.

When twenty-four years old, he left his young wife, became a Vairági, and assumed the name of Chaitanya. He visited the sacred shrines of Mathurá and Brindában, where, by constant meditation on the adorable Krishna, he became subject to ecstatic visions, or fits of love, "Prema-pralápa," which eventu-

[1] Wilson's "Religious Sects of the Hindus," vol. i, 152.

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ally deranged his reason. From Mathurá he returned to Bengal, and after a short stay, proceeded on a pilgrimage to Kaṭak and Rámeṣvara, in the south of India. He finally settled at Kaṭak, where he died childless at the early age of forty-three.

The most devoted and most famous of his followers were Nityánanda of Nadiyá, and Advayánanda of Ṣántipúr on the Hughli.

The teaching of Chaitanya marks an era in the religious history of Bengal, and at the present day the large majority of the artisan and agricultural classes worship him as an incarnation of Vishnu under the names of Mahá-prabhu, the great teacher, and Gaur-Harí.

The spread of the religious doctrines of this reformer was rapid, many causes combining to favour it. Their simplicity, their virtual agreement with the religious ideas then prevalent in Bengal, the zeal and enthusiasm of the first missionaries, and the boundless credulity of the people, are the chief causes assigned by an able writer.[1] But the unsettled state of the province, the constant wars and civil commotions excited by rival Muhammadan races and factions, left the Hindu population at liberty to follow their own religious aspirations. During the forty-three years of Chaitanya's life, seven kings, of whom four were Abyssinian slaves, sat on the throne of Bengal.

For many generations the Bráhmans had left the masses uncared for, and without any national faith, save that of the terrible Ṣiv, his hateful consort, and a host of malevolent beings, haunting every glade, thicket, and river. Contumely and disdain were the prerogatives of the priesthood; submission and resignation of the timorous people. Under this tyranny the land groaned for centuries, but at last a glimmer broke in upon the thick darkness, foretelling the advent of a brighter and happier future. Chaitanya stirred the hearts of the people by his impassioned preaching, awakened new conceptions and desires, and proclaimed that all men were equal in the eyes of God; that the same One who made the Chaṇḍál made the Bráhman; and that philanthropy was the mainspring of society, the renovator of national life. He farther taught that caste was a fetter on social advancement, and the religion of the Bráhmans a stumbling-block to his countrymen. This blow levelled against caste had temporary effect, and for many years after Chaitanya's death no distinctions of race or colour were, it is said, permitted within the Vaishnava pale. As enthusiasm, however, declined, differences of birth and occupation were again recognised, and now caste prejudices are almost as deeply rooted among the Vaishnavas as with the worshippers of Ṣiv.

[1] "Calcutta Review," vol. xv, 1851.

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The chief novelty in the teaching of Chaitanya was Bhakti, or loving faith, a new element in Hinduism. The Vedantic philosophers had taught that in the knowledge of God consisted the only hope of deliverance from the bondage of sin; but, according to the new truth, those who believed in Kṛishna, who prayed to him without ceasing, and who reposed their whole confidence on him, were more secure of endless felicity than the master of all sciences and all philosophies.

Such was the gospel of the Silhet reformer. By the addition of many mystical and sensual interpretations, later ages have corrupted much that was ennobling and moral.

The text-book of the Vaishnavas is the "Chaitanya Charitámṛita" of Kṛishna Dás,[1] written in Bengali, and interspersed with quotations from the earlier works, "Śrí Bhágavat" and "Bhágavat-gíta." According to this work there are five stages of Bhakti, the higher, as with the Çúfís, being only attained by a few privileged individuals, after prolonged austerities and mortifications.

The five stages are:—

1. Śánta, or quietism, in which the Vaishnava enjoys perfect contentment and peace of mind, ever dwelling on the happiness of his lot, and grateful to Harí for his mercy.
2. Dásya, or the relation existing between a master and his purchased slave. In this stage the Vaishnava practises self-denial, dedicating his whole energies and thoughts to the honour of his god.
3. Sákhya, or friendship. Arriving at this stage the disciple worships Chaitanya as his bosom friend, and regards his own soul as an emanation from and a particle of the Paramátman, or supreme spirit.
4. Vátsalya, or affection towards offspring. In this stage the Vaishnava looks up to God, not as the common Father of all, but as his own father, to whom he is united by the natural bonds of affection, as subsist between a son and his earthly parent.
5. Mádhuriya, literally sweetness, the "efflorescence of Bhakti," as it has been named. In this, the highest and most exquisite condition, the disciple glows with the same uncontrollable desire that Kṛishna felt for the absent Rádha.

The introduction of this last grade of religious fervour has destroyed the moral influence of the creed by sanctifying, as it undoubtedly has done, immorality and gross sensuality. The

[1] Kṛishna Dás Kabíráj, a Baidyá by caste, wrote this synopsis A.D. 1557.

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pure and elevating principles of Chaitanya have been lost sight of, and at the present day the male and female mendicants of this popular sect are notorious for their profligacy and moral depravity.

When Chaitanya died, his most enthusiastic disciples formed a society, consisting, it is said, of six Gosáins,[1] eight Kabírájs, and sixty-four Mahants, by whom the sect was organised, and a staff of assistants established in every district and town of Bengal. Their successors disseminated the Vaishnava creed throughout the province, and, penetrating among the wild tribes of the forest, converted many.

The highest rank in the hierarchy is that of the Gosáins, who are Bráhmans by caste, and claiming to be descendants of the six original Gosáins, the immediate successors of the Mahá-prabhu.

For many generations the three great centres of Vaishnavism have been Khardah, between Calcutta and Barrackpúr; Ṣántipúr in Nadiyá, on the Bhágírathi; and Saidábád in the Murshídábád district. The first is the residence of the Gosáins, tracing their descent from Nityánanda; the second, of the children of Advayánanda; while the third is the home of a family who became Gosáins at a later date, as related in the following story.

Ganga Náráyana Áchárya and Ráma Kiṣora Chakravarttí were Gosáins, the former being a disciple of a Káyasth. When the Káyasth died, the Bráhmans refused to permit the body to be buried. The disconsolate widow prayed to the deceased Guru, claiming his interference. His spirit appeared, and commanded her to summon all the recusant Bráhmans to a meeting, at which, after a long and excited discussion, the spirit asked if any one present could produce the four threads of gold, silver, copper, and cotton, which were used to make the sacred cord. No one was able, so the spirit produced them. The Bráhmans, satisfied of his identity, confessed that he was entitled, though a Káyasth, to be venerated as a Guru, and his disciple to receive the same funeral rites at his death as a Bráhman, the pupil of a legitimate Gosáin.

Gosáins are hereditary leaders of the sect. They are married men, generally wealthy, their temples having been enriched by the munificence of the Hindu laity, and their revenue further increased by the contributions of millions of disciples, and by the inheritance of all property left by Bairágís. They are also prosperous traders and money-lenders. Bráhmans view them with contempt, a Kulin family being dishonoured by giving one a daughter in marriage.

[1] Sanskrit, Go-svámi, a religious mendicant, an honorary title.

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The Vaishnavas have had it revealed that Chaitanya was an incarnation of Vishnu, Nityánanda of Balaráma, the brother of Krishna, and Advayánanda of Mahádeva; and, futhermore, that the first assumed the rank of a Vaidika Bráhman, the second of a Rárhi, and the third of a Varendra.

The adoration paid to the heaven-born Gosáin, or Guru, is regarded as the essence of Vaishnavism, and differs in no respect from that offered to God Himself. The votaries, by surrendering themselves and all they possess, not only identify the Gosáin with the deity, but honour him as one possessed of more authority than Krishna himself. He is further venerated as being inherently a pure and exalted personage, unsullied by the vices in which he always freely indulges. Implicit faith in him, and incessant devotion, are the arms with which the Vaishnava has to wage war against the world and its temptations; and he is taught that, successfully overcoming all his enemies, he will at last enter upon that stage of Mádhuriya, for the attainment of which all true Vaishnavas maintain a life-long struggle.

The slavish adoration of the Gosáin, however, formed no part of Chaitanya's teaching, which inculcated that God was all in all, while the Gosáin was only the spiritual father[1] of his flock. The modern sentiment, copied from the Bráhmanical system, and probably adopted when the Gosáins had secured their hold over the people, is firmly believed in by millions at the present day, and the influence that they wield is as strong as that of the Jesuit priesthood.

The inferior agency that spreads and supports the peculiar doctrines of the sect is the Ádhikárí, or superintendent, who acts as deputy, initiates disciples within a certain circle, and collects fees. Under him are Faujdárs, whose business is the enlistment of proselytes, and whose activity is stimulated by a percentage of the subscriptions. Lastly, comes the Chharí-dár, or usher of the rod, who is merely the messenger of the Faujdár.

The Gosáin, or his deputy, bestows the Mantra,[2] or sacred word, on the laíty. Any disciple, however, can confer Bhek,[3]

[1] The Gosáin is generally styled Báp, father; the Faujdár Kuru, or uncle, from Bengali, Khurá.

[2] The Mantra is usually a monosyllable, a name, or attribute, of a god, or goddess. It is taken by both Vaishmavas and Śáktas, and certain religious ceremonies are always observed on that occasion. The Mantra must never be divulged to any one.

[3] The word Bhek is synonymous with the Sanskrit Bhek-lava and Víkshagraha-na, and is analogous to the Bhikshuka, or fourth Áśrama of religious life. Bhek is probably a corruption of Víksha, sight. In this stage of life the votary rightly adopts the garb of a mendicant, retires from the world, and subsists on the charity of strangers.

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an introductory ceremony peculiar to the Vaishnavas. No member can aspire to any stage of faith, or secure salvation after death, without the Mantra. The Bhek, on the other hand, is taken by those who resolve to spend a life of poverty and trial, without ties, and with few restraints, and is given to men, women, and boys over ten years of age. At this ceremonial, a new piece of cloth is wrapped round the waist of the neophyte, a "Kaupína" is triced between the legs, a stick, or switch, placed in his hands, a beggar's wallet given him to carry, and a necklace (mála) hung round his neck.

As is the case with other Hindu sects, the Vaishnava laity is divided into two great classes, the Gṛihi Vaishnavas, or Boistubs, as they are popularly called, and Bairágís. The former marry and live as their neighbours; the Gosáins, and the large majority of the sect, belong to this division. The dead are burned, but the bodies of Gosáins are always buried. Bairágís are mendicants, usually living in celibacy, but often adopting a Bairágan, or sister, who is in reality a concubine. The bodies of Bairágís are either burned, buried, or cast into a river; but if the relatives be rich, or if the deceased has attracted disciples, the corpse is interred, and an Ákhára built over his grave. A Bairágí may marry, but it is deemed highly meritorious to lead a celibate life, avoiding all connection with women. On obtaining permission to marry he is known as a Sam-yogí, becoming enrolled in a caste, or community, called Ját Boistub, but generally nicknamed "Vántáṣi," a term more expressive than elegant.

Bengal is divided into circles, each circle having its own Gosáin, within whose jurisdiction no other Gosáin can legitimately act. The Gosáins of Nityánanda have always been more popular than their rivals, and claim the exclusive right of making disciples in the districts of Dacca, Báqirganj, Farrídpúr, and Jessore; but in each of these representatives of the three head centres may be found. The Nityánanda Gosáins were especially favoured by the Muhammadan governors, Jasárat Khán, the Nawáb of Dacca, when the English acquired the Ráj, granting a Sanad to Nanda Lál Gosáin, conferring on him land in Báqirganj for the maintenance of male and female mendicants. In 1783 the zamíndárs dispossessed the proprietors, but on appeal the Çadr 'Adálat ordered the restitution of the property, which is held by their descendants at the present day.

In the city of Dacca there are seven Nityánanda Gosáins, the chief, Madan Mohan Gosvámi, being eleventh in descent from the Prabhu, while the others are the offspring of children adopted by former Gozáins. As a natural result, there is much covert enmity and jealousy between each household. The

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chief Ákhára, or monastery, of these "Gentoo Bishops," as they were styled by Holwell, is called Rám Kanháí in Islámpúr; but in Farrídábád, a suburb of the city, and at Uthali, near Teota, in the Ja'farganj Thánah, are two celebrated Ákháras, at which other Gosáins reside.

The Gosáins are a comparatively pure stock, and fair specimens of the higher Bengali race. As a rule they are of a light brown, or wheaten, colour, tall and large-boned. Muscular they ought to be, but indolence and good living stamps them at an early age with a look of sensuality and listlessness, and they become large fat men, fond of sleep, their chief muscular exertion consisting in holding out the foot to be kissed by admiring followers. Their lives are passed in sensual pleasures, and the boundless influence they wield among thousands of the middle classes is, unhappily, not directed to their moral elevation. Satisfied with a blind and unquestioning adoration, they are quite content, if it lasts during their lifetime, to disregard the possibility of future agitation and revolution.

The Nityánanda and Advayánanda Gosáins differ in several respects. The former admit into their communion all ranks and conditions of men and women, from the Bráhman to the Chaṇḍál, from the Bráhmaní widow to the common prostitute; but the latter only admits Bráhmans and members of the clean Śúdra castes. The first maintain that any limitation is opposed to the teaching of Chaitanya, and at variance with the fact that the whispering of the Mantra in the ear of the most wicked and dissolute often leads to repentance and conversion.

The Nityánanda Gosáins have always been most popular with the lower Bengali castes, having acquired a commanding position among Vaishnavas. A "Panjah," or silver hand, is the badge of the family. At Khardah is still paraded one presented by a Nawáb of Bengal, and the Janmáshṭamí procession of the Tántís is preceded by a man carrying a "Panjah."

The Advayánanda Gosáins, as a matter of course, are highly esteemed by the upper classes, it being exceedingly rare for a Bráhman, or Baidyá, to enroll himself in the ranks of the other. They are numerous in Dacca, the most respected and learned being Dínabandhu of Bosés Bazár. These Gosáins are said to be more sincere, and less depraved, than the others, invariably refusing to receive any woman, and thus avoiding much scandal. Furthermore, they do not seek to increase the number of followers in the indiscriminate way the Nityánanda do, but welcome any penitent who approaches them, if he proves by his behaviour that he is really desirous of leading a new life.

Vaishnavas on entering the society pay a fee of twenty anas, sixteen of which go to the Gosáin, and four to the Faujdár. It

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is also asserted that the Advayánanda Gosáins pay a fee to the Nityánanda, on the grounds that only the latter can properly initiate disciples in Eastern Bengal.

No one but a Hindu can join the Vaishnava community, and as a rule no probation is required. Each member of a Vaishnava family must receive the Mantra, his water-vessels being impure until he does so, while it cannot rightly be given until the rite Karṇa-vedha, or ear-boring, has been performed. The strict Vaishnava never drinks water from the hands of a Ṣiv worshipper, even though he belong to the same caste.

In each important village of Bengal an Ákhára, belonging to the sect, exists, sanctifying, according to Hindu ideas, the place and protecting the inhabitants from all evil. Ákháras are often built by subscription, mendicants being invited to take posssesion and tend the idols of Madana-Mohana or Kṛishna, Rádha-Kṛishna, or Kṛishna-Balaráma, lodged in them. The two most famous images of the Bengali Vaishnavas are those of Vishnupúr in Bankúra, now in Calcutta, and the Gopi-náth of Agradvípa in Krishnaghar.

The religious duties (Sádhana) of the Gṛihi and Bairágí Vaishnavas are sixty-four in number, the most important being the foot-kissing (Pada-áṣraya), of the Gosáin, and the Náma Kírtana, or invocation of the god's name.

At initiation the Vaishnava novice receives a Mála, or rosary, which is either hung round the neck or put into a cloth bag, having an opening for the thumb. The rosary consists of 108 beads, and it is incumbent on each individual to count his beads a certain number of times daily, while no true disciple will drink water, or touch food, until he has made a round of the rosary, muttering as he touches each bead, one or other of the names of Hari. The frequency with which the beads are counted is considered a test of sincerity, and many Vaishnavas spend the chief part of their lives repeating the names of Harí; while in the streets, in places of public amusement, and even during conversation, they may be observed dreamily, often unconsciously, renewing, with painful reiteration, the bead-counting, and the monotonous burden of their prayers. It is also considered a most meritorious act to teach a parrot, or "mainá," to speak nothing but Harí Rám.

Another important Sádhana is the San-Kírtana, which consists in reciting religious songs in honour of Kṛishna. Twice a day, in the forenoon, and at sunset, services are held in all Ákháras, when oblations are made to the idols. The favourite musical instruments are the Mṛidanga, an elongated drum, tapering towards the ends, and the Kartál, or brass cymbals. The eleventh day of the waxing moon in each month

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is a fast, no food being taken till sunset; while on the Ekádaṣi, the eleventh "tithi," or lunar day, following the Dashará, and for the ensuing thirty days, Vaishnavas are engaged in prayer and singing. Before dawn discordant music clangs from every shrine and Ákhára in the country, and in the daytime bands of Mahants, pupils (chela), and scholars (avadhúta) perambulate the streets reciting—

"With earnestness repeat, Rádha, Kṛishna, Nitai, Chaitanya, Advaita, the three Prabhus."

The aforesaid duties are essential to salvation, and a strict observance of them will ensure endless felicity, even though the other sixty Sádhana are neglected.

The Gṛihi Vaishnavas, who live as other Hindus, comprise the majority of the sect. They celebrate with more or less pomp the Dol-játrá in Phálgun (March and April), the Rath-játrá in Ashárh (July and August), the Janmáṣhtamí, or birthday of Kṛishna, in Bhádra (August and September), and the Rás-játrá in Kártik (October and November).

The rich Súṇṛí bankers and merchants frequently erect Ákháras adjoining their houses, liberally endowing them, and providing food for swarms of hungry mendicants. Although the Vaishnava creed has attracted most of the lower classes of Bengal, it has, by recognising caste, entirely failed to elevate or guide them towards higher aspirations.

The Bairágí and Bairágan Vaishnavas are of evil repute, their ranks being recruited by those who have no relatives, by widows, by individuals too idle or depraved to lead a steady working life, and by prostitutes. Vaishnavi, or Boistubi according to the vulgar pronunciation, has come to mean a courtezan. A few undoubtedly join from sincere and worthy motives, but their numbers are too small to produce any appreciable effect on the behaviour of their comrades. The habits of these beggars are very unsettled. They wander from village to village, and from one Ákhára to another, fleecing the frugal and industrious peasantry on the plea of religion, and singing songs in praise of Harí beneath the village tree, or shrine. Mendicants of both sexes smoke Indian hemp (gánjha), and, although living as brothers and sisters, are notorious for licentiousness. There is every reason for suspecting that infanticide is common, as children are never seen. In the course of their wanderings they entice away unmarried girls, widows, and even married women, on the pretext of visiting Ṣrí Kshetra (Jagannáth), Brindában, or Benares, for which reason they are shunned by all respectable natives, who gladly give charity to be rid of them.

The following account of an annual religious gathering in

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Bengal discloses the true character of these disreputable mendicants. Amid the ruins of ancient Gaur are large reservoirs of water, called Rúpa and Sanátan, after the two distinguished Muhammadans converted by Chaitanya, on the banks of which the "Rás Mela," or "Prema tala," *i.e.*, real love, festival is held in the month of June. Crowds of Bairágís and Bairágans resort to this fair from all parts of Bengal, the latter being seated in long rows with their faces covered. Should a Bairágí be in search of a companion, he pays the customary fee to the Faujdár, and a selection is made. He leads the female aside, raises her veil, and if satisfied takes her away, otherwise he takes her back to her place. In the latter case the Faujdár refuses to allow another choice, unless the twenty anas fee is again paid. It is a law with these licentious Bairágís that a man cannot put away the woman selected, even for adultery, until the next year's gathering comes round.

BÁYÁN-KAUPÍNA.

This sect of Vaishnavas has received this strange name from the members wearing the "Kaupína," or waist-cloth, fastened on the left (báyán) side instead of the right, as is the invariable custom with other Vaishnavas. The following story is told of its origin. A Guru in the act of initiating a disciple inadvertently tied the Kaupína on the left side, but seeing his mistake he was proceeding to rectify it, when the novice remonstrated by saying that the oversight must have been predestined by Harí, and refused to permit of any change. He accordingly went forth in disarray, and established the Báyán-Kaupína Vaishnavas.

There is only one Ákhárá of this sect in Dacca, situated in Narsinghdee, a suburb of the city. The Mahant is a Śrotriyá Bráhman, only twenty years of age, who succeeded his father, a native of Northern Bengal. In Silhet there are many communities of the sect, and at Haibatnagar, in Mymensingh, there is also an establishment belonging to them.

The special object of worship of the Báyán-Kaupína Vaishnavas is Rádhá-Kṛishna, but they are never charged with the immoral practices usually attributed to sects worshipping this union of the male and female principles. The flesh of all manner of fish, or beast, every intoxicating substance, and Gánjha, are strictly forbidden, and only women of moral character are initiated, and allowed to reside in Ákhárás. The members of the sect formerly ate with other Vaishnavas, but of late years this toleration, being abused, has been revoked. The

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Mahant makes an annual visitation throughout his circle, instructing the laity and collecting the yearly subscriptions for the support of the Ákhárá.

KIṢORÍ-BHAJANA.

This, one of the many outgrowths of Vaishnavism, is properly designated Sáhuja, but in Eastern Bengal it is known as Kiṣorí-Bhajana—Kisorí being a maiden, and Bhajana the Sanskrit for adoration. In many respects the sect resembles the Rádhá-Vallabhís, and a tradition survives that it seceded from them. It is related that the Guru having tasted food on a fast, or "Ekádaṣí," day, observed by all Vaishnavas, gave a portion to his disciples, making them violate their vows, and obliging the other members who had not tasted to separate and form a dissenting body. It is more probable, however, that the society is the same as the Rádhá-Vallabhí, but acknowledging other masters. The founder of the sect in Dacca was one Kála Chand Vidyálankára, a poor Bráhman, who lived about ninety years ago. He served in his Guru's house, but having accidentally struck his mistress when pounding rice, he fled to Navadvíp, and became the pupil of Vaṇṣá Rám, a Spashṭa Dáyaka. The religious establishment created by him differed altogether from that of his Guru. A Spashṭa Dáyaka will not look upon a woman, nor accept food from her; while with the Kiṣorí-Bhajana, woman occupies the chief place, and is the principal object of worship.

This sect is peculiar in having no Udásí, or religious mendicants. There is a Guru, or Pradhán, as he is called, who initiates converts, and conducts all religious services. As among the Chakra worshippers of the Tantras, absolute secresy regarding the mysteries of the creed is preserved, although in the city of Dacca many hundreds of Hindus, especially women,[1] belong to it. The majority pertain to the low Súṇrí caste, but individuals of all ranks, from the Bráhman to the Chaṇḍál, are freely admitted, equality being enforced, and no distinctions permitted.

It is extremely difficult to find out the precise religious beliefs of this sect. It is stated that members always place a book, or an article of common use, in a conspicuous part of the house, and worship it as a symbol of their faith, in the hope of misleading the public and avoiding too particular inquiries.

[1] Who generally shave their heads, leaving only a top-knot.

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The following incomplete account has been obtained, and as far as it goes may be accepted as correct. At the initiation of a disciple a Mantra, consisting of the word "Hang-sha," is whispered into his ear, and is believed to possess a certain mystical meaning, the first syllable typifying the air breathed, the latter the air expired. An indecent scene, in which a naked woman sits on the knee of the neophyte, is then rehearsed, as a crucial test of his having mortified the flesh and its lusts, and of his having become a worthy candidate for admission.

The chief ceremony resembling the Rás Mandalis of the Maháráj as of Bombay, which have been styled "carnal love meetings," is celebrated in a suitable room where a long strip of white cloth is spread on the floor with plantain leaves laden with fish and rice, while flesh and spirits never appear.

The feast being over, songs in honour of Rádhá-Kṛishná are chanted with the effect of often causing extravagant and violent excitement, terminating in hysterical weeping and convulsions. The Pradhán then selects a woman, possibly the prettiest; the pair are dusted with sandal-wood powder, crowned with flowers, and the company make adoration to them as the personations of Rádhá and her lover Kṛishna. Each man present then decorates himself with garlands, perfect silence being observed, and is presumed to fall into a dreamy sensuous condition, with mind abstracted and absorbed in the contemplation of the semblance of Rádhá at his side.

Such is the degraded and immoral product of the teaching of Chaitanya! The secresy in which the sect flourishes, and the reticence maintained by its members, not only favour the worst suspicions, but explain the disgust with which all other classes of natives regard it. The Kiṣorí-Bhajana holds the same position among Vaishnava sects as the Chakra does among Ṣaiva, both being the fruit of religious ecstasy carried to its natural conclusion.

JAGAT-MOHANÍ.

This, perhaps the most excellent of all the Vaishnava sects, derives its name from the Sanskrit Jagat, the world, and Mohana, a title of Kṛishna, signifying the fascinator, or cynosure.

The founder, Jagat Mohan, appeared as a teacher at Mashulia, a village of Silhet, about two hundred years ago. He was worshipped as an incarnation of Vishnu, and it is believed that he never tasted of death. On his translation from

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this world his mantle descended in turn on Govinda Gosvámí, Śánta Gosvámí, and Rám Kṛishna Gosvámí, the greatest of them all, whose Samádhi, or tomb, is the principal object in the large Ákhárá at Baithalang in Silhet, where the head-quarters of the sect are located. Of this Gosáin many wonderful stories are told. For instance, he obtained anything he desired by merely wishing for it, and his credulous followers believe that by prostrating themselves before his pattens (Kharáún), preserved at this shrine, their wishes will be fulfilled. Facing each Ákhárá of this sect a mat hut stands, where visitors perform Bhajana, or adoration, every evening; while inside is a "Chauḍol," or cabinet, containing a pair of pattens. The Baithalang Ákhárá is richly endowed, and often hundreds of pilgrims are fed at it in a single day.

This body is very numerous in Silhet, less so in Mymensingh, and in Dacca it is calculated that not more than fifty families belong to it. There is one Ákhárá in the quarter of the city called Faridábád, and another at Tál-ṭolá in Bikrampúr.

It is asserted that throughout Bengal the society possesses three hundred and sixty Ákhárás, each having a Mahant, or leader, and a Pújárí, or officiating priest. These offices may be filled by persons of any caste, there being a tradition that Rám Kṛishna Gosvámí was a fisherman. Women are not permitted to reside within an Ákhárá, and should any immorality be proved against one of the brethren, he is admonished; should he repeat the offence he is summarily expelled.

In the Ákhárás, Kírttan, or religious songs, in praise of Kṛishna, very rarely of Rádhá, are chaunted seven times a day, and twice at night.

As with other Vaishnava sects, there are two ranks, namely the Gṛihí and Vairágí, the former living at their homes, and working as other men; the latter wandering about the country as beggars. Women receive the Mantra, as well as the men; but not the Bhek. Hindus of all classes join the association, but Christians and Muhammadans are disqualified. The Mahants are more earnest, and more watchful over the welfare of their flocks than is usually the case, and every year make visitations throughout their dioceses. No fixed sum is levied from a novice, but if rich he is expected to contribute something to the Ákhárá. In Silhet, moreover, it is customary to present a share of the first-fruits to the nearest shrine, and bequeath money for its support.

The Vairágí is forbidden to eat fish or flesh; to smoke Gánjha or tobacco; or to drink spirits.

After death corpses are usually cast into a river, never burned, and it is only when a dying Mahant expresses a wish to

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be buried, that a Samádhi is constructed. While in articulo the body is lowered into the grave, as it is thought lucky for him to die where he is to rest.

The bodies and faces of members of this sect are marked with twelve or more sectarial devices. Two parallel lines are drawn with sandal-wood paste from the crown of the head, or from the roots of the front hair, to the tip of the nose, where they meet and form a loop; a spot is put on the last rib on each side, at the top of the sternum, on each arm, and on the lobes of the ears. Their dress is noways peculiar. The fore part of the head is closely shaven, while the back, from which a long cue depends, is left untouched. Many also wear round the neck a double fold of red tape received at Jagannáth.

The residents of Ákhárás are forbidden to beg, but thankfully accept any charity offered them. On no account can they absent themselves unless summoned to visit a sick, or penitent, disciple.

Very little can be ascertained regarding the tenets of the Jagat Mohaní Vaishnanas, but even their enemies admit that their lives are exemplary and moral. The Mahant at Dacca is a quiet, unassuming youth, with no hypocritical pretensions to sanctity, as is too often the case with Hindu cenobites.

SPASHṬA DÁYAKA.

This sect was founded by Rúp Kabíráj, the disciple of Kṛishna Chandra Chakravarttí of Saidábád, the pupil of Mákandah Dás, a successor of Chaitanya. It is set forth that Kṛishna Chandra sojourned at Brindában acquiring great renown as a holy teacher, and that on leaving he delivered to Rúp Kabíraj the charge of his flock, upon whom a great scandal had fallen owing to the crowds of women residing in the Ákhárás with the disciples. Rúp Kabíráj, therefore, determined on casting out all those who, by their licentious behaviour, had brought disgrace on the community; but he encountered serious opposition. Worn out, and irritated by this factious spirit, he one day threw the leavings of his food into the dishes of his opponents, and thereby cast a stain on them. He then intimated that for the future no member of the society should eat food cooked by a woman.

Another story is sometimes told of its foundation. The wife of Rúp Kabíráj was in the habit of distributing food to the disciples, but some refused to accept it because she wore a shell

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bracelet, the badge of low birth. The husband pointed out that his wife, a Ṭhákuráni, could lawfully mete out the Prasáda without causing disgrace; but the disciples, still sceptical, seceded, and established the order of Spashṭa Dáyaka.[1]

This sect has never flourished in Eastern Bengal, but it has an establishment in the city of Dacca, known as the Ináyatganj Ákháṛá, founded by Vanṣa Rám Gosáin. Another monastery exists at Simalía, fourteen miles north of the city; a third at Dalál Bázár in Noakhally; while in Silhet many Ákháṛás are supported.

A writer in the Calcutta Review, with whom Dr. Hunter agrees, has put forth statements apt to mislead regarding the peculiar doctrines of this body. These authorities state that its characteristic features are the repudiation of the servile veneration paid to the Guru, and a mystical association of the male and female devotees. On the contrary, at Dacca, the Guru does receive special veneration, and the spirit of a former Gosáin Pancha Rám is still invoked, while in the Ináyatganj Ákháṛá the mother of the Guru resides, although her son cannot receive food from her hands, and no other woman is allowed to remain within its walls. Further, it cannot be denied that Rádhá Kṛishna is the principal object of worship. The Mantra is bestowed on women, the Bhek never. Finally, celibacy is professed by all, and any glaring immorality entails expulsion.

All castes, including Chaṇḍáls, are enrolled in the sect, but a preference is shown for the pure Súdras.

The distinctive sectarial mark is a daub of ochre (Gopí-chandan) on the nose, with two narrow lines drawn upwards to the roots of the hair. The temples, arms, chest, and shoulders are stamped with the sacred names of Harí.

The Spashṭa Dáyaka accept alms from any Hindus, and even from Muhammadans, but never from Chamárs, or prostitutes. The Vaishnava Vairágí is forbidden to eat with him, and he declines to eat with the Vairágí. He is further prohibited from touching flesh or fish, and from eating with any one not a member of his association.

The Bhek is conferred on married men, even though continuing to lead a secular life. The Vairágí Spashṭa Dáyaka leads the same irregular vagabond existence as the Vairágí Vaishnava, making pilgrimages to Ṣrí Brindában, and roaming from one shrine to another, subsisting on the charity of the villagers. It is forbidden for him to receive money at marriages and festivals; but on all other occasions he is at liberty to accept it.

[1] Sanskrit Spashṭa, true, Dáyaka, giving, or given.

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Their dead are usually interred, and the grave (Samádhi) of those who have died leaving disciples is, as with all Vaishnavas, held in especial veneration, an Ákhárá being built over it. Every cenobite desires to be buried, and this feeling is one of the most potent means of spreading the doctrines of the sect, as each one strives to form a company, and to become the founder of an Ákhárá, where his name will be preserved, and his memory revered.

A corpse is buried in a sitting posture, as among the mendicant Jogís. A cloth (námá-bolí), stamped with the name Harí, is wrapped round the head; the Kaupína, like that received at initiation, round the body; while the arms are folded across the chest, a necklace hung around the neck, and a cocoa-nut shell (Karanka), a wallet, and a staff (ḍanḍá) placed by the side. If the deceased were a man of unusual sanctity, religious rites would be daily performed at his tomb, and his spirit invoked on all occasions of affliction and misfortune.

The Ákhárá in Dacca is richly endowed, possessing "debottar" lands yielding a revenue of four hundred and fifty rupees a year, which is supplemented by collections made by the Vairágís.

KAVÍ-INDRA PARIVÁRA.

This title is assumed by a small sect of Vaishnavas claiming to be the Parivára, or attendants, of Vishnu Dás Kaví-Indra, one of the original sixty-four Mahants who preached the doctrines of Chaitanya after his decease. Vishnu Dás was a Śúdra, and the Mahants have since his day been Śúdras. As the story goes, Vishnu Dás was a special favourite of Chaitanya, evincing his humility and faith by daily partaking of the leavings of the Maháprabhu's meal. Unfortunately, one day he found no orts, but looking into the spittoon he detected a grain of rice, tinged with blood, which had been ejected by Chaitanya when rinsing his mouth. Vishnu Dás swallowed it, but his proceeding did not escape the watchful eye of an enemy. The Maháprabhu was appealed to, and decided that any disciple tasting the blood of his Guru must be excommunicated. Chaitanya was grieved at the loss of his devoted follower, but having once given his decision it was irrevocable, so Vishnu Dás went forth to organise a dissenting society of his own.

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The doctrines of this sect are almost identical with those of the Chaitanya Vaishnavas, and the only differences in the internal economy are, that the Mahant, or religious head, discharges the duties of an elective, not of a hereditary, office, and that he is always a Śúdra.

The only Ákhárá of the sect in the Dacca district is situated at Sánara, twenty miles north of the city; and it is calculated that the society consists of not more than forty families. Many, however, are rich Súnrí bankers, and merchants, who contribute liberally to its maintenance. This sect is peculiar in having no Udásí, or Vairágí grade, the members from the Mahant downwards being Gṛihí, or married men. All castes are freely admitted into its ranks, and it is said that even Śrotriyá Bráhmans are occasionally enrolled.

BÁOLA.

In Bengal various disreputable mendicant orders exist, comprehended under the generic term Báola, or Váyula, the Sanskrit for crazed, but used in the same sense as the Persian "diwánah," inspired. These orders are schismatics from the main Vaishnava body, and having been established by low caste enthusiasts chiefly attract the fisher and peasant classes.

They are distinguished as Nitya, Chaitanya, and Harí Dás Báolas, after the great Vaishnava doctors. The ordinary treatises, such as the Chaitanya-Charitámṛita and the Kṛishna Tantra, are followed as the authoritative guides of their orders.

Báolas make pilgrimages to all the shrines deemed sacred by the genuine Vaishnava, and look upon the Gosáins as their spiritual leaders. Flesh and spirits are forbidden, but fish is considered lawful food, and Gánjha is smoked to excess. No Báola dare shave, or cut his hair, and personal uncleanliness is commended as a religious virtue. They assume greater social tolerance than Vaishnavas generally, and while the Vairágí only eats with Vairágís sprung from his own caste, the Báola fraternizes with all Báolas, even with those of the lowest and most despised castes. Members of the order affirm that in the Dacca district alone twenty Báola Ákhárás exist, but the only recognized one in the neighbourhood of the city is in a village called Mírer Bágh.

The favourite object of worship with all Báolas is Kṛishna as a child, or Láḍú-Gopál; but in most Ákhárás the Charaṇa, or pattens, of the founder are also honoured.

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At the initiation of a disciple loathsome substances are eaten, and actions indescribably filthy are committed, as tests of worthiness. Celibacy and morality are inculcated, but never practised, and nowadays there is no sect so despised for its shameless profligacy as the Báola. Young women are encouraged to join the body on the pretence of living as sisters and helpmates in the Ákhárá; but the majority of the females in Ákhárás are prostitutes. A Báola gives a feast to the Mahant, and pays a fee of twenty anas when he wishes to possess a helpmate. Girls with good voices are usually selected, as the revenue of the community is derived from playing on the Gopíjantra and Sarangí to the villagers, and from singing religious hymns.

Mahants are always buried in the same position as Jogís, and over the grave, or Samádhi, an Ákhárá is built by his disciples. The bodies of the laity are thrown into a river, unless the individual has been distinguished for sanctity, or for the number of his adherents.

The various Báola divisions only differ from each other in certain ceremonial observances and social usages.

The low estimation in which all Báloas are held by the Hindus, and the odium, shared by all, are explained in the following account of the Sudarám Báolas.

About 1825 Sudarám, a Chaṇḍál peasant of Birkrampúr, received "*bhek*" from a Vairáganí, named Tokání, a member of the Nyaḍa-Nyaḍí society, and thereupon organised a new sect, making Jagannáth Dás, a Kaibartta, his pupil. Sudarám resided at 'Abdullahpúr in Bikrampúr, and there the first Ákhárá was constructed. Sudarám and Tokání were quite illiterate, but this was no drawback in the eyes of the simple villagers, who joined the new society in considerable numbers. The Samádhi of Tokání Máya is at 'Abdullahpúr, where Gaur Dás, the Chaṇḍál Mahant, resides; but that of Sudarám is at Sirájábád on the river Padma. A third Ákhárá has been lately established at Narsinghdih, north of Old Sunnárgáon.

The doctrines taught by Sudarám were, the existence of one God, Harí, and the perfection of the Mahápraḃhu Nityánanda. Further, it was revealed to him that Víra Bhadra, a successor of Nityánánda, observed the Ṣákta ritual; consequently the abominable impurities of the Chakra worship were engrafted upon the Vaishnava creed. Adding whatever was likely to bind his credulous followers, and prevent separation, he further adopted the disgusting practises of the Aghorapanthís.

In the Ákhárá at 'Abdullahpúr an image of Krishna as a child, called Bála Gopála, Gopála-na-bálaka, or Láḍu-Gopála, a Ṣíva-linga, and a wooden Vishnupada, are worshipped. A most

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sacred relic is a staff, four feet in length, with an iron hand at the top, said to be the fac-simile of one borne by Nityánand, and decorated with strings of shells, stone beads, and flowers. Although Harí is the chief object of worship, Sudarám and his "Charaṇ" share in the adoration of the society, who also sing hymns in honour of Suda-Tokání, the two founders, and make offerings of rice, "Kái," starch, and native spirits.

About two hundred and fifty families, chiefly Kaibarttas and Chaṇḍáls, have already joined this dissolute body; but all classes, even Muhammadans, may do so. It has gained a certain position among the uneducated masses, and villagers who, though disagreeing with its principles, often present offerings in fulfilment of vows.

At the initiation of a disciple a wooden huqqá of a peculiar elongated form is given, as well as a necklace of a hundred and eight beads, a staff, a wallet, a piece of cloth, called "Uran-Vasana," dyed of a reddish colour with Gerú, or ochre, and a hempen cord to fasten the Kaupína, or waist cloth. The distinctive badge of the sect, however, is a pair of brass bracelets (Kaṛá) of singular shape. At the thinner end elephants' heads are roughly designed, while the trunks unite to form the circle. The wooden beads of the common Hindu necklace have been discarded, and the party-coloured glass heads of the Muhammadan Faqírs adopted. Twenty anas is paid to the person giving the Mantra; but the Mahant claims the same amount from each novice.

Women receive Bhek, and reside with the Sádhus, or mendicants, as wives. This is a late innovation, for Sudarám restricted the association of men and women to a platonic sympathy like that of brothers and sisters. A few professing celibates, however, are to be found, as well as some who have had the "Mála" ceremony of regular marriage performed, but the large majority live shamelessly.

The Sudarám Báola is a dirty and unsavoury ascetic, seldom bathing, except when ill, and fulfilling all requirements by smearing his face and body daily with mustard oil. He drinks spirits to excess, and is generally stupefied with Indian hemp. They, however, pride themselves on shaving the beard, and on not allowing it to grow untrimmed like other Báolas. The "Mirdang" and "Kartál" are the favourite musical instruments, but when attending as professional musicians at the Trínath Mela, which they often do, the "belá," and "Sárangí," varieties of the violin are preferred.

These Báolas assume many virtues. The Mahant is very humble, styling himself "Jháṛú," or sweeper, Mahant, and pretending to have no interest in the dissemination of his

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religious belief among the villagers. Everybody who comes to the Ákhára, asking for admission, is welcomed, and no proof of sincerity is required. Pilgrimages being supererogatory are not favoured, as knowledge of the world is thought likely to give rise to doubts and unbelief.

In the villages of the interior the Sudarám Báolas bear the worst reputation for enticing away girls from their homes, and encouraging lovers to elope, and join their society. It is a common occurrence to meet these unclean mendicants on a country road walking unencumbered, while a young, and often comely girl, carrying all their property, lags behind, with a melancholy expression of face, an index of the humiliation she feels. Widows, it is not to be wondered at, often join the Báolas, as they cannot receive greater indignities than at home.

DARWESH-FAQÍR.

This compound Arabic-Persian name has been adopted by one of the latest and most corrupt offshoots from the Vaishnava stem, tracing its origin to Rúpa and Sanátan, two of the six Gosáins after Chaitanya, who, if not Muhammadans themselves, were servants of a Muhammadan king. The following history and particulars were gleaned at visits paid to the two chief Ákhárás in 1874.

The founder of the sect, Udáya Chánd, a Karmakár, died about 1850, leaving three Ṣiṣu, or pupils, namely, his daughter and immediate successor, popularly called the "Mahárání," one Autal Chánd, a Káyath, and Bípan Chánd, a Sáha. Autal Chánd dying left two disciples, Ṣánta Chánd, a Saha, and Prem Chánd, a Telí. The Mahárání died suddenly in November, 1874, and the succession was disputed by Bípan Chánd and Ṣánta Chánd.

The Ákhárá to which these parties belonged, at Jháú Kandhí, on the left bank of the river Padma, is a remarkably clean and tidy place, consisting of four separate thatched houses with raised mud floors. In the centre of the square is a magnificent Bakul tree (*Mimusops Elengi*), while bounding the enclosure is a plantation of mangoe trees and Betle palms. Three houses serve for the accommodation of the resident Udásís, five or six in number, while the fourth is a Baiṭhak-Kháná where visitors are entertained. In one corner are the

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graves of Udáya Chánd and his daughter, the former within a brick building with only one entrance, the latter beneath a square thatched shed. Both graves are of the same pattern, namely, a rectangular earthern mound, from the centre of which a round flat knob rises, and on the earlier one two eyes have been painted. Fresh flowers, chiefly marigolds and convolvuluses, are daily strewn over them, while in front a clean white cloth is spread on which a tumbler of water, a plate with sections of an orange, and a huqqá primed with tobacco are placed. A strong, and unmistakable, odour of spirits issued from the Maháráni's resting place on this occasion.

At Kálakopa, on the Hilsámárí river, an Ákhárá was built over the Samádhi, or grave, of one Baláí Chánd, a Gop Goála, and a distinguished member of the order. His favourite disciple, a Sáha woman, now presides over it, and is everywhere known as the "Khepáráni," or mad queen, to distinguish her from the "Maháráni" of Jháú-Kandhí. She is now about forty years of age, and usually dresses in oily and very unsavoury garments. She never leaves the Ákhárá, but receives food and other necessaries from the Karmakárs and Sáhas of the neighbourhood, although they do not belong to her sect. Anybody can enter the shrine, as no regular service is held there, but only prayers recited, and oblations made whenever domestic troubles happen. The Khepáráni has no Śishya, or pupil, as she deems herself unworthy of having one.

The Darwesh-Faqírs worship Krishna, distinguishing their creed by the term "Brahma-dharma." Their religious books, such as the Chaitanya-Charitámrita, are the ordinary Vaishnava ones, but few can read, still less understand them. At the initiation of a disciple the Mahant receives presents, and delivers to the novice a "Kaupína," a Khirqá, or gown reaching to the ankles, and a Kishtí, or cocoa-nut shell, which serves the same purpose as the scrip, or wallet, of European beggars. Like the Aghorapanthís, he must taste the most disgusting substances to prove his indifference and contempt for the prejudices of humanity. The Udásís never shave or cut the hair, and seldom bathe with water, but use instead mustard oil, with which they saturate their garments. The sect professes to lead celibate lives, but there is in each Ákhárá at least one woman ostensibly engaged in sweeping the enclosure and cooking the meals of the Udásís. The wearing of necklaces and bracelets like other Vaishnava sects is forbidden, but the members feign greater liberality, and are glad to eat with every caste, and even with Mussulmáns.

Intoxication is a very venial offence, and spirits are not only openly drunk, but also form the principal accessory of their

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worship. A bottle of brandy is a more welcome present than money, and whenever the Mahárání or Khepáráni makes a tour through the country, village women of all castes flock to the boats with offerings of spirits, in hopes that through the intercession of these personages every desire will be attained. After being blessed, the village matrons, it is said, drink a little, and in June, 1873, the excise officers accounted for a sudden reduction in the consumption of spirits to the illness of the Mahárání.

This sect always apes humility, repudiating the title Váyula a name of Nityánanda, but claiming to be the most austere of all Vaishnava societies, and professing to reject those who have not mortified the seven lusts of the flesh. Animal life is never taken, and it is deemed sinful to break off branches, or even leaves, from trees. A singular form of obeisance is made before the Samádhis, and on the receipt of a present. The individual kneels, touches the ground with his forehead, and rising up daubs his chest and face with dust.

Though heartily despised by Hindus generally, for their filthy and dissipated habits, the Ákhárá of Jháú-Kandhí stands on Brahmottara lands, bequeathed to the founder, and low caste Bráhmans visit the Baiṭhak-Khána and smoke dry huqqás with the Udásís.

This sect owns its origin to the egotism of some low caste Bengali, ambitious of emulating the prosperous Vaishnava communities, and of founding a society without any mystical beliefs, which would be acceptable to credulous persons. Owing to that spirit of toleration, so characteristic of the Hindus, the seed sown took root, and still vegetates. As the characters and influence of the leaders are estimated by the number of disciples, there is no lack of energy in spreading the doctrines of the sect. It will, therefore, in every probability, increase in numbers and importance until some equally debased association arises and displaces it.

ṢAIVAS.

The Ṣaiva fraternities have never gained popularity in Eastern Bengal. Their conventual establishments are few, and would have disappeared long ago but for the charitable endowments of former ages. The two principal sects are the Kánpháta Jogís and the Brahmáchárí. The former possess an Ákhárá founded above a century ago, the latter one as old as the seventeenth

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century. The Ṣaiva cenobites, or mendicants, are notorious for their licentious lives and dissipated habits, but notwithstanding the scandal they cause, their Ákhárás are on festival days thronged by crowds of devotees, chiefly women.

1. Kánpháta Jogís.

The comparatively modern sect of Kánphátá Jogís, founded by the great Ṣaiva doctor Gorakhnáth, possesses an Ákhárá at Mánikganj, endowed by the pious Mahárání Bhaváni of Nátor about A.D. 1750. The land and shrine having been swept away by the river Dhulleṣwari, a new building was erected inland, but has never flourished on its new site.

The history of the shrine is, that Harí Ṣrí, an Udási, and Kánu Ṣrí, a Grihí Sannyási, came from Benares, and obtained from the Mahárání a grant of land at Mánikganj to found an Ákhárá. The first Mahant, Harí Ṣrí, was succeeded by a son of Kánu, and it has ever since been the rule to elect a Mahant alternately from these families.

Kánpháta Jogís are not necessarily Bráhmans, but the Mahants usually belong to some Hindustání Bráhmanical tribe. At the initiatory rite the Udási receives a bamboo whistle three inches long, called Sinha-náth, which is attached to a cord, and used at the beginning of all religious ceremonies, and a rosary consisting of fifty Rudráksha beads, which must be told at least twice daily. The distinctive badge of the sect, however, are the large triangular blue glass or silver earrings adopted after initiation, and from which they derive their singular name of "torn-ears." The Udásís bestow the Mantra on all castes, but no one can wear the whistle or earrings unless he becomes an Udási. The Kánpháta Jogís claim as their perquisite the Sánr, or bull, branded with the sacred trident at Ṣráddhas, and at Mánikganj this claim is admitted.

The Grihí Sannyásís, again, as with Vaishnavas, are married men, who, although permitted to wear the ochre-dyed mendicant garb, are generally peasants dressed like their neighbours. It is this class of Jogís, remarkable for their large filigree earrings, who during the cold season wander about Bengal as snake-charmers. They are usually cultivating Goálas from the Doáb, who leave their families at home during the annual tour in Bengal.

The principal festival of this sect ís the Ṣív-chaturdaṣí, or fourteenth day of the waxing moon of Phálgun (Feb.-March), when a great commercial fair is held near the Ákhárá. Although the traders aud hucksters still resort to it from all parts of

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Bengal, the Udásís complain that yearly fewer pay their devotions at the shrine, and, what is of greater importance in their eyes, contribute less than formerly to its support. In only one respect has the reputation of the shrine been preserved, and the credulous still talk of the wonderful cures performed by the Mahant.

By blowing a Mantra over a cup of water, the Mahant cures one class of disease; by mixing the ashes of his Gánjha pipe in water the ordinary diseases are got rid of; and by making an amulet of the withered flowers which have stood in the sanctuary of the idol, a certain preservative against a third class of ailments is provided. Should the sick person be able to visit the Ṣiválí, or temple, in person, he is made to crawl on his belly to the sanctuary, and there lick the dust of the floor, and smear his face with it.

The Kánpháta Jogís are Ṣakta worshippers, consuming enormous quantities of spirits at all religious rites, and in the intervals stupefying themselves with Indian hemp. The drinking vessel is the skull of a Chaṇḍál, which is supported on the points of the thumb, forefinger, and little finger of the right hand, while spirits are quaffed from it. An Udásí can drink from the skull with all castes, without it only with Bráhmans; but the offer of a bottle of brandy overcomes all scruples, and it is incredible the impunity with which a toper drinks off the whole undiluted.

Although confirmed drunkards, the common people excuse their delinquencies, and are satisfied that they must be holy men because they live in an Ákhárá, wear the mendicant dress, and affect indifference to worldly feelings and interests.[1]

2. Brahmáchárí.

This is a term applied to a mendicant who professes to have prolonged the period of studentship, and to observe through life the practice of study, poverty, and continence; but in Bengal it signifies a Ṣaiva ascetic. Under this name are usually included four classes, the Ṣuddháchárí, Brahmáchárí, Paṣuáchárí, and Dvidháchárí, which are alike in admitting only Bráhmans into their ranks.

The Ṣuddha, or stainless Áchárí, is a celibate, who lives on Atapa rice, milk, and vegetables, and is obliged to use Ghí in cooking instead of oil. Tobacco is allowed, and sweetmeats if

[1] For further particulars of the sect consult Wilson's "Religious Sects of the Hindus," i, 213, and "J. R. A. S.," vol. v, 268.

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prepared by an ascetic, but only one cooking pot can be used for preparing a meal. He wears the sacred cord, and the hair is left uncut and unkempt. The sectarial mark, or Tilaka, is a perpendicular streak made with dark clay from the Ganges.

The four classes are distinguished from other orders by garments, stained of red ochre colour, called Gairiká (Geru) Vasana, or Bhagavan Vastra. The principal shrine of the Ṣuddhácháris is in Nadiyá, at Bela-Pokharia, on the Hughli.

The Brahmáchárí often reside in Ákhárás without any pretensions to sanctity, eating flesh, drinking spirits and Bháng, and leading a life of sensuality without any fear of losing their hold on the consciences of the credulous multitude.

The Paṣuáchárí correspond with the Gṛihí Vaishnavas living secular lives, and only distinguished from other villagers by their unshaven chins and ochre-dyed clothes. The Dvidháchárí is the same as the Vánaprastha, who leaves his home, assuming the garb of a hermit, as soon as his wife bears a son.

All Ṣaiva mendicants regard Ṣankaráchárya, who lived in the eighth or ninth century, as their founder. His four disciples, "prabhus" they are usually called, Padmapáda, Hastámalaka, Sureṣvara, and Troṭaka, settled on different sides of India, at Jagannáth, Haridvara, Dváraká, and Rámeṣvara, which are still visited by all Ṣaiva pilgrims. The "prabhus" left ten disciples, after whom the ten orders of Ṣaiva ascetics (Dasṇámí) are named. Of these the Girí, or Gír, is the only one found in Eastern Bengal.

In the centre of the Ramná, or park of Dacca, rises the pyramidal spire of a famous Ákhárá, founded by Uttama Gír, a renowned saint, who could even transmute metals. When the Muhammadans first came to Dacca the Nawáb built a summer house in this park, but his rest was disturbed by the constant blowing of chank shells. A peremptory order was issued to stop the unseasonable noise; but the same night the Nawáb was taken ill, and did not recover until the ascetics had been granted full permission to perform their religious ceremonies according to custom. In acknowledgment of his wonderful recovery, the Nawáb gave the garden house to the Ṣaiva mendicants, who built on the site an Ákhárá, called the Prakása Datta, or Káth-ghar, long celebrated for its footprint of Ṣankaráchárya. This temple was pillaged by the Nágas, or Sannyasís, in 1763, and has since been gradually falling into ruins.

The existing Ákhárá was built in place of the two older ones, and is popularly known as Harí Charan Gírs, a famous superior of former days. The temple is richly endowed, and is liberally supported by the inhabitants of Dacca. Mahárájas of Kochh Bihár and Tipperah, and Rájas of Chandradvíp, have at

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different times given grants of lands for its maintenance, but most of these have been resumed. Several branch temples have been established around Dacca in connection with this Ákhárá, which add considerable funds to the annual income, while one-sixth of the gross receipts of the Dhákeśvarí shrine are paid to the Mahant. The temples at Ṣítákhund in Chittagong have, within the last few years, been handed over to his care, and the post of head of the infamous Tára Kesvara temple in Hughlí was unsuccessfully claimed by the present Mahant. The Gosáin of the Dacca Ákhárá is Kálí Gír, a Gaur Brahman, well known in every court and jail of Eastern Bengal. The high-sounding titles with which he begins every petition are Paramánanda Girí, Paramhansa, Paribrajuk, Śrí Prakáśa, Kálí Charan Gir, Gosvámi, Mahant. Although his life is notoriously unsaintly, crowds of women resort to the Ákhárá, especially on festival days, and worship him with the same extravagant devotion as the Vaishnava does his Gosáin. In the sanctuary of this temple are two large idols of Kálí and Kṛishna, made of the eight metals (ashṭa-dhátu), regarded by the Hindus with superstitious fears, one the gift of a Mahárájah of Kochh Bihár, the other of a ruler of Tipperah.

All Brahmácháris worship Ṣiv and Kálí, and their religious observances are those prescribed in the Sáma Veda and the Tantras, often including the impure practices attending the Ṣaktí ritual. Bloody sacrifices, libations of ghí and spirits, as well as offerings of fruits and flowers, are presented to the deity.

A Brahmáchárí, after spending ten years of devotion in an Ákhárá, can return home, burn his sacred thread, and swallow the ashes, after which he may assume the garb of a Daṇḍi. If during another period of ten years he has complied with all the requirements of the grade, he becomes a Paramhansa, and must remain seated for twelve years in one position without asking charity, or accepting viands, but those voluntarily offered.

Surviving this prolonged penance, which is seldom tried, and scarcely ever accomplished, the devotee assumes the title of Mahá Paramhansa, becoming a part of the divine spirit. It is remarkable how similar these different grades of holiness are to the various stages of Çufí abstraction. The yearning desire for a closer communion with God is characteristic of both, and their common goal is complete absorption into the divine essence.

Members of Hindustání Ṣaiva sects are occasionally met with in Dacca on their way to some holy place, but they very rarely settle, or prolong their stay.

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VARIOUS SECTS.

In addition to the Vaishnava and Ṣaiva sects, four others are met with in Eastern Bengal. The Ṣrí-Náráyana calls itself deist, but the great annual gathering is for the most part a scene of intemperance and vice. The members chiefly belong to low castes, who regard the drinking of spirits and the smoking of Gánjha as the greatest enjoyments in life.

The Nának Sháhí and Suthrá Sháhí sects, transplanted from the Punjáb, have never become acclimatized in Bengal. They have no root in the affections of the people, and are gradually perishing for want of support.

The Tri-náth Púja, a modern excrescence peculiar to Eastern Bengal, has attracted great numbers of the most credulous and foolish of the people. The intoxication produced by Indian hemp is considered to be the illumination of the Spirit, and essential to the proper performance of their religious duties. The evil effects of this debasing worship are obvious, but up to 1875 it had spread with wonderful rapidity throughout Eastern Bengal, although no respectable Ṣúdra had openly enrolled himself in its ranks.

ṢRÍ-NÁRÁYANA, ṢIVA NÁRÁYANA.

This unitarian body in Eastern Bengal styles itself Ṣrí-náráyana, the name of God, and repudiates that of Ṣiva-náráyaná, the name of the founder.

The Dacca Mahant alleges that the peculiar doctrines of his congregation have prevailed for eleven hundred and forty-five years; and that their Granṫha, or book, was unintelligible until Sítala, an inspired Sannyásí, translated it in compliance with a divine command. The translation, consisting of several works in the Devanágarí character, is the undoubted composition of the Rájput Ṣivanáráyaná of Ghazípúr, who wrote it about A.D. 1735.[1]

The most important of these works are the Guru-nyása, and Ṣánta-vilása. The former, compiled from the Puráṇas, gives an

[1] Wilson's "Religious Sects of the Hindus," i, 358. The 1145 years was at first 1145 of the Bengali era, corresponding to A.D. 1738. Buchanan, ii, 137.

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account of the ten Avatárs of Vishnu, or Náráyana, and is subdivided into fourteen chapters, of which the first six treat of the author, of faith, of the punishment of sinners, of virtue, of a future state, and of discipline. The latter is a treatise on moral sentiments. The opening lines are, "The love of God, and His knowledge, is the only true understanding."

The Ṣrí-náráyanas profess the worship of one God, of whom no attributes are predicated. They pay no regard to any objects of Hindu or Muhammedan veneration, and are more strict unitarians than either the Sádhs, or Satnámís. Polygamy is prohibited, and sobriety, virtue, and charity inculcated. They strive to be tolerant, and not to wound the feelings of any sect by openly scoffing at their religious ceremonies. Finally, they admit all classes and races within the pale, and even half castes, or Eurasians, are occasionally enrolled. In Dacca the large majority of the Ṣrí-náráyanas are Dosáds, Dhobís, Chamárs, and other equally low castes.

As with most Hindu sects there are three grades, the Mahant, the holymen, called Sants,[1] and the laity.

The Mahant, or head of the Dacca congregation, a Patit Hindustání Bráhman, asserts that when a boy he accompanied Rám Mohan Rái to England. He initiates disciples by whispering a "mantra" into their ear, and presenting them with a parwánah, or certificate of membership.

The Sants are numerous, but as it is not necessary to relinquish worldly occupations, a person working at any trade or profession may become one, on paying a fee of thirty rupees, and on giving presents of muslin to the Mahant, and a feast to all Sants attending.

Sants are objects of reverence, and whenever one dies in a strange place, the Sants on the spot subscribe and bury him. The funeral procession is impressive, but very noisy. The corpse wrapped in a sheet with a roll of cloth wound round the head is deposited on a covered litter. Red flags flutter from the four corners, and a white cloth acts as a pall. With discordant music, and loud singing, the body is carried to the grave, dug in some waste place, where it is laid flat, not sitting as with the Jogís. The bodies of the lay brethren, on the other hand, are always burned.

The chief festival of the Ṣrí-náráyanas is held on the Ṣrí-panchamí and following day, in Magh (Jan.-Feb.). The Sants, along with representatives of many of the low Hindustání castes, resort to a thatched house, called the Dhámghar, having one large room with verandahs on all sides. At one end is a

[1] From Sanskrit Ṣánta, calmed, free from passions.

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raised earthen platform on which the open Grantha, garlanded with flowers, is laid, and before this each disciple makes obeisance as he enters. The congregation squats all round the room, the women in one corner, listening to a few musicians chanting religious hymns, and smoking tobacco and gánjha, indifferent to the heat, smoke, and stench of the crowded room. The Mahant, escorted by the Sants carrying their parwánas, enters about 1 a.m., when the service begins. It is of the simplest form. The Mahant, after reading a few sentences in Nágarí, unintelligible to most of his hearers, receives offerings of money and fruit. The congregation then disperses, but the majority seat themselves in the verandahs and drink spirits. If the physical endurance of the worshippers be not exhausted, similar services are held for several successive nights, but the ordinary one only lasts two nights.

It is sad to think that a religious body, established as a protest against idolatry and the polytheism of the masses, should have so rapidly and so utterly failed to preserve its original standard; but it has only followed in the same downward path all the reformed Vaishnava and Ṣaiva sects. The Ṣrí-náráyan creed, however, has encountered peculiar difficulties, against which it has succumbed. The lower Hindu castes, ever willing to repudiate Bráhmanical interference, and assert spiritual independence, have always been notorious for profligacy and intemperate habits. Intoxication is with them an irresistible passion, and no threats or corrections have the slightest effect in weaning them from the vice. Faithful servants, kind parents, and affectionate husbands, they have no conception of a moral religion; and their untutored minds can neither understand nor comply with a faith inculcating morality and the mortification of all worldly lusts and passions.

SUTHRÁ-SHÁHÍS.

This is one of the seven subdivisions of the Nának Sháhí faith, and it is a remarkable thing to find it existing in a remote town like Dacca. There is only one Ákhárá belonging to the body in Chúhṛá Bazár, where formerly many cenobites dwelt, but now it is occupied by a solitary Mahant. The sect is a very disreputable one, the members being usually drunkards, or Gánjha smokers. The Mahant supports this character admirably, wandering about on the look out for rich men's houses, before

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which he commences howling Hindustání songs in praise of Nának, and beating time with two pieces of wood. At weddings and other domestic rejoicings he appears uninvited, and by his importunity and shamelessness generally carries off alms in some shape.

The chief objects of worship with this society are Nának Sháh, and the Grantha, or sacred book of the Sikhs, to which on certain occasions flowers and other articles are offered, as is also done by the Nának Sháhís. Suthrá Shahís are often Bráhmans, who do not discard the sacred cord on becoming Udásís. They eat with Bráhmans of their own tribe, but not with all grades of Sikhs. No Sikh, on the other hand, will refuse to partake of "Prasád," or consecrated food, from them. The Suthrá Shahís observe all the great Hindu festivals, and pay special adoration to the "Sálagrám."

NÁNAK-SHÁHÍ.

During the sixteenth century several religious reformers appeared in India, but few were so successful as Nának Sháh. He proclaimed that there was One all-powerful and invisible, to whom men ought to pray; that the only knowledge of any value was the knowledge of God; and that salvation was free to every one who performed good actions and led a virtuous life. These doctrines were denounced, his disciples persecuted, and when Nának died, A.D. 1539, he left a few zealous and devoted followers to propagate his faith. In spite of the oppression and intolerance of the bigoted Aurangzíb in the seventeenth century, the sect prospered and became a nation, which few religious associations in India have ever done, enlisting armies of brave and enthusiastic warriors, and at one time threatening to become the paramount power in Upper India.

It is believed that Nának Sháh visited Dacca, for a large well, in a quarter of the city called J'afarábád, is still pointed out as a place where he sat and drank water. Panjábí sepoys always visit it, and make offerings to their Guru. Futhermore, there is little doubt that his successor, Tegh Bahádur, came to Dacca about 1670, and a portrait, said to have been sketched by himself, still hangs in the Sútrapúr Sangat in the city.

For many generations a small Ákhárá belonging to the Nának-Sháhís has existed in Shujá'atpúr, a northern suburb.

This monastery, situated in the centre of an old Muhammadan garden, surrounded by dense, impenetrable jungle, was assigned

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by a Nawáb of Dacca as a home for the Udásí, or religious sect of Nának Sháh. The first Gosáin was one Níta Sáhib, the disciple of Almat Sháh, who again was the pupil of the son of Nának Sháh. The grave of Nita Sáhib is still shown, as well as a goodly Kámaranga tree (*Averrhóa carambola*) that grew from his toothpick!

The present establishment consists of a Gosáin, or Sunnyásí, who is a Panjábí Bráhman, and an old woman from Hindustan, who accompanied her father on a pilgrimage to Balwá-Khund, in Chittagong, and when he died became a servant (sevaka) and pupil in the monastery. The Gosáin is a tall muscular Sikh, with hair plaited and rolled round his head, and a long necklace of white coral beads around his neck. The chief occupation of the inmates is chanting passages of the "Ṣambhu Grantha," and making frequent oblations to it. Having no endowment, the Gosáin is obliged to visit the city daily in search of alms, and starvation would long ere this have closed the monastery, but for the benevolence of a few Armenian and Muhammadan gentlemen of Dacca. The Gosáin estimates his followers at one hundred, but one half are too poor to contribute anything to his support.

The Nának-Sháhís have adopted many Hindu rites. Special worship is held on the Ṣivarátrí, Doljátrá, and during the Durga Púja. At the foot of a fine Ámlá tree (*Phyllanthus emblica*) in the Ákhárá garden is the Charaṇa, or footprint, of a former Gosáin, which is daubed over with red Abír powder at the Holí festival.

Owing to poverty, the Udásís allege they are obliged to frequent the holy places of the Hindus and observe all their religious ceremonies. When travelling an Udásí carries a lotah, a wooden platter (Kaṭhrá) for alms, a dried gourd, a pair of long pincers (Chimṭá), and a dried deer's skin, while many wear a Kaṛá, or ring, with the same object as the Roman "Citharoedus," described by Juvenal,[1] wore the "fibula."

In the days of the Nawábs there were nine Sangats, or places of worship, belonging to this sect in the city, and within living memory there were three in Mahalla Úrdú; but now there is only one, known as the Sangat of Tegh Bahádur, in Sútrapúr. It, too, is languishing, and the twenty houses forming Sangat-ṭolá being deserted, there is every prospect of the sect becoming extinct in Eastern Bengal. Only four Panjábí Bráhmans reside in the city, and all the old families who attended the services have died off. The Mahant is therefore obliged to take service, the worship at the Sangat being performed by a Panjábí

[1] Sat. vi, 73.

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Chhatrí born in Dacca. Although there is no material difference, there is much latent jealousy, between these two Nának-Sháhí Mahants. The head of the Sangat does not make disciples of Bengali castes as the Shujá'atpúr Gosáin does. The former, again, is chiefly supported by Sikh sepoys quartered in Dacca, the latter by low Bengali castes. The Gosáin eats with the Chhatrí priest, but he will only touch "púrí," cake fried in butter, made by the Gosáin.

The Gṛihí, or married followers of Nának-Sháh, celebrate all the popular Hindu festivals, smoke tobacco, drink Bháng to excess, and wear the long beards and voluminous turbans of the Sikhs.

Among the Udásís of the Nának-Shahí, as well as among Jogí Sannyásís, the miserable creatures, who, having devoted a limb to God's service, hold the outstretched arm so long upright that it becomes fixed.

In 1874, one of these mendicants, a Panjábí Bráhman, aged 40, reached Dacca. His left arm was raised upright, having remained so for nearly thirty years. The arm was much atrophied, the head of the humerus resting on the floor of the axilla, and when accidentally struck acute pain shot through it. The pectoral muscles had shrunk to mere bands, while those that raise the arm were hard and tense. The fingers were bent, and the thumb lay on the first phalanx of the middle finger, the nail having a slight curve upwards, doubtless intentionally produced to prevent its eating into the flesh. The nail of the ring finger from its matrix to the point measured three inches, while that of the forefinger was twisted like a ram's horn.

This man belonged to the Rámráyí subdivision of the Nának-Sháhís, whose head-quarters are in the Deyra Dhún. His dress consisted of garments dyed with yellow ochre, while on his forehead was a sectarial mark painted with wood ashes. He was a vegetarian, abstaining from flesh, fish, and spirits, but he smoked Gánjha to great excess.

TRÍ NÁTH PÚJÁ, TRÍ NÁTH MELÁ.

This fantastic worship of modern date has spread with wonderful rapidity among the fisher and agricultural population of Eastern Bengal, and seems to have been intended to incorporate the three deities, or triad, of the Hindus with the Triune God of the Christians. In Dacca the founder of the sect is said to have been Ánanda Chunder Dás, a constable in the municipal police,

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but as the peculiar ritual of the worshippers has gained followers in Rájsháhí, Pubna, Farrídpúr, and all the eastern districts, it is likely that some one of more influence and education originated it.

The following account is abstracted from a lithographed Bengali pamphlet on the doctrines of this new-fangled worship :—

In the beginning Harí revealed himself as Gaur Rúpa, afterwards as Brahma, Vishnu, and Ṣiv, but on account of the grievous sins of the world he has appeared in these last days as Trínáth, pointing out a new road to salvation. The priesthood had waxed proud, and as wealth accumulated, divine worship became a prerogative of the rich, an impossibility for the poor. The intention of the modern revelation was to limit the expense of worship, and three paisa, a sum within the reach of all, was prescribed as the fitting pecuniary donation. Each worshipper is therefore instructed to buy one paisa worth of Indian hemp, one of betle-nut, and one of mustard oil before entering the meeting house, and on his arrival to pour the oil into a large lamp in the middle of the room, with a wick made of three cotton threads twisted to form one, and to deposit the other articles in a tray common to all.

Before the beginning of the service all join in shouting "Trínáth! Ánanda, Harí! Harí! Bala!" The congregation then squatting around the lamp chew betle, smoke Gánjha, and listen to prayers, and to the Panchálí, or metrical confession of faith, as long as the lamp burns; but as soon as the light flickers, the company disperses.

The Panchálí, or poetical narrative, consists of hymns in praise of Trínáth, and of verses exhorting to faith in the new revelation, and to disbelief in the efficacy of all other creeds. The meetings, always held after sundown, but on no fixed day, may be convened by any one desirous of fulfilling a vow, of averting a threatening calamity, or of returning thanks for the mercies and blessings of the past. Women are rarely present at the meetings, consequently no immorality is practised, but men belonging to all castes associate together at them.

Such is the impious worship that is attracting crowds of uneducated and credulous Chaṇḍáls, Kaibarttas, and Tíyars throughout Eastern Bengal. The influence of the Guru and Purohit is still powerful, but they can only discourage a worship which brings them no honour or reward. It is difficult to account for the rise of such a creed unless we believe that the Brahmanical hold on the people is relaxing, and that the masses blindly accept any worship which recognises the equality and brotherhood of all classes of mankind.

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SECTION III.

HINDU CASTES AND ABORIGINAL RACES.

INTRODUCTORY REMARKS ON CASTE.
NINE CLEAN CASTES.
CASTES HOLDING AN UNCERTAIN POSITION.
UTTERLY VILE CASTES.
HINDUSTÁNI CASTES DEGRADED BY RESIDENCE IN BENGAL.
CASTES AND RACES MET WITH IN EASTERN BENGAL:—

Ahír.—(*a*) GAURIYA—(*b*) MAHISHA GOÁLA.
Bádlá-gar.
Baidyá.
Banpar.
Báotí.
Baqqál.
Barái.
Battí-wálah.
Bediyá.—(*a*) BA-BAJIYÁ—(*b*) BÁZÍ-GAR—(*c*) MÁL—(*d*) MÍR-SHIKÁR—(*e*) SÁMPERIA—(*f*) SHÁNDÁR—(*g*) RASIA.
Berua.
Bhúinhár Bráhmans.
Bhúinmálí.
Bind.
Bráhman.—(*a*) RÁRHÍ—(*b*) VARENDRA—(*c*) VAIDIKA—(*d*) SAPTA-SATI—(*e*) BHAṬ—(*f*) ÁCHÁRJÍ—(*g*) AGRADÁNA.
Cháín.
Chamár.
Chaṇḍál.
Dhobá.
Doí.
Dosádh.
Gaḍarlyá.
Gandha-banik.
Gandhí.
Gaṇrár.
Ghaṭak.
Goála.—(*a*) SÁDA GOÁLA—(*b*) DAIRA GOÁLA.
Godná-wálí.
Halwah Dás.
Jaliyá.
Jauharí.
Jogí.—(*a*) JÁT-JOGÍ.
Kácharu.
Kahár.
Kaibartta.

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Kámár.
Kanaujiyá Bráhmans.
Kándho.
Kándú.
Kánsárí.
Kantha Bráhman.
Kápálí.
Karní.
Karrál.
Kawálí.
Káyath.—(*a*) HINDUSTÁNÍ K.
Kewaṭ.
Khatrí.
Kíchaka.
Kochh Mandai.
Koerí
Kumár.—(*a*) RÁJ-MAHALLIA KUMÁR—(*b*) KUMHÁR.
Kurmí.
Lálbegí.
Lohait-Kori.
Madhu-Nápit.
Maithila Bráhman.
Málákár.
Malláh.
Málo.
Muríárí.
Nápit.
Nar.
Núniyá.
Páchaka.
Paráśara Dás.
Pásí.
Páṭial.
Paṭní.
Ráṅgá Wálah.
Ráwat.
Rishí.
Śánkhárí.
Sarvaria Bráhman.
Sekrí.
Śilarí.
Śonár.—(*a*) BANGA—(*b*) DAKHIN RÁṚHÍ—(*c*) UTTAR RÁṚHÍ—(*d*) NADIYÁ.
Súnri.
Suraiya.
Súraj-bansí.
Sutár.
Tántí.—(*a*) HINDUSTÁNÍ TÁNTÍ.
Támbúlí.
Telí.
Tin-wálah.
Tíyar.
Vaiśya

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HINDU.

THE Hindus of Bengal claim to be pure Aryans, but the Hindus of Upper India repudiate any relationship with them. The Aryan immigration extended gradually throughout Bengal, and the tie which bound the settlers to their faith and peculiar usages was relaxed by residence among aliens. The example of races untrammelled by caste, or religious scruples, also led them to shake off all bonds, and assert greater freedom of action. The priesthood formed illegal connections, and neglected their religious duties; while the mixed offspring observed none of the Bráhmanical ordinances. In the tenth century corruption and irreligion being universal, Adisúra introduced priests, trained in the orthodox school of Kanauj, to reform and educate the people. But the arrival of a small body of religious teachers did little towards elevating the Bráhmans, or laity, and in the twelfth century Ballál Sen found only nineteen families of the Rárhí Bráhmans living in strict obedience to all that their religion demanded. These families were raised to the highest rank, but those who had forfeited all respect, and formed illegal marriages, were reduced to secondary, or even lower grades. The innovations made by this monarch only affected the Rárhí and Varendra Śreṇi, or orders, for the Vaidika and Bhaṭ, refusing to be classified by a Vaidyá, retired into the hill countries of Silhet and Orissa; and the other tribes, who had become hopelessly demoralized, were left untouched.

The chief object of the reform organised by Ballál Sen was the creation of an aristocratic and powerful hierarchy, placed in such a position of dignity that no misdemeanor, and no immorality, could deprive it of hereditary privileges, or the reverence of the lower classes. An illegal marriage was the only transgression entailing loss of rank and forfeiture of respect. No provision was made in this new code for the elevation of the lower ranks, when families became extinct, consequently, as Kulin houses disappeared, the difficulty of procuring husbands for daughters vastly increased, and when the third re-organisation of the order was made by Deví Vara, in the fourteenth century, polygamy, and the buying and selling of wives, was the engrossing occupation of the twice-born Bráhmans.

In spite of these successive endeavours for securing the

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purity of the Bengali Bráhmans, it is remarkable that Kanaujiya, and other Bráhmanical tribes of Hindustan, have always despised and repudiated any connection with their Bengali brethren. In their religious and domestic ceremonies, habits of life, and mode of living, Bengali Bráhmans are quite distinct from any of the other tribes, and the only point of attachment between them is when outcast Kanaujiyas marry Śrotriyá maidens, and become absorbed into their ranks. Although clinging with characteristic pertinacity to all the prerogatives of their order, modern ideas are gradually undermining their bulwarks, and the exclusive rules are step by step yielding to education and the progress of the nation. Kulín Bráhmans are now found adorning the bench, the bar, and the medical profession, and, while proving useful members of society, exert a rare influence for good over their Hindu countrymen.

Besides the Raṛhi and Varendra tribes, there were in Bengal four inferior classes of Bráhmans left out of the organisation of Ballál Sen, namely, the Vaidika, Sapta-śati, Áchárya, and Agradána. The three first claim to have been resident in Bengal before the reign of that monarch, and the services of all the four are still required by the Ráṛhi Śreṇi at many important ceremonies. The Vaidika is the only division that has preserved an honourable position; but whether this is owing to their being descendants of Kanaujiya Bráhmans, to the respectability and decency of their lives, or to their independence of character, is very doubtful. They decline to give their daughters in marriage to the Kulin Bráhmans of Bikrampúr, and refuse to act for any clean Śúdra, or Bráhman, unless his family can trace their origin to Kanauj. The Sapta-śati, undoubtedly one of the oldest Bengali septs, is gradually being absorbed by the Śrotriyá, and few confess they belong to it. In a few years they will be sought for in vain. The Áchárya and Agradána are Bráhmans only in name. The former are chiefly employed in secular occupations, and in discharging duties useful, but unknown to the Vedas or Puráṇas. The Agradána, claiming to rank above Áchárya, is the most despised of the sacred order, and clean Śúdras, as well as Patit Bráhmans, would be degraded by eating with them

The Patit Bráhmans are the most active representatives of the Hindu hierarchy, having fallen from their high estate by neglecting religious duties, officiating in Śúdra temples, marrying into inferior grades, or acting as Purohits to the Varṇa Śankara.[1] The loss of rank has in some respects been mitigated by the affection and devotion of the laity, and by the high

[1] Literally mixture of colours, hence mixture of castes.

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social position given by the caste for which they officiate. It is to this class, abandoned by the Kulins, that India owes the spread of the Hindu religion among the wild tribes of the Taráí, Assam, and Eastern Bengal, and the conversion of the semi-Hinduized aborigines throughout Bengal. Bad and immoral many of these Ṣúdra Bráhmans are, but as a class their lives are not one long course of depravity and selfish indulgence, as is too often the case with the Kulins. Education has made no progress among them, and holding the position they do, concession to the wants of the age is not to be expected. Their hold over the men is slowly loosening, but the women still obey, and worship them, and while this subjection lasts Hindu caste and Hindu exclusiveness will remain.

Though not recognised in books, many social grades are found among these fallen Bráhmans. Those ministering to the Nava-ṣákha,[1] popularly called Ṣúdra Bráhmans, occupy a position of comparative distinction; but at the bottom of the scale Bráhmans appear, who are accounted lower than the vile caste they serve; while such an individual as the Chaṇḍál, or Ḍôm, Bráhman scarcely deserves to be called by that proud title.

The Vaiṣya caste, standing next the sacred order, occupies a very anomalous and strange position. Their claim to be genuine Vaiṣyas is admitted by the higher classes, but the Ballálí Vaidyá and Káyath refuse to touch food prepared by them. This small caste deny that Ballál Sen re-organised, or interfered in any way with their regulations, and for this reason it remains isolated and unrecognised by Hindus.

The two next castes are the Vaidyá and Káyath, who repudiate the name of Ṣúdra, and maintain that Ballál Sen did not enroll them among the "Nava-Ṣákha." Both are satisfied to rest their title of superiority on the fabulous births of their reputed ancestors. Ballál Sen belonged to the Vaidyá caste, and it is to his partiality that it secured pre-eminence. On one section the Bráhmanical cord was bestowed, although the caste profession was a dishonourable one, and Ghaṭaks were engaged to preserve the family purity. There has always existed much latent jealousy between the Vaidyá and Káyath, but the latter acknowledge some inferiority, although the cause of this difference is never defined.

The Káyath is undoubtedly one of the oldest tribes in Bengal, but it is unnecessary to believe all that is said of Ádisúra and the five servants of the five Kanaujiya Bráhmans. One branch, the Bangaja,[2] has been settled for many generations

[1] Or Nava-Ṣayáka, the nine inferior castes.
[2] Banga, or Vanga-ja, Bengali born.

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at Edilpúr, along with the caste Ghaṭaks, and Kulin Káyath families are as punctilious and as vain of their birth as any Gánguli, or Mukharji, although the Lálás of Mathurá and Agra laugh at such pretensions, and will not recognise them as Káyaths at all.

The Kevala, or pure Súdra, does not exist in Bengal. All castes below the Bráhman belong to the "Varṇa-Ṣankara," being the offspring of parents of different tribes.

The recognized authorities on caste are the Institutes of Menu, the Játi Nirṇaya chapter of the Brahma-Vaivartta Puráṇa,[1] and the Játimálá. According to the Bráhmans it was the wickedness of Veṇa, the Rájarshi, who ordered that no worship should be performed, no oblations offered, and no gifts bestowed on Bráhmans, and caused the people to disobey the laws and intermarry with prohibited classes. Until his era Bráhmans only married Bráhmans, Ṣúdras women of their own rank, and Chaṇḍálas followed their own tribal customs. It was natural for the priests to attribute the irreligious propensities of the people to a cause like this; but there is no doubt that laws prescribed by the Bráhmans for maintaining the purity of their order must have been soon violated by those in whose favour they were enacted. Although marriages between individuals of different tribes gave origin to the Varṇa-Ṣankara, or mixed castes, the Puráṇas give other explanations. According to the Brahma-Vaivartta Puráṇa, the gardener, blacksmith, shellcutter, weaver, potter, and brasier are descended from the offspring of Viṣvakarma, the celestial architect, and Ghritáchi, an Apsará, or nymph of heaven, and hence it is that all Kárus, or artisans, worship their progenitor with exceptional reverence. The reasons, again, why certain casts are degraded, are often quite ludicrous, but this does not cause their rejection. The Sútradhára lost rank for refusing to supply the Bráhman with sacrificial wood; the Chitrakára for painting execrably; and the Suvarṇakára for stealing gold given him to mould an idol. The modern Súnrí, moreover, does not resent being told that his ancestor was created from the chips of the mutilated trunk of Ganeṣa, nor the Kumár that Ṣiv transformed a waterpot into the first potter.

According to the classification of Ballál Sen, as interpreted in Eastern Bengal, the nine following castes are considered pure, and the so called Ṣúdra Bráhman officiates for all:—

Ṣánkhárí	Kumár	Gop-Goála
Tántí	Málákár	Madhu Nápit
Kámár	Nápit	Barái.

[1] A Synopsis of this is given in the "Calcutta Review," vol. xv, p. 60.

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Judging, however, by traditions still surviving, the position of a caste in the new roll depended chiefly on its usefulness and importance to the community at large. The profession which had proved itself essential to the comfort, or welfare, of the Hindu hierarchy, was at once promoted to a higher level, while the less important was reduced. Thus the Tántí, unclean in Bihár, became clean in Dacca, and the indispensable barber was raised to the same social level as the Káyasth. The relative position of the various castes is still a burning question in Bengal, and in large villages, where any caste predominates, its claims to superior rank are usually conceded. For instance, the Gandha-banik, Telí, Támbúlí, and Kánsárí often assert to good purpose the right of being enrolled among the nine, and, if their voice be sufficiently loud and influential, it will be heard.

The Nava-Śákha have five servants, or Pancha-vartta, attached to them in common, who possess the prescriptive right of attending at all caste and family celebrations. The five servants are the Bráhman, Málákár, Dhobá, Nápit, and Naṭa, or musician, who are presumed to be exclusively engaged in the service of the Śúdras, but they also earn money by waiting on lower castes. Even now-a-days some work for the Súrya-vansi, who ten years ago were not Hindus in name, while others readily work for the Báotí, Kapálí, Kawálí, Paráśara Dás, and other tribes of doubtful origin. Where the fisher castes are numerous, and cannot be overlooked, no difficulty is found in engaging their services. They work indeed for all castes employing a Patit Bráhman, but the utterly vile tribes, the Bhúinmálí, Chamár, Paṭní, and Súnrí, having Bráhmans of their own, are not served by the Pancha-vartta. To this general rule, however, there are exceptions. The worshipful barber, for instance, condescends to shave, but will not pare the nails of the rich Sáha merchant.

Although caste is no longer revered as an old institution sanctified by religion and immemorial usage, and is disappearing before the assaults of modern civilisation, a tendency to the formation of new castes still exists. Semi-Hinduized races are being enrolled among Hindus, and old established castes are being split up by adopting new occupations. But if this new occupation be not dishonouring, the Purohit continues his ministration. For instance, the great Chaṇḍál tribe has given off eight branches, yet the Chaṇḍál Bráhman officiates for all. On the other hand, the agricultural Kaibarttas, having taken to a base employment, are obliged to support a Purohit of their own.

Between the Śúdras and the Nícha, or vile, castes many tribes, organised by degraded Bráhmans, or united by the exigencies of modern civilisation, are found occupying an

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uncertain position, exposed to the sneers of the exclusive and conservative Ṣúdras.

These intermediate castes are:—

Báotí	Karrál
Baqqál	Kawálí
Bhát	Lohait Korí
Beṛua	Nar
Halwah Dás	Paráṣara Dás
Kándho	Páṭial
Kapálí	Sutár.
Karní	

In the Tantras,[1] the epithet Antya-ja, or inferior, is applied to the following seven tribes, washerman, currier, mimic (Naṭa), fisherman, "Meda," or attendant on women, cane-splitter (Varuḍa) and mountaineer (Bhilla). The term Antyávasáyin, or dwellers outside the town, was given to the Dôm, Pan, Háṛí, and other sweeper castes.

We however possess a very correct list[2] of the outcast tribes in Bengal in the roll of pilgrims excluded from the temple of Jagannáth. If prohibited castes are distinguished from professions there are only eleven castes so utterly disreputable that they dare not enter the sanctuary. These are the

Súnṛí	Chamár
Nama-Ṣúdra	Dôm
Dhobá	Tíyar
Jogí	Bhúinmálí
Kahár	Háṛí.
Ráj-Vaṇsi	

Much information regarding caste, as understood in Bengal, is obtained by comparing the relative position of Hindustánís who reside, or temporarily sojourn there, with that of castes native to the province.

Permanent residence is always attended by social expulsion, but a stay of a few years is with some castes a disqualification, with others it is not so. For example, the Ahír, Surahiyá, and Kanaujiyá Bráhmans, who keep up communication with their kindred and marry from their own homes, are reckoned pure; but the Kahár, Ahír, and Kándú domiciled in Bengal forfeit all claim to be considered stainless. By adopting local Ṣúdra customs and marrying with women of the country Hindustání tribes are stigmatized as "Khoṇṭá," or debased. The Kanaujiya Bráhman, again, expelled by his family for these delinquencies, finds shelter in the ranks of the Ṣrotriyá, but above this he

[1] Colebrooke's "Essays" ii, 164.
[2] Harington's "Analysis" iii, 213; Hunter's "Orissa" i 136.

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cannot expect to rise, and his children must be content with a very ambiguous position.

The steps by which a Hindustání caste loses its original rank, and gains a new one, may be traced in the case of the potters. The Kumhár of Bihár is always unclean in Bengal, but if he marries a kinswoman he may return to his home without loss of rank. The Ráj-Mahallia potters, however, being in an intermediate state, have neither risen to an equality with the Bengali Kumár, nor remained unclean like the Kumhár. The Śúdras of Bengal drink from their water vessels, and, still more blessed, the Śúdra Bráhman ministers unto them. Lastly, the Bengali Kumár, originally of the same stock, has become in the course of ages a pure Śúdra, and one of the Nava-Śákha.

In no instance, however, is the separation between kindred castes so striking as with the Chamárs and Rishís. Both belong to the same tribe, both are equally vile in the eyes of Hindus, and both live apart from all other castes, yet similar occupations not only excite jealousy and enmity but prevent all friendly intercourse between them.

Occupations, moreover, which a Hindustání may engage in at home without stain or obliquy are sometimes unbecoming when the habitation is in Bengal. Thus the Dômni and Chamáin, professional musicians in Upper India, are disgraced by plying for hire in Bengal, while on the other hand such menial work as the Mungírya Tántís perform in Daca would be considered very debasing in their own district.

Although continuous residence at a distance usually repels, a brief sojourn sometimes draws together disunited subdivisions. Thus the different branches of Ahírs and Chhatrís intermarry in Bengal and lose caste, although debarred from doing so in Hindustan.

The Bráhmanical order to which the Purohit belongs is generally a nice test of the rank accorded to a Hindustání caste. Among the lower tribes the Guru belongs either to one of the Daśnámí orders, or he is a Vaishnava Bhagat,[1] who visits his flock at regular intervals, confirming the old, and teaching the young the rudiments of their faith. Maithila Bráhmans, on the other hand, ordinarily act as Purohits to Kurmí, Chhatrí, Kándú, Ahír, Cháin, and Kewaṭ; but Chhatrís are occasionally found with a Sarsút, or Sarasvatí, Bráhman, and Kurmís and Dosádhs with a Śákadvípa. The Kanaujiya tribe again ministers to Binds, Tántís, and Gádaṛiyás. In the case of the Raṇḍa Khatrís whose parentage is equivocal, the strange phase is found of a Kanaujiya acting as Purohit, a Śrotriyá of Bengal as Guru.

[1] A corruption of Sanskrit Bhakta, "the devoted," hence a mendicant.

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A most important distinction between Hindustání and Bengali castes of similar origin, is the religious belief found among them. It may be said with perfect truth that Vaishnavism, in one or other of its diverse forms, to the exclusion of Ṣaivaism and all other creeds, is the faith professed by the agricultural, artizan, and fisher tribes of Bengal. The worship of Kṛishna has, for obvious reasons, attracted well nigh all the Goála, and other pastoral tribes of India. The teaching of Chaitanya and his successors has made little progress among Hindustání castes, but the sympathetic creeds of Kabír and Nának Sháh have attracted multitudes of disciples. The Kurmís and Dosádhs especially patronize Kabír; the Kewaṭs, Kumhárs, and many Dosádhs enroll themselves under the banner of Nának.

It is among castes from Northern Bengal, such as the Kándú, Bind, Muriárí, and Surahiyá, that the followers of the strange Pánch Píriya creed are to be met with. Other curious sects, unknown to Bengal, are also found in their ranks. The Tirhutiyá Tántís are members of the Buddh Rám communion. Kurmís often profess the doctrines taught by Darya Dás, and many Dosádhs those of Tulasí Dás. Still more worthy of notice is the existence among them of an old prehistoric cultus. The apotheosis of robber chiefs by Dosádhs, the deification of evil spirits, as Rahu by the Dosádhs, Kasi Baba by Binds, and Madhu Kunwár by Tántís, and the animistic idea endowing with life and personality the destructive energy of the Ganges, are all forms of belief unknown to castes native to Bengal.

AHÍR. ÁBHÍRA.

This important Hindustání pastoral caste is frequently met with in Eastern Bengal, the members assuming a superiority over the Goála, and refusing to hold any social intercourse with it. The Ahír forfeits caste privileges by settling in Bengal, but if he only resides for a short time, a wife can be got from his home in Bihár.

In Gorakhpúr the Ahír stands immediately below the Káyath, being regarded as a pure Ṣúdra; but in Bengal he is impure in the eyes of Ṣúdras and Gop-Goálas.

Ahírs are generally handsome, with fine delicate features, retaining in Bengal their ancestral love of spirits and pork. The tribe is known everywhere by a ceremony, peculiar to itself, called Gáe-dágha, Gáe-dhar, or Gokrirah. On the day

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after the Díwálí, and on the day before the new moon of Kártik (Sept.-Oct.), Ahírs place a cow, which has lately calved, within an enclosure where a pig is confined. They beat drums, sing, and shout outside until the cow, maddened by the din, gores or butts the pig to death, when the carcass is removed, cooked, and eaten.[1]

The flesh of the wild pig is also esteemed a great delicacy by Ahírs, and when procurable is made the occasion of much conviviality.

In Bengal the subdivisions of the Ahirs are—

Kanaujiyá,	Puchiára,
Maghaiyá,	Kṛishnautí,
Majrotí,	Gauṛiya.
Mungíryá,	

As with other composite castes the subdivisions vary according to locality, and clannish prejudices disappear in a foreign land. For instance, in Dacca the Mungíryá and Gauṛiyá intermarry, although it is forbidden in Bihár.

All Ahírs in Dacca belong to a "gotra," called Kaṣyapa, and the majority worship Krishna, only a few following the Ṣákta ritual. Ahírs observe the Sráddha on the eleventh day after death, and their funeral service is performed by the Mahá-pátra, or Kantha, Bráhman.

Ahírs sell milk, but are degraded by making butter, curds, or clotted milk. Bullocks cannot properly be used by Hindus in the plough or oil-mill, but the Ahír has no compunction about selling a vicious or unmanageable bull to the Muhammadan Kolú.

Bengal Ahírs never prepare the yellow paint called "Pewri,"[2] as is done in Mungír, although the Palaṣa tree (*Butea frondosa*) is one of the commonest jungle trees.

(*a*) Gauṛiyá.

The Gauṛiyá is the most numerous subdivision of Ahírs in Bengal, and to it belong the Uriya palanquin bearers of Calcutta, and the professional Laṭhiáls, or clubmen, of Kishnaghur and Jessore.

In Eastern Bengal they are reckoned a very impure race who castrate bulls, brand cattle, and act as cow-doctors, being on this account generally styled Go-baidyá, or Dághania Goálás.[3]

[1] This cow baiting exactly resembles the Binda-parab of the Bhúmij. Dalton, "Descriptive Ethnology," p. 176.

[2] Sanskrit Go-rochana, and used for painting Hindu sectarial marks, and walls of bungalows.

[3] In Northern Bengal the cow-doctor is called Hádiq.

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These Ahírs, chiefly residing in Jessore, have become naturalised in Bengal as cultivators, resembling in physique and appearance the common Bengali peasantry, though they still employ a few Hindi words when speaking the vernacular. It is alleged that in Jessore the Gauṛiyá is reckoned a pure Ṣúdra caste, but farther east utterly abominable. A Patit Bráhman ministers at their religious ceremonies, which are distinct from those observed by the Goálá of the Ballálí country. No genuine Ṣúdra Goálá would do the menial work of the Go-baidyá, nevertheless, a fallen tribe of Goálas in Tipperah is said to practise as cow-doctors.

The Gauṛiya have only one gotra, the Aliman.

During the cold season the Go-baidyás wander throughout the country, and in villages may be distinguished by the cry "Goru dágha ba!" or simply "Kemon!" How is it?

Preparatory to branding or operating on animals, the Go-baidyás always invoke Kṛishná and the two Páṇḍava brothers, Nakula and Sahadeva. They use skewers and awls of different shapes and sizes for opening abscesses and puncturing swollen houghs, but deny that they ever castrate bulls, and certainly no cutting instrument is ever found in their wallets. The Ṛishí and Hajjám, however, who undoubtedly do so, positively assert that the Go-baidyá is the recognised operator.

Go-baidyás brand the cattle of the peasantry, and treat the diseases of domestic animals with a few simples. In swollen joints they administer mashes of wild fig leaves and salt, or of the Arum, heated with salt, while they wrap the joint with poultices of pounded leaves. In œdema of the head the forehead is freely cauterised with two red hot iron hooks (dágh), which are also employed in making the common reversed semicircular marks on native cattle.

In small-pox (Basanta) Go-baidyás trust to a mash of "Ním" leaves, wild ginger, green turmeric, and the pounded bark of the Seorhá tree; while in catarrhs wild fig leaves are said to be very beneficial.

(*b*) Mahisha Goálá.

The Mahisha, or, as they are called in the Dacca dialect, Maisan, Goálás, derive their name from Mahisha, the Sanskrit for a buffalo, and were originally Ahírs from Patna and Mungír, who have been settled for several generations in Eastern Bengal. In towns, having ceased to keep buffaloes, they own dairies, and sell milk.

On the uncultivated "chars" or islands of the Dhullaserry, these Bengalí-speaking Ahírs tend herds of buffaloes belonging

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to Sáha merchants, and sell the milk to Gop-Goálás, who pay in advance for it. The herdsman keeps a daily account of the quantity sold, and at the end of each month his tale of milk is balanced, and compared with that kept by the purchaser.

Buffaloes give from four to five pounds of milk daily, a smaller quantity than in Bihár; but the "ghí" prepared from it is more highly priced, and more palatable, according to native taste, than "ghí" made from cow's milk. Bull calves are always sold as victims for sacrifices, the Bhúinmálí and Ṛishí eating the flesh, and the latter tanning the hides. As the annual inundation subsides, wild bulls from the neighbouring jungles of Bhowál visit the herds, and after remaining several weeks with the cows, revert to their wild habits.

Widow marriages, and the Gáe-dágha ceremony, are no longer observed.

BÁDLÁ-GAR.

The trade of wire drawing, or Tár-kash, is followed by Hindus of all castes, and sometimes by Muhammadans, in a very primitive manner.

Silver wire is heated, and merely passed through apertures in a steel plate, according to the fineness wanted. In gilding silver the following method is adopted. China gold leaf wrapped round the silver is put over a charcoal fire, and slowly heated. When partially fuzed it is withdrawn, and burnished with "Lahsan patthar," perhaps soapstone, after which it is drawn into wire, and sold to workers in Zardozí, or Zarí, and Kárchob.[1]

The Bádlá-gar also manufactures "chamkí," or spangles, and Gokhru-goṭa, or filigree ankle bells.

BAIDYÁ, VAIDYÁ, BAID, VAIDA.

The Baidyá is one of the most respected castes in Bengal. ranking immediately after the Vaiṣyas, and before the Káyaths. They are peculiar to Bengal, and in Bihár the Ṣákadvíp Bráhmans are the regular physicians.

The origin of the Baidyá caste is unknown, but the following tradition satisfies the curiosity of the Hindus. In the house of Gálava Muní was a Vaiṣya damsel, named Ambá, who one day

[1] In Dacca Zardozí often means muslins embroidered with gold or silver thread, in contradistinction to Kárchob, or brocade.

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returning from the river met the sage, and was asked for a drink of water, which she gave. The Muní blessed her, and said, "May you have many children!" She laughingly replied, "How can I, an unmarried girl, have children?" The sage having expressed the wish could not recall it, so he ordered her to bring a wisp of Kuṣa grass, which he transformed into a male child; the girl was naturally bewildered by the gift, as she could not return home, where eviction was certain, so the Muní sent for a Brahman and made him marry her. This miraculous child, called Ámṛita Ácháryá, was instructed by Gálava Muní in the Áyur-Veda, or science of medicine. It is also related that by her Bráhman husband Ambá bore, among other children, a son called Ambashṭha, the father of such as practise medicine.

Under Bráhmanical rule the physician was not highly esteemed, and when a Bráhman encountered one on his return from bathing, he was polluted and obliged to go back and wash his clothes before touching food. In Menu we are informed that physicians and surgeons acting unskilfully must pay to the injured party the middle amercement.[1] The Sanskrit name for a physician is Chikit-saka, from Chikit, understanding, or Agadankára, "one who makes well," and it is said that he had charge of dispensaries (Aushadha-álaya, or Aushadha-ágára), where ready-made medicines were prepared and sold.

Although we know nothing of the origin of the Baidyá caste, history tells us that a Baidyá dynasty ruled over Bengal during the eleventh and twelfth centuries. The most famous of these Rájahs were Ballál Sena, and his supposititious son, Lakshmaṇa Sena, and it is to the domestic quarrels of the royal family that the separation of the caste into two divisions is popularly referred. Before their time, it is said, all Baidyás belonged to one clan, the members of which intermarried with one another as all were equal in rank. Ballál Sen, however, having determined on marrying a Dôm-Paṭní girl, his son Lakshmaṇa Sen, and the majority of the caste, protested against its legality, and on finding their remonstrances unheeded, broke the sacred cord, which all Baidyás then wore, and retired into a distant part of the country, where their descendants have ever since preserved the singularity of never wearing a "paitá."[2] The dishonour inflicted on the caste recoiled, it is related, on the head of its author, and Ballál Sen sought in vain for a Baidyá bride for his younger son.

At the present day Baidyás are subdivided into families following the peculiar rites of the Vaiṣyas (Vaiṣya-áchár), and wearing the sacred cord, and others practising the Ṣúdra rites

[1] Menu, ix, 284.
[2] From Sanskrit Pavitra, the sacred thread.

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(Ṣúdra áchár); but any member of the caste can assume the cord on his complying with the proper regulations of investiture.

A tradition survives, that Ballál Sen, among his other popular reforms, separated the Baidyás into three classes, Varendra, Ráṛhí, and Banga, according to the place of their abode, and conferred the rank of Kulins on the Dhanvantarí and Madhu Kuliyá gotras. In course of time, owing to the frequent marriages of blood relations, the Hingu gotra was also included among the Kulin class. The Baidyás were finally distributed in twenty-seven "stháns," or communes, beyond which no one could reside without loss of caste. The principal settlements were at Shinátí, Chandam Mahál, Daspárá, Puígráma, Karoria, Shendia, Itna, and Bhutta-pratáp in Jessore, Poragáchha in Bikrampúr, and Dásora and Chánd-pratáp in Dacca.

In 1872 the census returns exhibit a total of 68,353 Baidyás in Bengal proper, of whom 37,180, or 54 per cent., resided in Eastern Bengal; while in Báqirganj there were 12,960; in Dacca 8,420; in Burdwán 5,004; in the twenty-four Parganahs 4,556; and in Silhet 3,291.

The Samáj-patí, or presidency of the Banga Baidyás, has for several generations been vested in the family of Rájah Ráj Bullabh of Rájnagar, who reside on the south bank of the Padma river, but though now poor and dependent, the members are still consulted on all tribal matters. Formerly, Bráhmans ate whatever the Baidyá prepared with milk, or ghí; but now they refuse to do so, at least in public. The caste Bráhmans deny that they are Ṣúdras, but it is the fact that the Bráhmans who officiate for the Nava-ṣákha also officiate for Baidyás.

A Baidyá who wears the sacred cord is prohibited from marrying into a household which does not; but in Silhet, beyond the range of the regulations of Ballál Sen, Baidyás, Káyaths, and even Súnrís are at liberty to intermarry. When equals marry a curious custom is observed by Baidyás. A bond is executed notifying that the bridegroom has received twelve rupees, but should a second son marry he executes a bond for twenty-four, and if a third, the acknowledgement is for thirty-six, but beyond this it never goes. Again, if a Baidyá marries into an inferior gotra, he is dishonoured, and can only recover his social position by marrying his sister, or daughter, into a Kulin family, hence a common saying in Bengal, that rising and falling is the Baidyá's kul, or lot.

The four principal gotras of the Banga Baidyás are—

Dhanvantarí,	Ṣaktrí,
Madhu Kuliyá,	Kaṣyapa.

The most important "Padavís," or titles, are—

Sen, Dás, Gupta.

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The first belong to the Dhanvantarí and Ṣaktrí gotras, the second to the Madhu Kuliyá, and the third to the Kaṣyapa.

Baidyás wearing the Bráhmanical cord mourn fifteen days: those who do not for thirty. All old Baidyá families are Ṣákta worshippers, but among the poorer classes Vaishnavas are occasionally found. This caste has Ghaṭaks of its own, and formerly the Haḍa division of the Gauṇa Kulin Bráhmans acted in this capacity, but for many years past members of their own caste have officiated. This innovation originated with one Viṣvaratha of Jessore, who is reputed to have been the first legitimate Baidyá Ghaṭak.

Many of the caste have lately become Brahmos, and been excommunicated, until they can establish to the satisfaction of the Samáj-patí that the secession from Hindu belief and domestic usages has not been predetermined.

The practice of medicine is the proper profession of the Baidyá caste, but for many years it has sent forth young men who have distinguished themselves at the bar, and as agents, managers, and schoolmasters, whilst others have taken to the study of English medicine, and become Bengali class native doctors in the service of Government.

The Kabíráj, or medical practitioner according to the Hindu system, is found in almost every village of Eastern Bengal, and the most respected among them are generally Baidyás. Although it is the fashion to disparage this class, the educated among them are useful and deserving members of native society, occupying a position that cannot be more efficiently filled under present circumstances. The good that they do is rarely heard of, and the malpractices of the legion of uneducated quacks throughout Bengal are laid to their charge.

Kabírájs usually assume bombastic titles, such as Kabí-ratna, Kabí-sanjan, Kabí-chandra, Kabí-Indra, Kabí-bhúshaṇa Kabí-bullabha, and Baidyá-nidhí; but the popular nickname for all doctors is Náṛí-ṭepá, or pulse-feeler. Uneducated practioners and quacks are known as Háthuria,[1] or meddlesome fellows, from "háth," the hand; while a still more objectionable and dangerous character is the Ta'líqa Kabíráj, who goes about with a list (ta'líq) of prescriptions, selling them at random, and vaunting their virtues in curing all diseases. He is often a plucked student of the Calcutta College, or a young man too poor to prosecute his studies until qualified for graduation.

Formerly, medicine was taught in Páthsálas, or schools, the most famous being those of Bikrampúr and Kánchrapáṛá, on the Hughli; but at the present day each practitioner of any reputa-

[1] Buchanan, iii, 142, derives this sobriquet from Hát, a market.

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tion has a "ṭol," or class, of pupils to whom he translates and expounds the Ṣástras, if the youths understand Sanskrit, but if they do not he merely lectures on the principles and practice of Hindu medicine. A class generally consists of from ten to twelve young men of various Ṣúdra castes, and it is computed that about twelve per cent. of the Dacca Kabírájs are sufficiently versed in Sanskrit to interpret it.

The two principal text books of the Bengal physicians are the Mádhava Nidána, or commentary on the Áyur-veda, and the Chakra-váṇí. The former, written by a celebrated doctor, Mádhava-Kara, chiefly treats of the diagnosis of diseases, while the latter, named after the writer, who was physician and steward of the court of Gaur, is a later and less valued work. Each Kabíraj has a particular master and system, but the greatest teacher, Dhanvantarí, the physician of the gods, is obeyed by all. In the Brahma-Vaivartta Puráṇa the names of fifteen great physicians are preserved, but only the following six are invoked by the modern doctor, namely:—

Dhanvantarí,	Aṣvinau,
Divodasa,	Nakula,
Káṣi Rája,	Saha-deva.

The first three are often identified with one person, the fifth and sixth are the twin sons of Súrya, the physicians of Svarga, or heaven. On all occasions of anxiety Mahádeva, or Vaidya-nátha, "lord of physicians," is also addressed in prayer.

The chief causes of the stagnation of Hindu medicine, which has lasted from prehistoric times, appear to be the discontinuance of the study of anatomy, the belief that the medical Ṣástras, being of divine origin, are infallible, and the selfishness of successive generations of physicians in concealing the results of their experience and observation. Kabírájs of the present day often blindly follow the teaching of the Áyur-veda, notwithstanding the opinion that the habits and constitution of the human race, and the prevailing type of diseases, have altered since the archaic days of their teachers.

The candid physician confesses that his brethren have not the magnanimity to divulge the merits of a drug which chance, or experience, has taught them to value; and although it is revealed to a son, or favourite pupil, the secret is kept from the profession at large, and consequently is often lost at the death of the discoverer.

The real Baidyá always dispenses his own prescriptions, but as this consumes much time and necessitates his limiting the number of his patients, apprentices are employed in pounding and triturating drugs, while the minute subdivision into powders

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is done by himself in a private recess of the house. Before beginning this work, the Baidyá observes a custom, peculiar to physicians of his caste, namely, the worship of Vaidya-nátha, after which the medicine is divided into four parts, one being offered to the Elements, a second to a Bráhman, a third being retained by the physician, and a fourth sent to the patient. As a rule drugs are procured from the shop of the Gandha-banik, or Pansárí, but in olden days the physician had to go himself to the forest and collect whatever herb he wanted, and the most successful Kabíráj now in the Dacca district refers his good fortune to the trouble he is at in gathering and verifying the genuineness of the drugs used.

The principal difference between the practice of one Kabíráj and another is, that the works of different commentators on the Áyur-veda are followed. The practice is thus modified, and often inconsistent, while all agree that the fundamental principles of medicine are unchangeable, and that the causes of disease are the same now as they were in Vedic days.

Consultations are usually held in difficult cases, but the physician who can quote the Śástras most fluently and interminably, is too often deemed the most learned and skilful doctor. Although the Śástras declare that physic given by the hands of a Baidyá has an intrinsic virtue not possessed when it is administered by any other caste, the populace have no such conviction, and as soon as the treatment of a Baidyá fails the patient has no hesitation in placing himself under any other doctor, whatever his caste, or colour, who has acquired the reputation of curing his particular ailment.

Kabírájs, who can afford to be so, are often charitable, giving advice gratis to the poor, and at times treating the sick in a room reserved for them. At the present day Kabírájs are preferred by all Hindus of the old school, as the minute attention paid to diet and temperament is in keeping with the popular ideas, and the way in which European doctors ignore, or disregard, matters so important is especially reprehended. In acute diseases the Kabíraj admits that the European physician far surpasses him in knowledge, but he claims to treat chronic and lingering diseases with greater success. It may be that in the obscurer effects of malaria, and in cachexiæ the consequence of blood poisoning, the medical treatment of the native practitioners is so very efficacious as to explain the greater reliance placed on it than on the routine practice followed in the dispensaries and hospitals throughout Bengal; but no competent person has thought it worth his while to confirm, or refute, a belief which is universally held by the natives of Bengal.

The present state of Hindu medicine in Eastern Bengal is

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sketched in the following particulars, obtained from the Kabírájs themselves.

Kábírájs believe that the human race has degenerated, and that the constitutions of the present generation have changed, and they cite as an instance the type of fever now prevalent, which is more acute and less tractable than the fevers described in the Śástras. In these works it is enjoined, that for seven days no medicines are to be given to a patient, and that he is to fast, or only take liquid food; but now, as soon as a diagnosis is formed, and a propitious hour found, the first dose is given. The examination of the pulse is regarded of primary importance, and many doctors are credited with being able to distinguish a disease by its character. The inspection of the urine is not considered, as it is by the Hakím, of much value, for should a drop touch the physician he becomes unclean, and must at once bathe. When it is inspected the sample is always mixed with mustard oil, and the density of the water estimated by the buoyancy of the oil.

Venesection is never performed at the present day, as the type of the ordinary diseases contra-indicates its use; but cupping or leeches are occasionally ordered. In apoplexy, and some forms of hysteria, the actual cautery is still employed, and the potential cautery (Kshára) is used for destroying piles, and, in a fine state of division, is made into an embrocation, and applied over the enlarged spleen and liver.

In the Śástras, enemata are recommended, but, whether, owing to the clumsy syringes employed, or to the strange aversion of all Muhammadan nations to their use, Hindu physicians ceased to order them. Kabírájs, however, are beginning to follow the example of English doctors, but much latent opposition is encountered.

Hindu physicians have arrived at the following conclusions regarding the most valued European drugs. Quinine, in extensive use throughout Bengal, is popularly regarded as a heating remedy, and as causing, when injudiciously used, the fever to take a permanent hold, or to return after a short interval. The masses further believe that it drives the fever into the bones, and that, if once taken, it prevents all other febrifuges from being of the slightest benefit. As a tonic, however, during convalescence from fever, it is admitted by all to be invaluable and unequalled.

With educated practitioners the use of mercury has quite gone out of fashion, and iodide of potassium taken its place; but the victims of its abuse are still lamentably common, and scarcely a hospital in Bengal is ever without several poor creatures permanently maimed, or disfigured by it.

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English, or American, sarsaparilla is not much esteemed, as a "pát" of from nine to sixty ingredients is considered a better alterative. The patient being given twenty-one powders, made of a jumble of herbs, takes one daily and boils it in a ser of water until only a quarter remains, then straining and putting aside the sediment, he drinks the decoction. After the twenty-one days have expired, all the sediments are taken, reboiled, and the decoction drunk for eleven days longer. Finally, the sediment is put into boiling water, and with it the patient takes a vapour bath (Bhapárá).

Cod-liver oil is considered inferior as a nutrient tonic to divers pills and powders prepared by Kabírájs, and in consumption an oil, called "Sárchandanadí," made of Til oil and numerous herbs, is pronounced more beneficial.

Chicken broth, prohibited in health, is often prescribed in lingering diseases, while the good effects of port wine and brandy, in the treatment of low types of fever, are acknowledged.

Pills prepared at English druggists are objected to as the magnesia sprinkled over them interferes, it is thought, with the action of the medicine, consequently the Hindu pills rolled with the fingers, and mixed with honey, or the juice of the Belá, or Pân leaf, are preferred.

Such are the condition and opinions of the better class of native physicians, but the description would be incomplete if it omitted all allusion to the uneducated practitioner met with in every village of Bengal, who secures an extensive, and by no means unprofitable, practice among classes unable to pay for better medical advice. He is often a superannuated barber, or fisherman, who has obtained from some strolling "bairágí," or "faqír" a receipt to cure all diseases. The credulity of the average native is astounding, and even persons of education and high position display wonderful faith in the assertions of quacks vaunting the discovery of some new panacea. There is perhaps no single complaint which so often awakens the inventive faculty of such men as enlargement of the spleen, and he who acquires notoriety as the possessor of a remedy is courted by all classes. A very nutritious diet of milk, fish, and vegetables is always ordered by these shrewd observers, and is generally assigned by sceptics as the explanation of cures which they undoubtedly sometimes effect. The following instances are given in proof of the unsatisfactory appreciation of medicine by the lower classes of Bengal.

In March, 1874, a cloth merchant returned from Lucknow, cured by one 'Urf Husain, of an asthma of twenty-four years standing, and instructed how to cure all diseases, by spitting on and licking the seat of pain, and by rubbing wood ashes over

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the part. On his arrival in Dacca he exhibited his wonderful powers, which were the more readily believed as he demanded no remuneration, and was satisfied with the fame of his good actions. For weeks from fifty to a hundred patients daily thronged his courtyard, and rumours spread that the novel treatment had the most miraculous result in the most hopeless cases. After a short and prosperous career failures became so numerous, and the cures so very equivocal, that patients ceased to attend, his popularity waned, and the fickle people sought a new pretender.

Another amateur doctor, residing in the outskirks of Dacca, earned a more lasting reputation by using a vesicatory made with the root of the "Kálá-chítra," and applied over the spleen. He, however, assigned much of its efficacy to a secret invocation, addressed, in the act of applying the paste, to Lakhí Náráyaṇa. The Hindu, moreover, relies as much on the virtues of a cup of water, over which a mantra has been mumbled, as any Muhammadan peasant, and the water of the Ganges, water taken from a tidal river at the turn of the tide, or water in which the Gosáin has bathed, have each their crowd of admirers.

In Bengal, as in ancient Egypt and Greece, certain shrines are still celebrated for the cure of intractable diseases. The most famous are those of Tárá-Keṣvara in Hughli, sacred to Mahádeva; of Vaidyanátha in Bírbhúm; and of Gondulpárá in Hughli, famous in cases of hydrophobia. The device followed at the last place is for the bitten person, after fasting, to defray the expense of a special service, and to receive a piece of red broadcloth (Sulṭání banát), impregnated with the snuff of a lamp wick, and secreted in the heart of a plantain, called "Kathálí Kelá." As long as this charm is preserved, and the patient abstains from eating this variety of plantain, the effects of the bite are warded off.

With a people who think and act in this blind, irrational manner, any change to more sound and enlightened modes of thought must be slow. When we still find the lower classes of Scotch and Irish relying on the virtues of certain springs, and believing in the wondrous cures effected by them, we cannot hope that the Hindu will speedily relinquish his faith in miracles and his unreasoning acceptance of every imposture; but a great change is already in progress, and the spread of dispensaries, and of native doctors educated according to English ideas, is doing as much to advance the people, and to awaken among them self-reliance and healthy scepticism, as any other influence directed against the ignorance and credulity of the East.

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BANPAR.

The Banpar, or Gauri (? Gonṛhí) Banpar, as they prefer calling themselves, belong to a caste of degraded fishermen and boatmen from Patna and Bihár. Buchanan considered them as a branch of the Koerí, dishonoured by becoming fishermen; but the tribe has sunk so much lower than any offshoot of a clean caste ever does, that it seems far more probable to assign them an aboriginal origin. In Bihár the Banpar, objecting to till the soil, live by fishing and trading. They are skilful sportsmen, entrapping the alligator (magar) and Ghaṛiyál in strong rope nets and eating their flesh. Although this is, according to Hindu ideas, a sufficient explanation of their low position, it is a curious circumstance that, like the Málo of Bengal, their being outcasted is referred to the peculiarity of passing the netting needle the wrong way, from above downwards, and not to any penchant for forbidden flesh.

BÁOTÍ, BÁITÍ.

In Bengal this small caste is usually called Chúnarí, or Chúniya, from being engaged in the manufacture of lime (Chúná), and is chiefly found on the borders of the large marshes in Bikrampúr. In the census rolls the Báití are returned along with the beggar and vagabond classes, and it is probable they are the same as the "Báorí," a vagrant tribe in the Gangetic delta and west of Delhi, who subsist chiefly by stealing.[1]

In Dacca they all belong to one gotra, the Aliman, but in the Farrídpúr district there is an outcaste Magí subdivision.

The Purohit is a Patit Bráhman, and the caste is mainly a Vaishnava one. The only titles met with are Rái, Bhúya, and Sen.

The Báotí do not gather shells, but Bediyás occasionally do, and fishermen from the Murshídábad district come annually in March and April to collect them. The common swamp shells are almost useless, while a small univalve, called "Mojia," formerly found in abundance, and repaying the cost of burning, has become so scarce that it is now never sought after. The best fishing ground is the Kamargangá river in Farrídpur, and the only shells calcined by the Báotí are the "Ghonghá," "Sípí," and Shámuk, the molluscs (gíta) being extracted by an iron hook. A "*man*" (80 lbs) of shells, costing from fourteen to

[1] Wilson's "Glossary," p. 61.

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twenty anas, produces, when calcined, about four "*mans*" of lime, which sells for about an ana a seer (2 lbs). The Káthuria Sutárs are the only other class of Bengalis engaged in lime burning.

Although the Báotí is one of the most impure of Bengali castes, their water vessels defiling any pure Hindu, no one will refuse to chew lime moistened with water from these very same vessels.

Kabírájs purchase unslaked lime (Gúra-chúná) from the Báotí for medicinal purposes, while the finest and most expensive lime for chewing, "Panka-Chúná," is prepared with the ashes of tamarind wood.

The Ṣúdra barber and washerman work for the Báotí, but the Bhúinmálí, owing to some party grudge, will not, and the Muhammadan Beldár has to be engaged whenever the Báotí has a house to build, or a ditch to dig.[1]

BAQQÁL.

This Arabic name for a grain merchant is a title assumed by a few Chaṇḍáls, who neither eat nor intermarry with the parent stock, although their Bráhman is the same. The Baqqáls are wandering traders who retail turmeric, bay-leaves, rice, ginger, and other condiments in inland villages and markets. They are chiefly met with in the Ja'farganj and Mánikganj parganas of Dacca. They will not cultivate the soil, but, possessing cargo boats of their own, navigate them without any hired servants. All belong to one gotra, the Kaṣyapa, and the majority follow the Kṛishna Mantra.

Having assumed a higher and more respectable position than the Chaṇḍáls, they have renounced the drinking of spirits and the eating of pork.

BARAÍ.

The Bengali caste of Hindus engaged in cultivating Pân is generally included among the Nava-Ṣákha, or nine clean castes. They are closely allied to Ṣúdra Káyasths, with whom they eat

[1] Báori, Bawari, Bhourie, are the names of a migratory tribe found throughout India, probably the same as the Barbara, or Varvara of Sanskrit works. In central India they are also known as Haran Shikárí and Harandardí, "J. A. S. B." of Bengal, xiii, 5.

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and drink. The ordinary name among the lower classes for a cultivator of pân is 'Lata-baidyá, a "doctor of creepers."

In Bengal there are 156,807 persons belonging to the Baraí caste, fifty three per cent. of whom are distributed in the eastern districts as follows:—Dacca 15,931, Silhet 15,036, Báqirganj 14,453, Tipperah 8,982, Chittagong 12,448, Mymensingh 6,435, Farrídpúr 6,120, Noakhally 3,485, and Cachar 692.

The "Padavís," or titles, of the caste are very numerous, and their gotras are uncertain. The following list was furnished by the caste Bráhman:—

Padaví.	Gotra.
Dutta	Vishnumásí, Aliman.
Sen	Kaṣyapa.
Mitra	Karnamásí.
Bawál	Ṣáṇḍilya.
Khor	Aliman, Gotromásí.
Dás	Kaṣyapa, Aliman.
Pál	Aliman, Vishnumásí.
Nandí	Jaintimásí, Madhu Kuliya.
Mantianí	Vishnumásí.
Chand	Chandramásí.
Ásh.	
Kundú.	
Náha.	
Rukhít.	
Deo.	

The most common honorary titles are Chaudharí, Biṣwas, and Majumdár. Their Bráhman and servants are the same as those of the Káyasths. Towards Mymensingh, beyond the limits of the Ballálí country, the poorer members are found cultivating the soil, an occupation abhorrent to the Bikrampúr Baraí.

Along the banks of the Lakhya the Baraís celebrate, without a Bráhman, the "Nauamí" Újah in honour of Ushas, a Vedic goddess, identical with the Eôs of Grecian mythology, on the ninth of the waxing moon in Asín (September-October). Plantains, sugar, rice, and sweetmeats are placed in the centre of the pân-garden, from which the worshippers retire, but after a little return, and carrying out the offerings distribute them among the village children. In Bikrampúr the deity invoked on the above date is Sungáí, one of the many forms of Bhágavatí. The reason given by the Baraís for not engaging the services of a Bráhman is the following: A Bráhman was the first cultivator of the Pân (Piper betle).[1] Through neglect, the plant grew so

[1] Pán is the Sanskrit parṇa, a leaf; while betle is a corruption of Viṭi, or Viṭika, the betle plant.

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